

Winter Dungeonland

FREEHAVEN ONLINE



A LitRPG Adventure

JUN PRINCE

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Introduction

Hi. I'm Justine.

I know what you're thinking. "Are you talking to me?" You don't have to get all DeNiro on me. It's the holidays which means it's a great time to show a little forgiveness for me becoming aware I'm in a novel for the next few pages. I promise, everything will go back to normal at the end of this section.

You see, I understand that it's almost Christmas, and a lot of people are gonna pick this bad boy up because there's holiday lights on the cover, only to think "Oh no! It's book 3 in a series!"

I've got you covered. Here's what you need to know to get up to speed. I'm, or at least I was, an intuitive programmer with VWI, Virtual World Innovations, which means I created monsters and in-

game objects for Freehaven Online which we're all stuck in.

Shortly after the last patch, the logout button was disabled by a hacker organization called Archangel, which means that everyone who's still online is on life support somewhere completely unaware of what's happening to their bodies. Since then, NPCs have started acting a whole lot more human.

We were warned that special quests to re-enable the logout "Feature" (Since when has logging out been a game feature, right?) would be hidden within the Freehaven universe, only no one to my knowledge had found one until last month. Then a draconic mummy dropped a child's doll in Hades starting a quest that can only be completed in December. Find the owner in the North Pole.

The reward for completing the chain: A choice between evolving legendary items, and having the log out button re-enabled.

Frobod of course is ecstatic. He's our death knight, and has been wanting to get back to his daughter since he missed her birthday party on the night of the update. The rest of the Toxic Muffins (I'm a guild master by the way, and that's the name of our guild) are give or take. More than half our members are

incapacitated in real life, meaning they can't take care of themselves. My in-game kid sister, Mirae, was a quadriplegic in Meatsville before she digitized, sacrificing her real world life to live digitally in Freehaven Online forever. Suffice to say, being stuck in game permanently has made some people happier than they've been in a very long time.

By the way, in-game food sucks, unless it's prepared by our chef, Pehrom whose discovered how to make dishes taste like they do offline. For everything else, you get a whole lot of texture, and zero flavor. I blame the DataBite corporation, for not licensing the technology, but Archangel seems to have worked some of that magic in with the update. It's a shame it's not automatically applied to existing recipes.

... but none of that is what this story is about.

This book is about saving Santa, Great Uncle Winter in-game, and finding out how many people's holiday wishes of being with their families we can make come true.

Freehaven Online is a virtual world where the computer rolls a bunch of ten sided dice to determine the outcome of character actions. The basic system is that every time you try to take a difficult or combative action, the system rolls a number of dice equal to your rating in an appropriate attribute, plus your rating in an appropriate skill or ability.

Attributes:

Physical:

Strength, Dexterity, Stamina,

Social:

Charisma, Manipulation, Appearance

Mental:

Intelligence, Perception, Wits

The more dice that turn up over 6, the greater your caliber of success. If you roll a 1, the system takes away 1 from your caliber of success. You re-roll tens for a chance for even greater success, and if you roll more 1s than your total caliber of success (thus taking your result into the negative), it's a critical failure, and

something bad happens the severity of which is
determined by how far into the negative you've rolled.



Chapter 1 - I'm Not Coming

THUNK!

It's Thanksgiving morning and Pehrom, our bat eared, green skinned, foul mouthed chef, brings his cleaver down on a haunch of meat.

He says, "I told ya, I'm not comin'!"

His wife, Lilly, also a goblin in-game, pretty, black haired, and pouty lipped says "This is our chance to get back to the real world together." They both speak with heavy New Jersey-Boston accents. It's like they were raised in one place, and were transplanted to the other ten years ago.

"I don't want to go back!" Pehrom roars. "I'm happy here. You don't see that? Look at me. I'm cookin'. I ain't cooked in years back home. This is home to me."

"So, what?" Lilly says, "You just gonna give up on our lives together?"

"Look, honey." Pehrom says, "When the devs fix the button I'll log out like everyone else, but this? The quest. It's special. They gotta use it on someone who's got somethin' to go back to."

"So, what? I ain't nothin' to go back to?"

"You are, you are! Babe, you're here with me now. Give it to someone who ain't seen their ma for two months."

Tako, our boyish half-elf rogue with a stylishly messy black k-pop style hair do, dips out of the walk in-freezer, a closet permanently frozen with ice magic, sucking on an apple juice popsicle.

Pehrom motions, "Like this guy over here. Bet his fuckin' parents er' worried sick. We ain't got kids. Give it to someone with folks back home who are worryin'."

"What about my family? Huh? You think ma ain't worried?"

Pehrom says, "I thought you took care of shit before you went in."

Lilly shrieks, "I made sure someone would find me!" Then in a calmer voice says, "I couldn't tell ma what I was gonna do. She'd have called the hospital on

me, sayin' I was gonna commit suicide. I'm in here cause of you."

"So you regrettin' on me? I didn't make you do it."

Lilly says, "I ain't regrettin' nothing. I'd do it every day of my life to be with you, but Rob," That's Pehrom's real world name, "I miss my family... and my friends. Not everyone plays this game."

"I'm your fuckin' family!"

Lilly says, "Hey, man. Chill the fuck out. I ain't sayin' you aren't, but I got other family. We got a way. Why can't I have you and them too?"

"Then you do the fuckin' quest then."

I wanna do it together."

Pehrom says, "I'm not coming!" I clear my throat uncomfortably, Pehrom looks up catching the look on my face, I'm pretty sure he hadn't seen me lurking. He says, "How you doin'?" and gives me an upward nod.

I say, "Great, but..." I look to Lilly, "That might work."

"What?" Lilly says.

"You doing the quest on your own, or rather without Pehrom."

Lilly says, "What's the point if I can't take this guy back with me?"

"You can come back and see him."

At this, Tako perks up giving me his full attention, "You think? What if we get stuck again?"

Lilly says, "Yeah. What if we get stuck?"

"The quest reward says that the logout feature will be re-enabled. It doesn't say anything about it being a one time thing." I look to Lily, "If it's to be believed, you could log out, see your family, and come back here to spend time with your man before logging out again."

Tako says, "... and I can see Mirae."

Lilly says, "You got this on inside information?"

I shake my head no, "VWI didn't break the logout button. This reward... It's all Archangel. I'm not saying I like them but..." I trail. "Everything they've said so far has been true. It sucks that we're all stuck in here, but so far as I can tell they haven't lied."

Lilly huffs, "Hell of a risk."

I say, "What's the worse case scenario? Worst case. You log out. Have dinner with your family. Let them know you're alright. Come back here. and you can't log out again. Sounds like you'll be exactly where you started plus a holiday spent with the rest of your family, but I don't think that's gonna happen."

Lilly grumbles. "I'll think on it."

Pehrom says, "Finally, someone around here's talkin' sense!"

I shrug. "I do what I can."

Tako says, "Who do you want to bring on the quest with us?"

"Frobod's a given. The man's been single minded ever since..." I think, "Since... Hell he's talked about nothing else since the hidden quest announcement."

Tako says, "I'm good with him. What about Sajina?"

"I think he's going with Leroy and the Malefactors."

Lilly says, "Traitor."

I wave my hand dismissively, "It's fine. He and Leroy bonded. It's not like everyone in our guild is itching to go home.... At least not compared to most guilds."

Lilly says, "Yeah well... Legendary loot. Some of the Muffins aren't getting it because..."

"It's fine." I reiterate, then to Tako, "If you want to come there's a spot waiting for you. You could make your own party since you've got a dolly, but if you want to go with me you're welcome."

Tako asks, "Will you bring Scooti?"

"I don't think so."

"Fine..." He says, "I'll still go, but... You think Mirae can come too? She won't be taking the logout but she really wants the chance at a legendary item. She's just too nice to say it."

"Of course. It's like Lilly said, some of the muffins are gonna want loot. You, me, Frobod, Mirae... that leaves one person." I look to Lilly, "Do you want the last spot or..." I trail "I'm sure Pahrem will come if you're not into it."

Lilly says, "Let me think on it. If this guild's running multiple groups, we should save our healers. How many teams can we form?"

"Six dollies." I say, "Two went to the Malefactors, that means that the Muffins have control of four of them."

"Four groups of five." Lilly says, "That means the others are gonna be light on heals, so she should go with another party."

Can't argue with that logic. "So are you in?"

"Let me think on it. I'll let you know tonight."

I look to Pehrom who's sticking a roast in the oven, "What time's dinner?"

"We always did Thanksgiving early back home. I'm gonna say four o'clock."

I look to Tako, "Gives us time for Turkeyshoot, you want to go?"

He nods. "Laurelade's already down there."

"She would be..." I say, thinking of the little gnome's destructive spells. "I'll bet she rakes in all kinds of seasonal rewards." I look to Pehrom, "Four o'clock then."

The chef says, "If you see Pahrem, or either of my no-good apprentices tell them to get their asses in here and help me make dessert. These pies aren't gonna bake themselves. This is major income for the guild, fuckers are sellin' for five gold a piece."

"It's still morning." I say.

"Fuck mornings." the goblin says, "If they're asleep they need to get their asses out of bed."



Chapter 2 - Turkeyshoot

Tako and I are half way across the drawbridge when quick footsteps scuttle behind us.

"Hey guys!" That's Pahrem, Pehrom's in-game sister. Like most goblins she speaks with that Boston-Jersey accent, a player has to manually change the voice filter if they want to sound different.

I look over my shoulder, and discover our priest fully geared in her Mantle of the Undying Chronomancer, and Low Hades Garb of the Healer; both items she obtained on our recent trip to the underworld. The shoulder armor looks like a pair of golden dragon skulls with antelope antlers protecting her shoulders, whereas the garb of the healer looks like a knitted real world cardigan with a fantasy cloak style hood. When and if she chooses to raise it, as she is

doing now, her big ears stick out to either side, and her face is replaced with a ball of hot white energy with little black dots for eyes.

"You look like you're ready for battle."

"Hell yeah I am!" She lowers her hood so we can see her normal face. "A little bird named Alfred said you're going to Turkeyshoot, and I wanna come."

"More the merrier." I invite her to our party.

Pahrem has joined your group.

I give her a smile. "Still trying to get your turkey costume?" There are a number of quirky seasonal items you can only get by completing holiday events.

"That, and I've got a title to score! Just gotta ace one more challenge."

Tako says, "If we pick up another, we can try to five man it, otherwise we'll be doing solos and threes."

I catch the questioning look on the goblin's face. "Laurelade's already down there. Let's go have a look." I wave my middle finger in the air and shout, "INFERNO!!!" pump my fist, and then say "Let's ride."

Magical, elemental powered motorcycles burst into existence in pulses of red, yellow, blue, green and grey, corresponding to their elements. Tako straddles

the wind bike, and Pahrem takes the blue one as I mime pressing a button on a key chain while saying, "Bloop bloop! ... Bloop bloop!" to dismiss the extra mounts.

Pahrem says, "I already did fives last year. I need the three person challenge."

I'm sitting on Big Red, the fire elechopper, as I lift off the ground like a Harry Potter wizard. The November air is brisk but not uncomfortable. It rarely is in Freehaven, but the weather shifts enough to give players the feeling of changing seasons, but it's never extreme unless there's a world event connected to it.

We're heading to a farm near Durolan. There's one nestled outside just about every major city for these types of events.

Using party chat so I don't have to shout over the wind, I ask, "Do they do this in Canada?"

Tako says, "I don't know, why? I've never been to Canada."

I say, "When I lived in Korea they didn't have Turkeyshoot, but they had other events that mirrored Korean holidays. I was wondering if this is for all of North America, or only the USA since Thanksgiving in November is a US holiday."

Pahrem says, "They don't have Thanksgiving in Canada?"

"They do, but I think it's in October."

Tako says, "October must be a busy month for them between Thanksgiving and Halloween."

"I'll bet they overlap a bit." Even if real world holidays last only a day, the holidays in Freehaven tend to last one or two weeks to ensure everyone has a chance to enjoy them. "There it is."

I point to a fenced in area below featuring a few dozen adventurers and flashes of multicolored magic that explode within the enclosure. Settling to the ground on the spectator side of the fence, adventurers and Havenfolk erupt in cheers of excited "Yay!" and disappointed "Ohh.." I wouldn't be surprised to find a NPC bookie among them, though as a general rule only adventurers participate in the contests unless no players have queued.

I spot Laurelade, a little gnome with purple hair, wizard robes, and a hood on her back that glows like bioluminescence. I greet her with a cheerful, "Hey!"

She responds in her typical bored voice, "Took you long enough." I'm beginning to think there's no such thing as a cheerful Laurelade.

"How're you doing so far."

"Turkeycide." She says, with a sigh. "I swear, I'm that close to Turkeygeddon." She measures between her thumb and pointer.

"Is that solo or..."

"I haven't had a team for the other contests."

Pahrem says, "We're here."

"Turkeycide is respectable."

"Yeah, but I want to beat it this year." Laurelade looks to the goblin and says, "Are you on heals?"

"I got your heals and a crap ton of g'nades!"

"I like her." Then eyes Tako, "What do you have for AoE?"

Tako, having been caught flat footed says, "I... ah...errrr."

"Fat wad of nothing then." Laurelade points to me, herself and Pahrem in succession, "We can do threes then. You tank them, I'll burn em down with AoE, goblin can heal and add to area of effect damage."

I look to Tako and say, "Sorry..." in a sheepish voice, knowing that she has a point. I wouldn't have put it so bluntly, but AoE damage is way more effective for this event. "We can group up later."

Tako says, "Oh I see how it is. You're racist against half elves."

I clear my throat and rub the tip of my right, half-elven ear.

"Go, have fun. I'm just fucking with ya. I'll wait for Mirae and we can have our own party."

"Good," Laurelade abruptly turns, and walks away from the rest of us. She approaches a man, another gnome, with a far cheerier disposition. He's wearing a straw hat, brown suspenders, and rugged hide leggings. Laurelade motions to me and Pahrem as we trail after her. "Group of three. This time."

Speaking in a whimsical voice, farmer gnome says, "Do you have the tickets?"

Laurelade forks over three sturdy pieces of burnt orange paper. "You can pay me back later."

To participate in holiday competitions, you have to buy tickets from the festival vendor, much the same as you might have to buy tickets for rides at a Meatsville carnival. I reach into inventory and pull out a red one from a past year's Christmas event. "I have some now." Although the color changes based on when you buy them, you can use festivity tickets on any holiday.

A booming voice sounds, "Next up, a team of three. Lord Laurelade, Lord Melpomine, and Lord Pahrem of Durolan's Toxic Muffins!"

"That was fast."

Laurelade says, "Durolan's good for that. Outside Athelon you'll have to wait ten or twenty minutes when it's busy."

"C'mon!" Pahrem tugs at my pant leg leading me toward the enclosure.

Laurelade says, "Buff up."

I take the cue and wipe my hands together, a macro I set to cast the Enhanced Dexterity and Enhance Vitality abilities. A whistling wind sounds around me followed by the THUMP-BUMP THUMP-BUMP of a human heartbeat.

Enhanced Dexterity.

Dexterity increased by 10%.

Duration: 60 minutes remaining.

Enhanced Vitality.

Regeneration Increased by 10%.

Duration: 60 minutes remaining.

I cast Flow Like Water in a smooth martial arts kata where I twirl my staff around me in an evasive stance.

Flow Like Water (Rank 2)**Cost:** 2000 Manna**Effect:**

Your body takes on the fluid qualities of water causing it to flow out of the path of incoming attacks. Lasts 30 minutes, or until the loss of 10 levels of health have been negated. Negates physical damage only.

The brisk forces of Yin energy seep into my flesh like cool water. An additional buff appears in the top left hand corner of my vision.

Flow Like Water (10)**Duration: 30 minutes remaining.**

A red-orange and yellow utility crate that's taller than I am awaits us in the arena. It glows with orange light and quivers with fettered jack in the box energy. Taking our places before the box, the announcer calls, "Ready?" Though I still haven't spotted him.

Laurelade says, "Ready."

A countdown superimposes itself on my vision.

3...

2...

1...

Instead of the usual duel text that says "Begin!" the numbers are punctuated by a thunderous gobble. The cube shakes and rattles against the dirt. Suddenly a black streak shoots in the sky from it's top like an Independence Day firework. There's another, and another. The blasts hit the ground in a display of flying feathers. Laurelade launches a fireball at one.

CRITICAL HIT!

Laurelade casts Cinderburst.

Laurelade hits Turkeyshoot Turkey for 14 damage.

It explodes in a shower of dark feathers. A streamer of black smoke twirls in the air, before the avian corpse vanishes leaving scorch marks in the dirt. Pahrem's hands glow as she casts smite on one of the two remaining birds, with much the same result.

I see the third one, and ready to throw my Darksteel Chakram. It suddenly reaches behind it's back with wings that act like human arms, places a rubber duck bill on its beak and says "Quack Quack!"

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My chakram streaks toward it and separates the bird's head from it's body. The head makes a final, "Quaaaaaaack" before it hits the ground, and dissipates in the way of defeated game monsters.

Round One Complete - Turkey Shoot.

Round Two in 3...

2...

1...

The crate hops and wobbles, an explosion of seven turkey rockets soar in a high arc from the top of the cube in streamers of autumn colored magic. The new birds are just barely getting to their feet when the scent of ozone fills the air. Clouds gather overhead. KA-CRACK! KA-BLAM BLAM BOOOM! Spears of lightning strike the new birds dead where they stand. Their smoking bodies remind me of incense before they despawn.

Round Two Complete - Gobble Gobble Uggghhh

Round Three in 3....

2...

1....

The crate jitters and jumps. Orange and brown missiles of bird blast from its roof sending avian opponents high overhead. Each time there are more. Last time seven, this time at least sixteen fall to the earth around us. The bird nearest me gobbles, then unleashes a dinosaur belch sending a gout of flame at my body. I'm just out of reach. *Fire breathing turkeys. Who comes up with this?*

Laurelade's fast on casting, as shards of ice fall from above like panes of glass... CRASH!! SHATTER! CRASH!!! Magical frozen guillotines create a massacre of Thanksgiving death. Bits of ice tumble in the dirt.

One turkey hobbles, twitching a broken wing, my darksteel chakram beheads it.

**Round Three Complete - Gobble Gobble BOOM,
Gobble BOOM BOOM**

Round Four in 3...

I'd forgotten about the prospect of elemental damage during Turkeyshoot, so before the next round begins, I close my eyes, bow my head, and enable one of the special abilities Leroy taught me before entering Hades.

Shield of Harmony, Aura of Emptiness (Rank One)**Cost:** N/A**Target:** Self Only**Duration:** 1 Hour**Requirements:**

Martial Arts: 5, Stamina: 12, Endurance: 7

Your soul has evolved to a perfect state of harmony with the universe, which allows you to shrug off the effects of magical and elemental attacks that would leave lesser warriors crippled. You are surrounded by a shield of emptiness that protects your harmony and prevents hostile forces from breaking through.

Effect:

While Aura of Emptiness is active, incoming magical and elemental damage has a 7% chance to be nullified before rolling to resist damage.

There's no manna cost since it's a special ability rather than a spell, activating it is a near instant effect.

2...**1...**

"I'll nuke again this time, next wave tank round em up, goblin heal and use bombs."

Pahrem laughs and shouts, "They're g'nades!"

Laurelade says, "Whatever."

There are so many magic turkey projectiles that I can't begin to count. Laurelade's waving her hands in a furious blur as pale, cold energy springs up around her. As soon as our opponents touch down, she unleashes her magic causing their feathers to frost over, and blocks of ice to harden over their feet. They gobble in defiance. A nearby bird rears it's head back, and coughs a cloud of acid.

Turkeyshoot Slimecougher hits you for 8 points of damage.

You resist 8 points of damage.

"Ugh!" I say, as it splashes over my chest. It sizzles. itches and tingles on my skin. I hurl my chakram and am surprised to see that it doesn't kill the bird in one hit.

Laurelade says, "Incoming!" as she rains more ice down on the animals. Many gobble and die where they stand unable to move after her first spell.

The ice around their feet shatters, they charge directly at her. I rush to intercept, but Laurelade beats me to it, waving her arms, calling fiery hunks of rock down on our opponents. They all die, leaving nothing but large burned craters in the earth.

Round Four Complete - Fried Turkey? I'll bathe you in your children.

Round Five in 3...

2...

1...

The box shakes more violently than before, now hopping a good two feet in the air before launching Thanksgiving fireworks. Some big, some small. One of the big ones touches down a few feet away from me. It's a turkey mount as tall as I am, ridden by a smaller turkey with a great steel lance, and an armored helm.

"Gobble gobble gobble!" It lowers the steel tip and charges.

I dodge out of the way, a little counter in the top right hand corner of my vision moves up to one. Each dodge adds a charge, and after a few more dodges, my boots will begin sending blasts of electricity into opponents that attack me.

As the turkey knight passes, I tag the mount's rear flank with Bite, my electrified staff, an arc of electricity jumps from it's tip into the mount, then the rider, and all the smaller turkeys within a five foot radius, taunting them in the process.

"Stack on me!" I begin casting my new Paladin spell, "Lord Sune, God of Lightning, God of Travel, hear my call and consecrate this land."

Circle of Blessings (Rank Two)**Cost:** 700 mana**Target:** N/A**Duration:** 10 Minutes**Requirements:**

Clergy Member

You bless the ground beneath your feet in your deity's name. Hostile characters feel uncomfortable and receive holy, or unholy damage depending on your deity. Elemental damage may also be applied if your god or goddess is associated with a particular element.

Effect:

While Circle of Blessings is active, hostile characters within a ten foot radius must resist two points of holy damage every 8 seconds

Clergy of Sune Modifier:

Holy damage has a 30% chance to convert to lightning damage.

Pahrem lobs a g'nade that explodes against the beak of another turkey mount, and splashes caustic

lemon yellow goop over the birds around it. Turkeys scream and the goblin runs at me. Laurelade's chugging manna potions as she scuttles to my side.

Weeds of white and electric blue energy sprout from the ground around me. They reach toward our opponents like magic fingers sizzling and zapping them where they stand.

Most small turkeys die after only two ticks of the area effect blessing. The rest go down as I smash one of the three turkey mounts with Bite causing electricity to jump from my weapon, into my primary target, and then to all the lesser birds in the area. Pahrem chuck's another g'nade at the turkey knight I just hit. It explodes in a puff of yellow fire.

Two big birds remaining. Laurelade's still drinking. I take the offensive and charge the closest turkey mount on foot. Rather than initiating an attack, I leap high into the air, using the mount's body as a spring board, knocking the smaller turkey rider to the ground, and landing behind it. It's only then that I smash Bite in a wide violent sweep against the mount's leg, pivot and crash the armored rider in the face.

The rider dies and disappears.

The other turkey mount is going for Pahrem. I shout, "Hey!" and crunch the end of my staff into the earth.

Taunt. Successful.

Turkeyshoot Knight attacks.

Before it has a chance to injure Pahrem, it changes course and barrels toward me, lance leveled and ready to impale. I'm a bull fighter dancing out of the way. My dodge counter rises by one.

Pahrem unleashes another smite at my attacker, a jolt of hot holy energy stabs into the turkey mount from heaven. The other giant turkey comes in for a frantic peck with its face looking like a shriveled brain, it connects, but passes through me as my flesh reshapes around the blow. Two points drop off of my Flow Like Water defense. I crack the one that tried to peck me in the side of the head and it falls to the ground, despawning.

One turkey knight to go. After the last unsuccessful attack, it loops around the arena to build up speed for another charge. Here it comes. Pahrem smites. The rider flies off its back, and disappears into

the digital place of NPC death like a ghost. There's just the mount to deal with, I hurl my chakram.

Round Five Complete: No pardon!

Round Six in 3...

2...

1...

The next few rounds pass in much the same manner, each introducing more difficult turkey themed opponents for us to conquer, but it's not until wave nine that I feel that we might actually lose.

I'm surrounded by five angry birds a good head taller than I am, and three times as wide. My Flow Like Water defense has long since eroded which means I'm open to losing real health from physical attacks. The one to my right gobbles then coughs up a fountain of caustic green liquid.

Turkeyshoot Slimecougher (Elite) hits you for 14 damage.

You resist 13 points of damage.

"Laurelade! Freeze!" I'm hoping she has a spell ready that'll allow me time to put up some new

defenses. No vocal response from the gnome, but the air grows colder. A crack like breaking ice sounds as my opponents are locked in place, encased in vertical frozen coffins. A countdown timer above their heads tells me that I only have four seconds until they break free.

With the birds frozen I move through the casting of another Martial Arts spell. Unlike the fluid motions of Flow Like Water, these movements are rigid and harsh, much like the element they embody.

Move Like Ice (Rank Three)**Cost:** 500 Manna

Dexterity + Martial Arts

Duration: 20 seconds

By channeling the cold forces of Yin energy, and directing them at your opponent you may cause them to slow, or even freeze them in their tracks.

Effect:

Target movement speed decreased by 50%. 20% chance to freeze them in place. 10% chance to impose -4 dexterity penalty.

Targeting the fire breathing turkey on my right, I feel a wave of ice push through me and into the monster. Next to the frozen debuff above it's head, a new status indicator appears telling me that it can't move for twenty seconds. I've gotta move because unlike Laurelade's four second spell, Move Like Ice still allows opponents to attack while they are locked in place.

I make a flying acrobatic leap that I couldn't dream of in the real world. I somersault mid air, and land behind my frozen opponents. The gnome's spell expires, causing the frozen prisons to crumble around the birds. I spin my staff and smack the acid spitting turkey in the butt. Electricity hops from Bite into my target and then creeps over the other birds like an electric spider, taunting each along the way.

I yell, "Kiting!" and bolt the opposite direction. All but the fire breather that can't move for twenty seconds turn to follow.

At the exact same time, three turkeys fill their enormous lungs, and spew their breath weapons at me.

Turkeyshoot Slimecougher (Elite) hits you for 14 damage.

You resist 14 points of damage.

Turkeyshoot Darkspitter (Elite) hits you for 16 points of damage.

You resist 12 points of damage.

Turkeyshoot Frostbreather (Elite) hits you for 13 points of damage.

Damage negated by Shield of Harmony, Aura of Emptiness (Rank One).

"Ugh!"

The dark damage stings, I'm now down to near fifty percent health. A bubble of golden magic surrounds me, as Pahrem heals my wounds. My health rises as I run around the back of the giant cube with four turkeys in tow.

Laurelade holds her hands in front of her body pressing her thumbs and pointers together so they make a shape like a spade, and shouts, "Solaris incendiuss!"

A bar of hot white fire erupts from the space between her thumbs and index fingers incinerating the

Darkspitter and Slimecougher. They gobble, smoke, die, and disappear.

My health's back up to full. Three birds remaining, a fire breather, an ice spitter, and a turkey with a chrome head that has no breath weapon. Pahrem casts another Smite which drops the frost turkey down to 30% health.

"Heading back to fire! AoE once I connect!"

Coming back around the cube the fire turkey I hit with Move Like Ice follows my body with its little black eyes. It exhales a cone of fervent hot flame, though I'm way out of range, but the heat nevertheless touches my face. As soon as the blaze fades I rush the bird with Bite at my side. Angry squawks and gobbles, and turkey feet in the dirt sound behind me as I move to engage. *They're still following.*

Move Like Ice fades. The brown and red fire breather dashes at me. Bite slams into the side of its head in a disgusting wet CRACK! No electricity bounds behind me, so the birds in pursuit must still be more than five feet away. The one I just hit flaps it's wings stirring the air and rises a few feet off the ground. A blanket conflagration rolls over me, causing my skin to grow pink and sensitive like an ugly sunburn.

Turkeyshoot Gobbleflame (Elite) hits you for 12 points of damage.

You resist 12 points of damage.

The sensation disappears within a second. I spin Bite, and thrust the staff into the turkey's core mass. This time I'm rewarded with an arc of electricity that leaps back over my head, and into the chrome and ice enemies.

WHAM!

Knockback!

Turkeyshoot Battle Rammer (Elite) hits you for 16 points of damage.

You resist 13 points of damage.

It's the first time I've been hit by the metal bird. A solid thump to my back, knocks the breath out of me. Suddenly I'm flying, waving my arms wildly with nothing to hold on to. There's no ground beneath my feet. It's a full two seconds before I reconnect with the earth.

Tumble**Dexterity + Athletics****Caliber of Success: 7**

I break the fall with the palms of my hands which turns into a roll that brings me back to my feet. I'm a good fifteen feet away from our enemies, and I'm lucky to have landed that last blow, because the ice and chrome birds were just taunted by my staff's passive ability. Now their giving chase. I'm a little worried that Laurelade will get agro if she attacks, so I turn back to the group, spin Bite, and smash it into the dirt to taunt the fire breather.

Taunt. Successful.**Turkeyshoot Gobbleflame (Elite) attacks.**

All three birds are coming at me. I should, "Now!"

Laurelade waves her arms, speaking words that I can't make out from this distance, calling down another ice storm on our opponents, slowing their movement. I launch my darksteel chakram at metal head since it has the most health. It whizzes through the air like a flying saucer, and buries itself into the Battle Rammer's

breast. If we're lucky, Laurelade will pull off a few more AoEs and kill them all at once. Seconds later, the chakram reforms around my wrist.

Metal Head: 60%

Ice Blaster: 20%

Fire Breather: 40%

"Burn em' down!" I hurl my chakram again at the metal headed turkey. The sky above us turns red, and meteors fall upon the group as Laurelade casts a fire spell.

SKA-SQUAK!

The ice turkey falls making a vocalization that sounds more like a chicken than Thanksgiving dinner. Sparks fly as my chakram connects with the chrome bird's forehead. It leaves an ugly dent, but doesn't quite kill it.

Metal: 20%

Fire: 10%

Pahrem's hands glow with white-gold light. A bolt of holy energy pierces the last turkey from overhead, brightening the arena for a split second. The heavenly fire peeks out the fire bird's eyes and beak like a plasma jack-o-lantern as it takes its last breath.

I call, "Good job Pahrem!" but she doesn't respond. Laurelade hits the one remaining turkey with

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a Cinderburst, that sends flurries of ash that that pulse like red fireflies into the air.

Round Nine Complete: Turkeycide!

Pahrem and Laurelade both chug flasks of manna restoring water. They aren't as fast as a manna potion, but they get the job done if you have a few seconds to spare.

Round Ten in 3...

2...

1...

Laurelade pinches her forehead like she's got a brain freeze. "Last stage."

Pahrem echoes, "TURKEYGEDDON!"

The big crate at the center of the enclosure jumps high, no more wobbles, this time it goes well over our heads. It lands with a resonating BOOM that shakes the ground like a t-rex footstep. Sparks shower from above, and countless turkey rockets fall from above.

"Lord Sune, God of Lightning, God of Travel, hear my call and consecrate this land."

Cast Circle of Blessings (Rank Two). Success!

The ground beneath me takes on a blue tint, and streamers of holy white energy reach up to the sky like lambent tendrils of sea weed. They occasionally crackle with Sune's lightning power, and the air smells fresher.

"I'll round em' up while you drink. Stay in the circle unless there's AoE."

As expected the smallest of the fireworks touch the ground, and begin to reshape into real-world-sized turkeys. They flap their wings and move their tiny legs to engage. As soon as they take damage from the Circle of Blessings all turkey attention is on me. I move to the edge of the circle, so our attackers are no longer facing Pahrem and Laurelade who are seated close to the center.

There's so many of them. Turkey turkey turkey turkey turkey. Brown ones, black ones, white, and some with patches of color in between. All of them life size, with their shriveled raisin heads and little coal eyes.

They flap their wings, rise off the ground and peck me with sharp beaks. I counterattack, hitting a brown one in the breast, and electricity jumps from my

staff to the swarm around me. I'm getting pummeled by beaks, talons and feathers, but my stamina and endurance are high enough that I'm not taking much damage, so I absorb the hits, and occasionally strike to keep them busy while the casters top up on manna.

It's a slow AoE bleed as the flock takes occasional damage from the radius effect of my weapon, paired with the Circle of Blessings ground effect. I could carry on like this for hours. Most of the birds are at ten to thirty percent health when I dip out of the way of a white turkey, and smooch it with the end of my staff. It dies in pain, and I hear the death cries of other birds as lightning jumps from my staff to it's neighbors and the Circle of Blessings damage devours their health.

BOOM.

The ground shakes.

BOOM.

It's a terrible drum that resonates through the earth.

One flare.. two flares... three four five large flares launch from the top of the turkey spewing crate. When they hit the ground they take the form of colossal eggs the size of stallions —Black, Red, Blue, White, and Green.

Boom. Boom. Boom.

The crate shakes, splinters and cracks.

A bone shaking, "GOOOORRRROOAAARBBLE" sounds as the turkey box disintegrates in an explosion of dark feathers. A giant turkey foot appears out of nowhere and crushes the ground before me sending most of the remaining smaller turkeys to their deaths. It knocks me to my butt as it takes another step. Looking up from my vantage point, I see Turkakodzilla, a massive multi-energy breathing bird the size of my apartment building.

I stumble to my feet, hit one of its toes with Bite to grab it's attention, and run away. Hoping it'll follow.

Pahrem's hands are glowing as she readies a smite, but to my surprise it hits the black egg rather than the boss, as soon as it hits, Turkakodzilla turns to face her.

Laurelade casts Cinderburst on the same egg. The boss whirls and takes a step toward her. "Taunt! Keep taunting!"

I whistle, loud to draw the giant bird's attention.

Taunt. Successful.

Turkakodzilla attacks.

Pahrem shouts, "We gotta break the eggs fast. Every time someone hits one, it taunts the boss."

It doesn't take a genius to guess what happens if we don't break the eggs in time—ugly, ugly bird monsters. I take my Darksteel Chakram in hand. "Pahrem on 1 smite, Laurelade on 2... Do what you do. I'll hit something, and then start the count over."

Pahrem switches to party chat. "Huh?"

I use party chat to give orders, "One! Smite! Now!" I don't want her to use g'nades because of the delay before they go off. The goblin hesitates, and I shout, "Smite!"

I run as far as I can from the goblin and gnome, with the giant turkey thunder stomping behind me. Pahrem's hands glow, and send a bolt of holy energy, into the dark egg. Turkzilla stops, and turns to run after her.

"Two! Laurelade, go!"

The gnome's faster on the uptake, and calls down a blizzard that damages all five eggs at once. Turkakodzilla changes course and runs at her, breathing deep and unleashing a blast of fire in her direction. I expect her health to evaporate, but she disappears just in time, and reappears ten feet to her

right in a flash of yellow and blue. *A teleport? I didn't know she could do that.*

I hurl my chakram at the black egg.

CRITICAL HIT.

You hit Turkakodzilla Egg for 13 points of damage.

A great hole appears in its side, and yellow yolk gushes onto the ground.

"One down, spread out!"

Turkakodzilla's chasing me again, in my ranged position. After a good four or five booming steps I shout, "ONE! Pahrem! Go!"

I can't see what she's doing because the boss's massive body is in the way, but I know she hit, because it turns, and nearly knocks me to the ground again with its tail feathers. "TWO! Laurel! Go!"

The sky grows red, and another fiery AOE crashes into the eggs, collectively reducing their health. As soon as I can see around Turkakodzilla's body, I throw the Chakram again. It connects with the blue egg, but unfortunately, it doesn't break.

The boss gobble-roars, "GROOOOOARRBBBBLLLE-ABBBLE-ABBLLE!" and charges at me. It lowers its head like a battering ram.

Fuck! If the horse size metal head turkey sent me flying, I don't even want to think how far I'll go if this thing connects.

Shadow Step (Rank 5) - Success!

In the nick of time, I charge into the turkey's shadow, and reappear directly behind it, bypassing the headbutt entirely.

"ONE! Go!"

Pahrem smites. The boss whirls and tramples me in it's best effort to get to our healer. Not only am I in the dirt, but a hard kick from a larger than elechopper sized turkey foot knocks the wind out of me, and I lose twenty percent of my health.

Before I can say two, the sky darkens, and Laurelade's calling down a lightning spell. The blue egg explodes when it's zapped sending a yolk everywhere. *Three more.*

Pahrem's knobby hand's glow. *Don't attack! What is she doing?* My health begins to rise. *Right, idiot, she's our healer.* Turkakodzilla takes a deep breath, and breathes cold all over the gnome. Her torso's locked in a block of ice, immobilizing her, and she's down a whopping sixty percent of her health.

My chakram's reformed in my hand, but from the ground I'm not able to get a good throw to taunt by damaging an egg. Instead I whistle again, and shout, "Winner, winner, turkey dinner!"

Taunt. Successful.

Turkakodzilla attacks.

I scramble to my feet as the gigantic creature turns, and rushes at me.

Using party chat, Laurelade says, "Gotta move faster, or they'll hatch!"

"ONE! Go!" Pahrem smites, as soon as Turkakodzilla turns, I shout, "TWO! Go!"

Laurelade calls down another ice storm. I hurl my chakram, and break the red egg. Turkakodzilla heaves a deep breath, I brace for impact, suddenly I'm covered in acid, and all I see is bile scented green.

Turkakodzilla hits you for 16 points of damage.

Damage negated by Shield of Harmony, Aura of Emptiness (Rank One).

Yeah! I'd forgotten about that ability. While it's still gross, and itches under my armor, I take no

damage. I whack the boss's shin with Bite, (*Do turkeys even have shins?*) as I run between it's legs. Confusing the monster for a moment as it turns in place, looking for me. I'm closing with the eggs, staff in hand and ready to smash.

"ONE! TWO! ONE! TWO! GO GO GO!"

CRUNCH!

The white shell fragments and collapses when I connect. I'm fast on my feet and dance away just in time to avoid stepping, and slipping in the yolk. The last two eggs are shaking like they're about to hatch. Pahrem casts a smite. Turkakodzilla's footsteps shake the ground behind me. Laurelade unleashes another burning AOE. I strike with Bite. The green egg cracks.

Laurelade casts Firestorm.

Laurelade hits you for 10 damage.

You resist 10 damage.

Both of the remaining eggs shatter under Laurelade's spell. This time I'm unable to avoid their contents as my boots are mired in yellow goop.

Laurelade says, "Sorry, failed my control roll."

I groan. "You've gotta get that friendly fire under control."

Pahrem says, "You know how much this makes me want an omelet?"

I don't have time to answer. Turkakodzilla looms overhead.

"GRROOOOOOAAAARRRRBBBBBLE-ABBLE ABBLE."

The yolk freezes, and the lower half of my body is encased in ice. On top of that my health drops by thirty percent.

"Hey breakfast!" I toss my chakram at Turkakodzilla because I'm out of range for Bite.

Taunt. Successful.

Turkakodzilla attacks.

"Everyone behind the boss. Once the ice breaks I'm gonna kite away from the slime."

I can't move, so it's impossible to dodge the next attack. Turkakodzilla attempts to stomp me, and I miraculously manage to parry with my staff, causing the foot to smash down right beside me. The boss backs up and lowers its head. *Awe... fuck..* Boom! Boom! Boom! I wince, under the rattling footsteps and brace for impact.

"Ugh!" On the bright side, my legs are no longer locked inside a block of ice. On the other, I'm flying way farther than I had before. I clear the fence that marks the Turkeyshoot enclosure, and Turkakodzilla is groarbling after in hot pursuit, I see stars and dark spots as my head hits the earth. My health's down to thirty percent.

I could really use a heal.

The stunned debuff appears in the corner of my vision. Pahrem and Laurelade must be out of range. A Turkakodzilla stomp sinks my health even lower... fifteen percent. I can't move due to being stunned for the next five seconds.

Damn... No Turkeygeddon this match...

I've all but given up when a bubble of golden light bursts around me. *Pahrem's in range!*

My health leaps up to the sixty percent mark, and then trickles higher over the next few moments. My vision begins to clear, and I can move around again.

"Yeah! Heal your ass off Pahrem!"

Rather than attacking, I spin Bite in front of me, slam one end into the dirt, and taunt so the boss will keep coming at me.

Taunt. Successful.

Turkakodzilla attacks.

I dip out of the way of the monster turkey's foot and take no damage. PAH-POOM! PAH-BOOM! PAH-POOM! An endless stream of purple mage bolts slam into the boss's body. I hit the boss's leg with my staff sending arcs of electricity into him.

Boss health: 60%

I shout, "We've got this!" as I dodge out of the way of another monster stomp, sending my dodge counter up one. The boss breathes deep. I glance over my shoulder and see a tree.

Shadow Step (Rank 5) - Success!

I charge toward the turkey, step into it's shadow, and re-emerge in the shade of the tree. I miss the wave of fire breath entirely, though the grass isn't so lucky as red embers, and small yellow flames smoke and smolder. With some amusement, I note a crowd of gawkers watching, following, but keeping a safe distance.

Laurelade casts an ice spell to hold the boss in place, and I toss my chakram as soon as I'm within range. Not much sound as it impacts, but I'm rewarded with seeing it's health drop another ten percent. The scent of burning feathers fills the air as Laurelade unleashes another Cinderburst causing feathers to catch fire.

My health's up to eighty percent now, and Turkakodzilla attempts to stomp me, I try to evade. He barely nicks me. No damage to me, but a bolt of electricity from my magic boots rebounds on my attacker. I follow the dodge up with a swift kick to the nearest foot that causes light to explode from my heal—another effect of the enchantment.

The boss breathes deep. I try to run out of range, but I'm too slow. Shadow Step still has two more seconds on cool down. A tsunami of green acid pours over me. It burns, though thankfully in game pain is diminished. It's still not comfortable. My health's back down to forty, but Pahrem's watching and is fast on the heal. I'm now up to sixty percent... seventy.

The goblin lobs one of her g'nades. Two seconds later it explodes setting more feathers on fire. The area goes bright as Laurelade hammers the boss with her Solaris Incendius spell.

Turkakodzilla health: 20%

"Keep going!"

I dodge out of the way of another turkey stomp. BOOM. It crashes against the ground beside me. I hit the foot with my electrified staff and lightning scurries up it's leg. Another Cinderburst. Pahrem smites!

Boss health: 10%

We're so close I can taste it. Turkakodzilla heaves a deep breath. Flashes of purple. PAH-POOM! PAH-BOOM BOOM! Mage bolts! There's just a sliver of boss health remaining. I spring forward and deliver a roundhouse kick, before it can hit me with it's next breath weapon.

"GRRROOOOOOAAARRRRRRRRRBBBBBLLLL
EE...ble... ugh..."

Turkakodzilla falls backward. The ground rumbles. Leaves in the trees shake and flutter down when the boss hits the ground.

"Alright!" Pahrem says.

"Finally." Laurelade says.

Round Ten Complete - TURKEYGEDDON!

"Whew. " I breathe deeply. The boss despawns leaving a loot chest in place of a corpse. I motion for the others to open it.

Pahrem cheers, "All right! I got the title."

"What's the title? Show me." She holds out her VT so I can see the announcement.

Congratulations!

By defeating Turkakodzilla in the one, three, and five person challenges and obtaining 10 items from the Turkeyshoot Gift Shop, you have been awarded a new title.

You have earned the achievement: Turkanator.

Pahrem configures something in her interface so that her name now displays as Pahrem the Turkanator on her nameplate. "This is awesome."

Laurelade asks, "How did you manage the one person challenge? You have a DPS alt or something?"

Pahrem says, "Lots of potions, g'nades and goblin alchemy."

You have received 200 Turkeyshoot tokens.

Turkeyshoot Cornucopia

Type:

Misc

Quality:

Epic

Use:

Creates nourishment for 10 minutes.

Cooldown: 60 minutes.

Turkakodzilla's Steelbeak Claw Tips

Type:

Fist Weapon

Quality:

Epic

Base Damage:

Strength+3 (Slashing)

Equipped Bonus:

Stamina +2, Dexterity+2, Strength+2

Special Properties:

Steelbeak Knockback - When activated, sends target flying Strength x2+Damage feet on successful hit.

Stuns if target flies more than 40 feet.

Cooldown: 1 minute, 30 seconds

"Roll for Cornucopia."

Laurelade rolls 1 (1-10) sided dice. Result: 6

Melpomine rolls 1 (1-10) sided dice. Result: 5

Pahrem rolls 1 (1-10) sided dice. Result: 8

The goblin takes the horn of plenty in her hands.

"Today's my lucky day ain't it?"

"What's it do?"

Laurelade says, "Just creates buff food for a few minutes. Nothing OP since it's a holiday welfare epic."

I look to Pahrem. "Give it a shot."

She rubs the horn like a magic lamp. Orange light pulses, and fills the interior with red, and yellow mist. "Reach in."

I follow the instruction, not sure what to expect, but then my hand brushes up against something greasy and solid. I take hold, withdraw my arm, and discover that I'm holding a turkey drumstick.

I sniff. "Smells good."

Laurelade says, "Tastes terrible. Same as everything outside Pehrom's kitchen."

I take a bite, and am saddened to discover she's right. I swallow my first mouth full it tastes of unflavored tofu. A new buff appears in the corner of my vision.

Turkeyshoot Drumstick

Stamina increased by 10%

Regeneration increased by 20%

Duration: 60 minutes

I say, "That's not so bad." referring to the buff.

"It's not bad." Laurelade says, "But not amazing. I'd rather have plus ten percent to all stats, or twenty to one."

I shrug. "How about the fist weapon?"

"Take it," Laurelade says.

Pahrem says, "Claws are yours. I don't melee."

"Thanks." I put them in my inventory, thinking about how to use them. Bite's still my preferred weapon for tanking since it has an AoE taunt, but I'm sure there's some situations where the claw tips could be useful since I don't have any knockback abilities.

The announcer booms the names of the next Turkeyshoot challengers, and Tako approaches. "You want to do it again?"

I shrug. "I've got a few runs left in me. After that I'm going to Dragonswood. I want to check in with Zarentu and Aztram before we start the North Pole quest to see if they have anything that can help us."

Laurelade asks, "What do you think they can do?"

I shrug. "Dunno, but Aztram gave us the tip that helped us clear Cerberus last time."

Laurelade says, "Who's in your party?"

"I'm thinking Me, Tako, Mirae, Frobod and Lilly."

A look crosses her face, but it's hard to interpret since when she's not being aloof, she's grumpy. *Disappointment?*

Pahrem cuts in. "You can be in my group." She holds her hand up to my shoulder like a rollercoaster sign at Six Flags. "You must be this small to come. Beat it short points!"

Tako eyes Pahrem, looks to Laurelade, then back to me, "Is she racist against elves?" I can tell the healer's just joking, and I'm sure Tako can too.

"No way. We'll take a full blooded elf, but you half breeds are too tall. It's like I said, long legs, keep movin'."

"I guess tall is relative." I've always felt short as a non-human. I regard Tako. "If you're looking for tokens, I can do another 3P match with you if Pahrem's game, or 5P if we can find someone else."



Chapter 3 - Rage Babies

After a few more Turkeyshoot battles, I leave the others to farm tokens for their seasonal items, and visit Dragonswood. I haven't been to Dragonswood Keep since we returned from Hades. I travel via Thunder Bridge.

CRACK.

Lightning strikes on a cloudless autumn day. Stars and colorful splotches dance for a few moments in my vision. A puffed up man with a walrus moustache wearing Lord Zarentu's white tabard embroidered with a golden dragon greets me.

"Lady Lord Melpomine."

"Hi Archibald. How are things?"

"Quite well! Quite well... I think." His voice grows less confident by the syllable. Instead of

answering with words I raise a thin blonde eyebrow.

"There's nothing wrong with you, or Lord Zarentu anyway."

I sense a quest. "Tell me more."

"Well, you know it's the holidays, and people are running wild trying to get ready."

"That doesn't sound too bad."

"Yes, well... Our new additions haven't been helping."

"You mean the people I brought back from Hades?"

Archibald nods.

A clean shaven string bean of a man, also wearing Zarentu's house crest and colors, and conical helm approaches from within the gate. The newcomer smirks and says, "Tellin' her about the rage babies, are you?"

"Hello, Lyle." I pause, and then ask. "Rage babies?"

Archibald says, "That's what we've started calling them."

Jason, Annette, and James must love that being in their mid to late twenties.

My heart jumps because I feel responsible for the Freefolk we brought to Haven. Not only did our

party rescue the trio from a Freeworld Vampire dungeon, but I also used my Freeworld Online wererat alt to infect them with the Nativity Pestilence when I brought them to Haven. In some sense, by transforming them from humans into Rodekin, I'm their mother.

"I hope they're not too much trouble."

Archibald puffs up. "Nothing dragons can't handle."

"I'm sure. Where are they?" The guards exchange meaningful looks, so I repeat, "Where are they?"

Archibald says, "Yes, that..."

Lyle chortles and gestures toward the forest bordering the castle. "Down the road and out of ear shot."

Archibald says, "Our lord's fixed up a cottage for them."

Lyle says, "More like fixed a cottage for himself."

"Oh dear." I imagine what it must be like to live with not one, but three newly changed were rats that haven't mastered their impulses. It's a character type that literally has rage and calm as stats, and the former starts a lot higher. Until that calm rating eclipses rage, a were is going to be short tempered and violent. "I'll

pay them a visit when I'm done here. Is Lord Zarentu or Master Aztram available?"

Archibald looks to Lyle, and says "They're in our lord's study, correct?"

Lyle nods. "They should finish any moment."

Archibald says, "I trust you know the way by now. If you hurry you may be able to catch both at once."

"Thanks. Have a good one."

Dragonswood keep has become a second home since the Toxic Muffins forged an alliance with Lord Zarentu, the light dragon that rules this settlement in human form. The castle walls, and draconic tapestries decorating the corridors feel familiar in a way they hadn't a few months ago. The large wooden door of Zarentu's study opens ahead of me. A spry elderly half-elf dips out.

"Lady Lord Melpomine. What a surprise. So good to see you."

"Nice to see you too, Aztram. I see you're feeling better." The last time I saw him he had a limp.

"Much better. I was only down a couple of days."

"I was hoping to check in and pick your mind."

"Oh?".

"We're planning another adventure."

"Did you want to talk to Lord Zarentu as well?"

I nod. "Since you're both here..." I trail motioning to the door.

The half-elf says, "Not a problem. I'll announce you." He turns, knocks twice, and pushes the door open. "May I present, Lady Lord Melpomine, of the Toxic Muffins?" The heavy door groans as he pushes it wider, and motions me in. Zarentu sits behind his desk with steepled fingers. He gives me a tight, yellow eyed smile.

I laugh. "Less than happy to see me?"

Lord Zarentu says, "As always, it's a pleasure Lady Lord Melpomine."

"Your words say yes, but your mouth..."

"Just hoping you haven't brought any more surprises."

"I'm sorry about that. I hear Annette, Jason, and James have been causing problems."

He shakes his head. "You did well in bringing them to me, but... I may have underestimated the scope of this project."

Aztram says, "Their magic doesn't make any sense. Completely foreign. I'd really appreciate if you could teach me the basics of alien magic."

"They're doing magic?" I ask, surprised.

The old mage says, "Trying to... From what I gather it hasn't been very effective, and they lack the discipline to learn the proper art."

I assume that by "proper art" he means Haven style magic. "That may change. They've been through no small transformation." I look to Zarentu. "I hear they have their own cottage. What happened?"

Zarentu snorts, I can imagine a puff of smoke bursting out of a draconic muzzle. "They couldn't stay. All day, all night, screeching, and causing a ruckus. No one could slumber. By the terms of our agreement, I couldn't kill them so..."

"You built them a house." I finish. "Makes perfect sense."

Aztram says, "More like restored, but yes."

"How are they doing?"

Zarentu says, "Well enough. Aggressive, explosive, and yet... also human. You are correct in your assessment that they are not like local weres. They need training. Once they learn self control, and how to use their magic they'll be welcome back in my household."

I regard Aztram. "If it's what I think, my instruction won't help you. Freeworld Weres have their

own magic that's different from other magic. The only way to learn is to become a were yourself."

He shudders. "Perhaps I'd be better studying from afar."

Zarentu says, "This does not change the fact that they need guidance. Perhaps you could help with that."

"What do you want me to do?"

"Take them on one of your adventures. Teach them of what you know of their kind."

"Eh..." I trail. My were-rat isn't exactly advanced, so I'm not the best teacher. I rarely spent time playing characters with rage, because of the short fuse issue. If you're not careful, you'll lose control and start ripping apart your own party. "We have an important mission but... I'm not sure bringing along three volatile Rodekin is a good idea."

Zarentu says, "Then take one of my rage babies, train it, and return so it can help the others."

Quest

Taming the Rage Babies

Difficulty: Moderate

Lord Zarentu has asked you to help educate his Rodekin guests by taking one of them with you on one of your quests. During this time, you're expected to help them learn their magic, channel their rage, or learn to overcome it.

NPC party members will not count toward party limits.

Objectives:

Complete a quest of hard difficulty or greater with Annette, Jason, or James in your party

0/1

Rewards:

+750 Reputation with Dragonswood Keep

+500 Personal Reputation with Lord Zarentu

200 gold

1 Rare quality item from Lord Zarentu's armory.

Conditional Rewards:**+1000 General repute with spirits.****(Must assume were creature alias on turn in.)****Do you accept? Yes / No**

I choose yes.

"I'd pay you for the trouble. Upon return, you may also help yourself to an item from my armory. As you've said before. You're the closest thing we have to an expert. "

"I'll see what I can do. Do you have any preference on who comes with me?" The dragon shakes his head no. "I'll take Annette then. I'm sure she's feeling out of place in a small home with a couple of boys." I fish the mangled dolly we found in Hades from my inventory, and pass it to Aztram. "I was hoping you might be able to help me find the owner of this."

Mangled Dolly (Unique)

This item begins a quest.

Description:

A child's toy that's seen better days. Beneath it's dress is the mark of the San'ta Elves. Someone in the North Pole may be looking for this.

Activate to start this quest.

He takes it in his old wrinkled hands, scrunches his face, and examines the doll from all angles. "This is the mark of the San'ta. Reclusive folk from the top of the world."

"As in the North Pole, right? We've got to find them, and return this to it's owner. What can you tell me?"

"Well..." Aztram trails. "As I said, they're reclusive. We only see them around Winter Festival when Great Uncle Winter makes an appearance."

"Is that like Santa Claus?"

"I don't know who Santa Claus is, but Great Uncle Winter wears a jolly red suit and brings toys to children. Adults too on occasion."

"It's Santa." Lord Zarentu inclines his head, inviting an explanation. "In the home of adventurers, and Freeworld for that matter, there's the story of Santa Claus. A fat bearded man in a red suit who brings gifts to good children, and leaves coal for bad ones."

Zarentu rumbles, "This Santa Claus. Is he a spirit?"

I shrug. "In my world he's make believe, but I think he's real in the free world. The stories say that he flies around the entire world in a magic sleigh one night in every year. He sneaks into homes while families are asleep, and leaves gifts beneath the Christmas..." I see confusion clouding the NPC's expressions, and amend, "Winter tree. The kids often leave milk and cookies out on the table to thank him."

Aztram says, "It appears your Santa has much in common with Great Uncle Winter, though in Haven he's quite real. Though Winter Festival lasts two weeks, you can see him on the last day of celebration every year. He usually appears in temples, and places of giving with his elves. Those are the San'ta who made this mark." He indicates the symbol on the dolly.

"How does he appear in so many places at once, if everyone can see him?"

Aztram shrugs, "Powerful magic, we suspect. Fueled by Winter Festival cheer."

"Do you have any advice for finding him... or more precisely the San'ta elves, before Winter Festival?"

"Go to the North Pole." Aztram says.

"Yeah... I got that. Do you have any suggestions for what to do when we get there, or even how to get there?"

The wizard shrugs. "It's a largely unexplored region. There are no public portals that I know of to take you there, though I suppose you could charter a ship for the journey. Given the environment, I think it's safe to expect frost creatures."

"What is the environment? Where I come from, the North Pole is a massive sheet of ice floating on top of an ocean."

"Really?" Aztram says, sounding curious. "It's part of the arctic continent in Haven." I must look confused because he clarifies, "Arctica. Quite cold, but there is, at least, land."

"What about the South Pole?"

"That's part of the nether arctic continent."

"Nether-Arctica?"

Aztram smiles. "Yes."

"In Freeworld it's called Antarctica."

Aztram says, "Quite similar."

I say, "You'll find that much of the geography is identical if you ever cross over, though cities and cultures differ."

Lord Zarentu says, "When will you be departing for your expedition?"

I shrug. "Soon, within a few days. I've got to organize the last of the party and get Annette up to speed."

"If you need transport, I can place you in contact with a ship's captain for a charter."

I nod. "I'll let you know if it comes to that. Ships are slow, so I'd like to explore magical transport first."

Zarentu waves his hand. "You have my offer."

I look to Aztram hoping that he can contribute magical transportation. *Anything?*

He says, "I'm afraid I can't assist you there. Speak to the Wayfarers Guild." *Damn... I could have figured that out myself.*

"Well, thank you for your help. I think I'm going to visit Annette now."

* * * * *

The Rodekin's cottage is about ten minutes into Dragonswood Forest where deciduous leaves on skeletal brown trees paint the land and canopy in an insurrection of red, orange, and gold. A side trail off the main road leads into a ravine where trees are sparse, and the rustic structure is nestled at the end. The air smells of decomposing leaves and smoke, rising through a cozy chimney. A pitch fork, hoe, and long handled shovel stand propped against stone walls beneath a thatched roof. To the side there's a small pen for livestock though I see no animals.

A dry twig snaps underfoot as I call, "Hello..? Annette?" No immediate response. "Jason? James? Is this your house?"

"Just a moment!" A female voice sounds from the back. A minute later she comes around wearing a heavy dirt smudged apron and a pair of thick gloves. She's holding a spade in her right hand.

"Wow." She's come a long way from being the shell shocked victim the vampires kept on tap, or the angry survivor that wanted to become a were so vampires wouldn't feed on her again. "You look good."

She sighs. "We're adapting."

"I half expected this place to be a smoking crater from the way they talk at Dragonswood Keep."

Annette motions for me to follow her around the side of the little house. "Come around. I'll show you what we have here."

I trail after, and discover a start of a garden behind the house. There's also a picnic table and a couple of long wooden benches to sit at. Nothing sprouting, but there are mounds of dirt where seeds and bulbs have been planted in the earth. Furthermore a trio of small chicken coops line the back wall of their home.

"There won't be much growing during winter, but I figured I'd get a start on things for the spring." Motioning with her hand, Annette says, "We cleared out this whole area for growing. When we got here it was all forest floor. Had to clear the leaves, break up the soil and smooth it all out."

"Looks like you've been keeping busy."

A male voice within the house, "Mother fu... Son of a bitch! WHERE'S MY DAMN CHICKEN!"

Jason storms out the back door and gets in Annette's face, "You eat my bird?"

Annette screeches, "I didn't touch your food!"

"This is bullshit!" He slaps the spade out of her hand. It makes a metallic clatter on the ground.

Far from cowed, Annette hauls off and delivers him a full palmed slap across the face that reverberates in the air with a fleshy POP! "I said, I didn't touch your damned food!"

A wild gleam fills Jason's eyes when she connects, and my stomach jumps. *Oh shit.* I wince both in sympathy of the blow and explosion of activity. Jason takes a swing at her head, she dips out of the way and kicks him, hard, in the leg.

"I DIDN'T EAT YOUR FOOD!"

Jason's face begins to elongate, and rodent whiskers sprout from his upper lip. His clothing stretches to accommodate his fast enlarging body, as brown fur springs up on his arms and legs. He's now several heads taller than I am. A hairless tail dances back behind him like a whip, and his hairy enlarged hands are now tipped with vicious were claws.

"I'll break you! Lying bitch!"

"Hey!" I shout. "Chill out!"

Jason takes a swipe at me with those nasty claws, I duck out of the way, drop to the ground, place my hands in the dirt, and bring my leg around to trip him.

Martial Arts Maneuver - Dragon Tail Sweep (Rank 3) - Success!

The male wererat goes down, falling hard on his butt with an "Ugh!" and an incoherent scratch of syllables that I assume must be profanity.

Meanwhile Annette howls, "What did you call me?" Now she's growing a few heads taller, and just as furry. Unlike Jason, her fur is white with random patches of black about her body. She tackles him on the ground, and smashes her rodent forehead into his ratty face. A smear of red decorates the spot between and above her eyes like an Indian bindi.

"Guys!" I shout, as James comes around the other side of the house with a sack over his shoulder, and chewing the meat off a baked chicken leg. He snickers. Annette and Jason roll in the dirt while chittering and clawing at each others faces.

"Give them a minute till it runs out of their system."

Jason stops clawing Annette, his nose twitches. "My chicken!" He throws Annette off him like a sack of mulch, stumbles to his feet, and charges the new comer. "You ate my chicken asshole!"

James quickly polishes off the rest of the meat and tosses the bone over his shoulder. "Look what I brought."

Jason shows his interest by plowing into James like a linebacker and knocks him to the ground. Annette, springs to her feet and runs at the two men.

James says, "Fucker! I brought..." Jason claws him, leaving bright red claw marks on his cheek. Something snaps inside as he too shifts to wererat form, and beats on the guy that tackled him.

Annette takes two running steps, and makes a flying leap, landing on Jason's back, and pressing James, on the bottom, further into the ground. "Don't call me a bitch, biotch!" She hits the back of his head with her claws leaving bloody tracks in his fur. She bunches her hairy hands into fists, and begins hammering on the back of Jason's skull like she's trying to give him a concussion. "Bastard!"

I don't know what to do. I just watch the spectacle with my mouth hanging agape wondering, *Have they been going at it like this every night?* The three are a writhing mass of flying limbs, curses, and fur. Eventually, Jason in the middle stops moving, and automatically transforms back into human unconscious. Annette hits him one more time for good measure, rolls

on to her back and stares upward, breathing heavily. After fifteen or twenty seconds she reverts to human. Finally James pushes Jason's lifeless body off him, and shrinks back into his human shape.

Speaking reluctantly, "Is he going to be okay?" Like twins, the two conscious wererats wave dismissive hands.

Annette heaves herself to her feet and smiles, "You found us!"

"Errr..." *I guess we're not going to talk about what just happened.*

James motions into the forest, "I got a few rabbits for the ice box, and killed a boar back that way. It's too big for me to carry. I was hoping you could help me."

Annette says, "He's our hunter. Getting pretty good with a bow. We give a portion of what he hunts to the Keep to show appreciation for supplies and our new home, and in exchange Zarentu's people teach us skills."

Quest**Boar Meat****Difficulty: Easy**

James has killed a boar in Dragonswood, but it's too large for him to carry on his own. Help him bring it home, then escort one of the wererats with a portion of meat to Dragonswood Keep.

Objectives:**Boar retrieved** 0/1**Rewards:****+75 Reputation with Dragonswood Keep****Recipe: Dragonswood Boar****50 silver****Do you accept? Yes / No**

I choose yes.

"I thought you guys weren't allowed at the keep."

James says, "Lord Zarentu allows one of us to visit at a time, if we can keep our heads."

Jason stirs, and then sits up looking dazed.

Annette says, "James got us a boar. We need help bringing it back."

He grumbles something about "chicken," and Annette responds with "Pulled pork sandwiches!"

I look to James, "So where's the boar?"

"This way."

We follow after, breaking away from the road and into the understory where brush and sticks snap underfoot.

"Good hunting?"

"Not bad." James says. "It's a little tricky learning the bow, but I guess some of my ability with firearms back home has carried over."

"I should teach you meditation. It helps balance the rage, so you can maintain self control. Zarentu says you can come back once you stop flying off the handle."

"I don't know." Annette says, "I kind of like our place in the forest."

I chuckle. "You could be a medicine woman. Make the folk come visit you in your cottage."

"Only problem with that is I can't heal."

"Aztram says you've been trying to do magic."

She makes a teeter tottering so-so gesture with her hand. "I often feel like I'm on the cusp of something and then... nothing."

"Do you know about the spirits?" I take her silence as a no. "All Rodekin powers, and Rodekin specific magic come from bargaining with the spirits. You have to pay tribute to them and ask for their assistance."

Jason says, "What do you mean spirits? Like dead people in Hades?"

I shake my head no, "Rodekin and other weres get their magic from nature spirits. In fact, rather than being a spirit inside of a body, your flesh has become so infused with natural power that you are now a creature of spirit. It's the reason why nature spirits can teach you their abilities."

Annette says, "I'm trying to wrap my head around that. So what your saying is that humans are souls inside of bodies, and Rodekin are...."

"Souls inside of fleshy spirit bodies."

James says, "What's the difference?"

"Humans are flesh and bone. Weres from where you come from are flesh and bone that has been saturated in spirit energy. So much so that disembodied spirits think of you as cousins."

Annette says, "I guess that makes sense.... On an abstract philosophical level. I feel just the same when I'm not angry or transforming."

"I think it'll feel more real as you grow into your new powers."

We come upon the carcass of a fat wild pig.

James says, "Here it is." He walks over to a tree and drags a pair of long shafts of wood to the body.

"Found these before I went to get you to help us carry."

I'm thinking on the Rage Baby quest. "Hold up." Three sets of eyes regard me. "Zarentu wants me to teach you what I can about Rodekin and Rodekin magic." I look to Annette, "I'd also like to bring you with us on our next adventure, for additional instruction."

"Why her?" Jason snaps.

"I figured she might like a break from being around a bunch of men for a while."

Annette says, "I don't know..."

"I've gotta take someone, and this is the best way to help you get started on that medicine woman thing. We may be able to get you some healing."

"We'll see." She says, "We've just settled."

Never thought an NPC would be fighting me on joining the quest.

"Anyway... The first step toward growing stronger, interacting with nature spirits, and balancing the rage inside you is acknowledging the spirits around

you." I kneel beside the boar. Its dead eyes stare vacantly into the canopy. "Come here."

Annette kneels beside me, then James joins, and finally Jason. Three arrow shafts penetrate deep into the animal's flesh. Patting it's belly, I can still feel a bit of warmth. My fingers become red when I touch the wound with my fingertips.

"What are you doing?" James asks.

I draw a crimson streak on my cheek, savoring the sensation of blood against my skin. I move closer to him, and do the same. I look to Annette. "Your turn." She leans forward, I touch the wound, and repeat the gesture. "Jason?"

His lip curls. "Gross."

"This is important." He sighs and leans toward me, I make a two fingered smear on his cheek. "Feel that on your skin. This animals blood. It died so that you can live. Never forget that."

James says, "I know."

"Then thank Boar for his sacrifice."

"Huh?" Jason says.

"It's like a prayer. Bow your head, and thank the spirit of this animal for dying so that you might survive."

I bow my head, and initiate the rite.

**You cannot perform were magic on this alias.
Please change to a were creature alias to complete
this spell.**

"I can't complete the process as I am now,
because this... body... isn't Rodekin. See if you can do
it."

James and Annette bow their heads, Annette
folds her hands like she's in church, and I whisper
"Good." I look to Jason, he rolls his eyes, and goes
through the motions. "Anything?"

No response. Seconds bleed into minutes, as
Jason and Annette's muscles relax and their faces grow
serene. I decide not to interrupt.

**Mentorship skill increased by 1. Current level: 2
You have taught Annette Rite of Gratitude.
You have taught James Rite of Gratitude.**

*I guess I don't have to switch to a Rodekin alias
to teach basic rituals.*

"Whoa...." James says.

"That's so cool..." Annette echoes.

"Do this every time you kill for food or prepare a meal to begin building repute with the spirits. Pretty soon they'll begin helping you."

Jason says, "I don't feel anything."

I consider telling him that it's because he's not trying, but instead settle on "It just takes practice," not wanting to see him turn violent.

Jason eats his words and asks, "What happened?"

Annette looks around and then begins helping James create a stretcher from the long pieces of wood using a combination of rope and canvas in between. "Hard to explain exactly. The world feels lighter, and everything looks more alive. Even dirt, if that makes sense."

"That's because of the spirits. In Rodekin cosmology, everything has a spirit. Even stones and the wind."

James asks, "So it's not just people and animals?"

I shake my head no. "The young typically find it easier to interact with animals."

Jason says, "I'm 27."

"The day you were infected was a new birthday. So far as weres are concerned, you're just babies."

James shudders. "Never been so sick in my life."

I nod. "It sucks, but on the bright side Rodekin are immune to poisons and disease. The Nativity Pestilence inoculates you against all but the nastiest magical illnesses."

Annette stands having rolled the animal on the carrying device with James's help. "Well that's something."

James says, "'Nette, carry up front with me. Mel and Jason take the back."

We heft the pig between us, each of us taking one end of the make shift carrier. It's heavy but manageable between us. Speaking to Annette, I say, "Why don't you help me take the meat to Zarentu so we can discuss the quest?"

She gives me a look over her shoulder, I correct myself, wondering if the word quest is somehow filtered out of NPC ears. "The adventure I mentioned to help train you."

"Alright..." Her voice is non-committal.

Back at the cottage, the boys are quick to butcher the pig, breaking it down into component parts, though not as fast as opening up a loot window and retrieving "boar meat." One of the many perks of being a player.

"Ready to go?"

James gestures to a bunch of paper wrapped parcels on the backyard table. "We've got a cart if you want."

One by one they disappear into my inventory.
"I'm good, with my magic backpack. Annette?"

She removes her apron. "Alright."

Now long out of earshot, walking back to Dragonswood Keep, I look to her. "What's up? I expected you to be more enthusiastic."

"We're just always moving. First from home to Hades. Then from Hades to here, now you want to take me off to I don't know where."

"The North Pole."

"Yeah, there. It's hard to put down roots."

"This is a little different, because we're coming back. I guess the last few times you never knew where you'd end up." She nods in acknowledgement. "This will help you. Once you can get your rage and abilities under control, Zarentu will let you back in the keep which will make it even easier for you to become a part of the community."

"I guess." She says.

"If you really don't want to go I'll ask James, it's up to you."

A silence that's punctuated by crunchy footsteps settles between us. A few moments later she responds, "Alright, I'll go."

I smile. "Glad to hear it."

Lyle greets us at the gate. "Lady Lord Melpomine... Miss Annette."

"We've got meat for the kitchen." He eyes us skeptically, so I follow. "Magical backpack."

His eyes flicker to my shoulders, which do not seem to be holding a backpack since I toggled it to remain hidden some time ago, but it's lack of presence seems to remind him that I'm an adventurer. "Right you are then."

Annette says, "I know the way."

"So you do. Don't keep Aya waiting."

That's the Mistress of the Kitchens. I'm surprised by how quiet the environment is when we find her. A fine smelling stew warms over a cook fire, and a few chefs in toque blanches chop vegetables on cutting boards, but there's no sense of urgency in the kitchen.

Annette calls, "Mistress Aya?"

A brunette woman with long straight hair pulled into a pony tail peeks her head out of a magically chilled, walk in, ice box. She's wearing a black chef's

jacket with Zarentu's golden house crest on the breast. "Annette! What do you have for me?" She then realizes the Rodekin's not alone. "Lord Melpomine."

"Boar meat."

Aya says, "Bring it here." My skin becomes goose flesh as we step into the freezer, and I begin withdrawing the wrapped parcels from my inventory. "I see James is becoming quite the hunter. Good for him."

Annette nods.

"I'm surprised it's so mellow around here. When I arrived Archibald made it sound like the keep was chaos."

Aya says, "It's only Chaos in here before a feast. We have a few weeks yet. Laurent preparing for his Winterfest fashion show is another story." She stacks the hunks of meat on well organized shelves. "Stick around, and I'll teach you how to prepare it."

Quest Completed: Boar Meat**You have gained:****+75 Reputation with Dragonswood Keep****Recipe: Dragonswood Boar****50 silver**

Instruction doesn't take long, since it's Haven cooking and not the real world kind that actually requires you to manipulate the ingredients.

You have gained the skill Cooking.**Current level: 1**

Well there's an added benefit. I'll probably never use it, but I'm not complaining since every skill up gives me points to spend on spells and special abilities.

"Do you have any scraps I can take with me?"

"Hungry?" Aya asks.

I shake my head no, "It's for the birds." Annette looks inquisitive. "It's for your training."

"I'm sure we can find something. How about hard cheese, a few nuts, old bread?"

"That should work." I say.



Chapter 4 - Magpie

The courtyard is quiet when Lord Zarentu's not hosting a tournament. A guard patrols near the front gate, and gardeners manicure hedges near the keep's entrance. Annette and I are now standing beneath a tree with red and orange leaves.

I hand her the bundle of stale bread, old mild cheddar, and nuts. "I'm going to teach you to call your first spirit. They should be more receptive to you after the Rite of Gratitude. The vast majority of your magic will start with an offering to the spirits."

She asks, "What are we going to call?"

"I think Magpie's a good place to start since he's seen you, and responded to me not too long ago."

Annette asks, "What can he do?"

"Many things, but for now we're going to focus on you two building a relationship, so he'll teach you new abilities."

"What do I do?"

I say, "Break up the bread, and scatter some of it with a bit of the nuts and cheese on the ground." She follows my instruction. "Cup the rest in your hands like this, and hold your hands up like you're giving it to the tree. Send out a mental call for assistance."

"What do you mean?"

"In this case, just address Magpie, and indicate that you're looking for guidance and instruction. It's like a silent prayer. This is your first time so it may take a few tries."

She holds her hands up filled with the bits of cheese and bread, then closes her eyes. Long seconds pass. Nothing happens.

"It's not working." Irritation sounds in her voice.

"Take deep breaths, calm... Feel the air moving in and out of your lungs. Picture the spirit in your mind. You remember what he looks like, right?"

"Not really."

I think back to when we first met. *She might have been unconscious then.* "Alright. You know what

a magpie looks like? Kinda like a crow, with a patch of white, and dark blue and black feathers?"

"Sort of."

"Good. Picture a bird like that, but as a ghost with a blue-white aura." She closes her eyes, concentrating, though her hands aren't raised. "Do you see it?"

"Shut up, and let me concentrate!"

"Err. Okay." Never forget she's Rodekin.

She breathes deep. I watch her chest slowly rise and fall. I want to give encouragement, but I'm sliding on cracked ice not wanting to invoke her temper.

"I've got it." She says. "I feel something."

"Good. Now raise your hands to show it's an offering." She does so, the spectral bird swoops down nibbling bits of cheese and nuts off the ground. "You can open your eyes."

She does, and inhales a surprised breath. The spirit cocks its head at her. "Hungry." Magpie ignores me.

"You can put the rest of the food on the ground."

She empties her hands. The bird pecks the food with quick jerks of its head.

Annette whispers, "What now?"

"Let him enjoy his meal. He'll address you."

Magpie stirs, flapping his wings to readjust his position on the ground while filling his belly. Finally, the bird caws "Thanks. What now?" The spirit pauses. "What now?"

All of his attention is on Annette who in turn looks to me with a questioning expression painted on her face.

"Tell him about the quest.. errr.. our journey." I suspect that Magpie's not interested in me because I'm not playing my Rodekin character.

"Uhhh..." She fumbles with her words.

"Just talk, you're doing great."

"I know!" she snarls.

Magpie cocks his head, and pecks more cheese off the ground. He flicks his head back like he's catching a wad of popcorn in his mouth. "Doing great."

Annette says, "I need help. I just became Rodekin and I don't know about the spirits. I'm also about to go on an adventure."

The bird caws, "Hungry."

"I think he's always hungry. Offer to feed him in exchange for knowledge."

"If I bring you food, can you teach me?"

Magpie hops toward her. "Good food for good lessons."

I say, "He's an omnivore, so bread and cheese is okay for today, but next time see if you can bring some meat. Perhaps a mouse."

Annette gives me a bemused look. "A rat feeds a bird a mouse."

I shrug. "You've been a woman a lot longer than you've been a rat. Didn't think it'd bother you."

"Bring mice." Magpie flutters his wings, his avian voice is laced with pleasure. "Where are you going?"

Annette says, "I live in Dragonswood. I'm sure I can find mice there."

"For the journey, human. Where are you going?" I could be wrong, but I get the sense that Magpie reserves the 'human' designation for weres that aren't well attuned to their animal selves.

Annette looks to me, as if for permission.

I prod her forward, "Santa."

"The North Pole."

"Cold." Magpie croaks.

"Ask if he can open a moonwalk for us."

Confusion enters her gaze. "What's a moonwalk?"

"It's how weres quickly travel long distances. Just ask him."

"Uhhh.. Do you think you could do a moonwalk for us?"

Magpie issues a warning call that sounds like a toy machine gun.

"You don't have enough repute yet for him to agree, but at least you've put the idea in his mind."

"Repute?" Annette asks.

"Reputation with the spirits. Feed him, and help him with whatever he asks for a few days and see if he changes his mind."

"I'll have better food later today."

"Okay." Magpie issues a bird whistle. "Bye for now." He flies off, soaring over Dragonswood Keep's wall.

Looking to Annette I say, "He may come find you on his own. If he doesn't, do what you did here with your offering and he should come."

She nods. "So... This adventure, when do you plan on leaving?"

"After Turkeyshoot. Be ready to go at the start of next month. We'll swing by to get you then."

"What should I do in the meantime?"

"Put your focus on finding ways to interact with the spirits. The moonwalk is key, and any of them can open one. They just have to like you well enough. To

gain their favor, make offerings. A lot of times they'll give assistance in exchange for performing tasks for them. The more they like you, the cheaper their price. Don't be rude, because they can become enemies too."

"Alright..." she trails.

"I have faith in you. The boys will be fine. You can teach them that Boar recipe so they don't starve." I pause a moment, considering. "Actually, I think I'll make an announcement in the guild to see if anyone's familiar enough with Freeworld weres to train them. If there are takers, they may get to go on an adventure of their own."

Annette brushes a lock of hair behind her ear, "That makes me feel a little better."

"Rat mother, are you?"

"Little bit, but they won't admit that. Jason in particular is a pain in the ass. He's not adapting well to this place. He wants to go racing, and eat at restaurants."

"Racing?" I ask.

"He was a street racer from the sound of it, driving Elebikes and Elecruisers."

"Well, if the technology ever makes its way to Haven his skills will be in demand. Not too many driving experts."

She shrugs. "We'll figure it out."

I note the use of the word we instead of he. It's good to think they're thinking of themselves as a unit. "I'll be back in a few days. Until then practice with the spirits, and do whatever it is you'd normally do to get ready for a trip. I'll take care of provisions."



Chapter 5 - Turkeyshoot Dinner

Cupcake Keep's a lot more lively than when we left. Not only is every place set in the dining hall, but additional tables have been brought out of storage to fill the ballroom. The air smells of pumpkin spice. Alfred, the keep's caretaker, appears in a his customary cascade of purple smoke, wearing a tuxedo. Instead of a handkerchief in his breast pocket, a fan of small turkey feathers decorates his suit.

I raise an eyebrow. "Nice to see you're catching the spirit."

Unlike real world Thanksgiving, Turkeyshoot is a time of feasting, and celebrating the turkey as an animal, though we adventurers have imported a tradition of family, which is now to say guild,

togetherness and gratitude. There's a distinct lack of Native American and pilgrim imagery, it's all gourds, autumn colors and turkey feathers in Haven.

Alfred indicates the seasonal décor with a wave of his hand, and then leads me into the ballroom which now has a pair of long bench style tables with dozens of place settings. There's a small table in Toxic Muffins purple at the far end of the room reserved for guests of honor. "It's a special day."

I nod. "I think this is the first time I'll see everyone together since the new recruits."

Alfred says, "Justice officers will also be in attendance."

Pehrom bursts into the room wearing his toque blanche. "Good! You're here. Dinner starts in twenty minutes."

I raise a brow, "Where is everyone?"

"How the fuck should I know? I've been working all day making grub."

Alfred clears his throat. "Most are in their rooms, a few are outside training, and there four individuals in the guild bath. Our guests from Justice are currently outside. Do you wish me to call them?"

I shake my head no, and look to Pahrem. "Why don't you send an announcement?"

"I'm busy over here! Besides, I don't know how to do it."

I pull out my VT, and pull up the guild interface, "I'll show you." In spite of Pehrom's protest of being too busy for announcements, he eyes my device with interest. "Tap here for officer tools," Pehrom summons his own VT and follows my instructions, "Then on this icon that looks like a megaphone to create an announcement." An empty text box appears on our screens. "When you're done just hit send. Try it."

A burst of text superimposes itself on my vision, accompanied by a weighty BONG sound.

"DINNER IN 15 MINUTES FUCKERS!"

"Nice message." I type a follow up.

Pehrom shrugs as if to say 'What'd you expect?'
"I do my best."

BONG.

"Tell Justice and non-guild guests. - M"

"Is Lilly around? I want to talk to her about the quest."

Pehrom nods, "Yeah, she's here."

I send a message.

Melpomine: Hey, are you at CK? Can we talk before dinner?"

SalemLilly: Sure. About what?

Melpomine: Quest planning. Just want to make sure we have a balanced party.

SalemLilly: I'll be down in a sec.

Pehrom disappears into the normal dining room, which is linked to the kitchen. From what I glimpse through the doorway, it's been set up like a buffet, which makes sense since there are many people and we don't have a wait staff.

"I can't wait to eat."

Alfred, glances about the room. "I'll make sure our guests know to come." He collapses in a waterfall of rolling purple clouds, and I stand alone. I move to the

table reserved for guests of honor, and take a seat near the middle since the Toxic Muffins are my guild. An attractive, black haired, red eyed, green skinned woman with enormous ears enters from the left wearing a sand colored sweater that hugs her body.

"Have a seat."

She takes the spot next to me. "What's up?"

"So we've got Mirae on heals, Tako on sneaky stabby DPS, me as tank, and Frobod as melee DPS / off tank. We've also got an NPC Freeworld wererat coming along that doesn't have much of a specialization, but I'm grooming her for heals. What can you do?"

Lilly says, "I'm a dagger hexer. Dagger hex summoner to be exact."

"... and that is? I think I get the summoning part, but explain anyway. I mostly played Freeworld before this."

"It's basically a cross between mage and rogue. I've got stealth and some decent melee, along with a special ability to cast spells using knives rather than words and wands."

"So all your magic is nonverbal?"

"I can cast the old fashioned way, but I get bonuses when I use my blades. I can also do things like

store spells within my weapon so they release upon impact."

"Good to know. What can you summon? We're a bit light on AoE and crowd control."

She shrugs, "Like I said, I can still cast the traditional spells, but they're not my specialty. I've got a few summons that can get the job done too, demons, magical animals, you name it. I'm stoked about going to an unexplored continent. Hoping to expand my menagerie."

"How do you get more summons?"

"Three ways. The first, is you buy a scroll that teaches you how to summon an entity from another plane of existence. You use it, and when it arrives you negotiate terms of service. Next, you can buy an already captive creature and become it's master. Finally, the best way in my opinion, is to spare a creature's life in combat. You draw up a pact when it's at death's door. If the creature agrees, it lives and you can call on it in the future. If it doesn't, it'll usually try to kill you before it takes its last breath."

"Sounds intense. I take it you're trying to get some ice creatures."

She nods, "If they aren't from around here, they'll be worth big bucks in the market."

"They're not for yourself?"

Lilly shakes her head, "They are, some are, but why waste the opportunity for profit? Best thing about a pact is that you can negotiate transfers of ownership."

"I guess..." I trail. "But what about the loot? I assume if you catch them, they don't drop anything."

"We call it taming. There's no loot."

"I'm not wild about the idea of you trying to tame everything in sight, while taking away everyone else's drops. I'm going to ask you to split your profits with the party."

"Fifty percent for me, and you can divide the rest."

"Really?"

Indignant, Lilly says, "Hell yeah really, it's my skill that's bringing in the profit. Fifty percent of the sale price is way more than whatever vendor trash or coin they'd normally drop."

"If the others agree, I'll go along with it, but I'm going to say no taming mobs you can find around here."

"I wouldn't bother with those anyway. Takes too much time, and I'm in it to make the big bucks."

"I'll draw up a contract before we go. If everyone signs, we're good."

It's at this moment that people begin filing in. Lots of new faces, and I'm surprised to see that only a few are wearing armor. There are a lot of people like Frobod who just never removed their gear before we were stranded but now I'm seeing plain clothes—the kind of stuff that only Socs, social gamers, would wear pre-Archangel.

Mirae enters wearing a brown and orange dress that clashes with her sea elf green tinted hair, but it brings out the gold flecks in her otherwise green eyes. It's the one physical reminder that she not only digitized, but is the first player to play an exclusive subrace—The Undying, which is Freehaven speak for Mummies.

I motion her over. She has a spring in her step. "Hellooooo!" she flutters in a sing-songy voice.

"You're chipper."

She says, "It's our first holiday together in my new life. There's finally more to Thanksgiving than watching everyone eat from my wheel chair at the end of the table, that's always getting in the way of people who have to step around me. I haven't felt like this since I was a kid, and with Pehrom's cooking." She

moans in anticipation. "Real turkey. Do you have any idea what this means?"

"I think I can guess."

Mirae looks to the goblin beside me, and tilts her head "Hey Lilly."

"What's up?"

Mirae grins, "S'all good!"

I say, "We've finally got our party figured out."

"Oh?" Mirae asks, "What's the verdict?"

"It's You, Me, Tako, Frobod, Annette, and Lilly."

"Alright!" She extends a fist to Lilly, which the goblin knocks with her own. "Kapow! We're on this. Annette? You're bringing one of the Rodekin?"

"They're calling them rage babies over at Dragonswood Keep, and yeah, it's a quest. I'm hoping to teach her the basics of healing magic along the way."

Mirae shrugs, "I can help with that."

"I'm sure she'd appreciate your instruction, but I think the goal of the quest is for me to familiarize her enough with free-were cosmology that she can begin learning Rodekin magic herself."

Mirae shrugs. "Sounds fun." Though her voice suggests she could care less. "I'm not into Freeworld so..."

Lilly says, "I got nothin', rat magic's all on you Squeaks."

I roll my eyes because my Rodekin alt is also named Lilly, and the goblin has decided that Cupcake Keep isn't big enough for two Lillys. I look to Mirae. "Have a seat with us. I don't know what Pehrom had in mind, but I'm naming you a guest of honor. Besides, you're an officer."

"Thanks."

As more people wander in, they settle into clusters around the table. "That's a lot of people."

"Hell of a battle while you were gone. For the most part, we got good people."

"Sometime you're going to have to tell me about that."

Mirae walks around the table and takes her spot beside me. The ambient chatter becomes more intense as guild members, and guests settle in. A guy in blue armor with spiked gauntlets approaches. In spite of his gear he strikes me as business casual with smart parted hair, and a clean shaven face.

"You must be Melpomine. I've heard a lot about you."

"I am." My voice rises in invitation of an introduction.

"I'm Commander Longbean. Guild Master of Justice."

"Longbean, huh? Nice to meet you."

He fumbles, "There's a story behind it."

"There always is."

"Anyway... uh... I've heard good things about you."

I find his awkwardness charming, so unlike what I'd expected from the band of white knights that runs around protecting players from bullies. I smile, to show that my next words are in jest. "Don't believe everything you hear. I heard you came to our rescue while we were in Hades. Thanks for that."

"It's what we do. When I saw how few people you had around here, we had to step in. Yeah, so, your second said I should talk to you about an Alliance."

I shake my head and give Mirae a look, before returning my attention to Longbean. "I assume you're talking about Pehrom? Our structure isn't so rigidly defined."

Still nervous, he says. "I am. Your cook. Such a miraculous little man."

"He's got skills, I'll give you that. For the time being our leadership consists of me, Mirae and Pehrom. They're my officers."

"Yes, Lady Mirae, we've met. Very exciting."

"What does an alliance with Justice entail?"

"Just an agreement to come to each other's aid in times of need, sharing training facilities, etc. We can call on each other's members for joint guild runs on endgame raids, and we'll honor each others hierarchy."

This reminds me of the next quest chain in our guild's log that'll require us to destroy Cimmerian, the otherworldly dragon that tore a hole between the universes of Haven and Freeworld Online. "That could be helpful since we've got some big quests coming up after the holiday event. Are you a Limited Edition guild?"

He shakes his head no, "I wish. Too rich for my blood. Why?"

"We've got a major LE Quest to complete that'll take a lot of manpower."

"Hey man, or woman, sorry. Dude. Dude's gender neutral right? Dude. Hey dude, we're not looking to hog your glory, but I think a lot of our members would be interested in coming along just to see new content.

I snicker. "Any of those are fine as long as you don't ask me to make you a sandwich. We've got little green men for that."

Longbean stirs awkwardly, "Oh, aliens. They're good for that."

Lilly and I share a look. She shrugs. "Not quite what I meant, but I'll take your word for it."

Longbean moves around the far end of the table, and pulls out a chair. "It looks like this is where all the officers are sitting."

Looking out at the dining room I see Pahrem sitting at the end of one of the big tables for non-officers, and Sajina in his gargoyle skin across from her.

Lilly pokes my bicep to get my attention. "Hey, is Leroy coming? I'll bet a ton of people want to meet him."

I shrug. "He was invited, and I know he likes the food, but I imagine he's not all that into meet and greets for the holidays."

Pehrom comes in from the dining hall with a boiling pot in one hand and a steel ladle in the other. CLANG CLANG CLANG CLANG. I feel my eyeballs rattling in their sockets, but the cacophony does the trick because everyone quiets. Another guy I don't know, presumably Justice, takes a seat at the far end of our table.

The goblin drags a stool from the side of the room and stands on it to give him a little more height.

A few chuckles sound in the crowd. "What you're gonna make short jokes?" He points the ladle at an offending giggle. "No soup for you!" Half the crowd laughs, and the rest go abruptly silent. "I wanna thank you all for comin' our first guild Thanksgivin'. Over hea we got Mel, our Captain, Guild Masta or whateva. Most of you've met her. Mirae, the first person to come back from a failed digitization. Commander Longbean from Justice who helped us defend this place so we ain't got massive repairs."

Scattered applause. The goblin looks to Longbean and says, "Saved my ass man, so thanks."

"Happy to help, and protect those in need."

Regarding the rest of the crowd again, Pahrem continues "And last, but not least, Lilly, my beautiful loud ass wife."

Lilly says, "Who ya callin' loud ass Mr. Perfect? I ain't got nothing against Justice, but if I had a quarter for every time you messed something up in the interface."

"You'd have twenty five fuckin' cents!" Laughter sweeps through the crowd, most well accustomed to the married couples public bickering. He then notices Tako sitting at one of the common tables, and says, "The fuck

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you doin' over there? Get up here and sit next to your lady."

All eyes on Tako, he stands a bit off guard. "Oh, okay." He comes forward.

"So, enjoy your food. Buffet's in the dining room, and have a fantastic fuckin' Thanksgiving."



Chapter 6 - Moonwalk

The next few days pass in a flurry of bloated post Thanksgiving contentment as I prepare travel rations for our arctic journey. It's the first day of December, and as if by magic the entire city is covered in Winter Festival splendor. Multicolored fairy lights outline rooftops, and sparkle from evergreen branches to give Durolan a festive, holiday cheer. My favorite pond for contemplation and remembering my brother has frozen over, and opened for Havenfolk and skate minded PCs to go ice skating. To my surprise, Lilly's spent most of the morning there.

I'm hobbling on a pair of skates like a noob trying not to fall flat on my face. It's only by the grace of my massive dexterity rating that I'm not eating ice.

Lilly by contrast, jumps and spins in the air. She lands on the surface of the pond with barely a whisper of sound, whereas each one of my strokes reminds me of the earth shaking steps of Turkakodzilla.

You have gained the skill Skating (General).

Current level: 1

"Jeeze. How long have you been doing this?"

Lilly smiles, and launches into a fast spin that makes me dizzy just watching it. She stops, looking not at all dizzy. "Since I was four."

"Ha ha. Very funny."

"I'm serious."

I roll my eyes. "The game hasn't been out that long."

"Well yeah, but I'm countin' in Meatsville. You watch the Olympics? You probably know me."

I feel a skeptical look twist my face, "You're trying to tell me you're Alice Cheon?"

"Different Olympics, I ain't as young as I was before."

"I can't tell if you're messing with me. You're telling me we have an honest to god Olympian in our guild."

"Yup. Think hard. You'll figure it out, or ya can just ask Alfred."

Lilly... Lilly.. Lilly... I'm trying to place the name in the context of figure skating, but the answer is evading me. Nevertheless there's something there.

Lilly... OMG! "Lilly Sutherland!"

The goblin winks at me, and says "Give the lady a cigar!" before putting on a burst of speed toward the other end of the lake where not many people are skating, she does a double axel, immediately followed by a triple toe loop before gliding back toward me.

"Best thing about Freehaven skating is that the ice is always pristine. That and being able to shrug off the effects of old age."

"Are you serious? I used to watch you. You can't be that old."

Looking indignant, she says "What. you callin' me a liar or somethin'? After thirty it's pretty damn hard to qualify for the Olympics. You age out faster than modeling."

"Your voice is different."

"Fuckin' voice filters, or did you think I sound like a gobo on all my alts?"

"I guess not. I'm just letting it all sink in. Can't you still compete outside of the Olympics?"

"I can, and do sometimes, but it's not as satsfyin'. Once you've stood on top of that mountain that ever athlete aspires to, everythin' else is just a shadow of your former self."

"That's depressing."

She waves her hand dismissively, "It ain't so bad. I still love to skate, and in here I can live up to my former glory. Got an alt in a Figure Skatin' guild."

"They have guilds for that?"

"Damn right. Gotta weed out the people that don't know shit about skatin' in real life. Nothin' worse than losin' to people that neva set foot on real ice, and just spent a bunch of hours grindin' the skill. We ask questions that people would only know if they've hung out at the rink, or trained under a coach that Haven Online never teaches if you just level your skill by skatin' around all day."

"Does it make a difference in the game?"

"It's like playin' music or paintin'. You can use your own technique from Meatsville, but if your real life ability is better than your stats, the engine will fuck it all up and make you fall on your ass. If you just have the skill howeva, all you got to do is program a macro to initiate different jumps."

"This is a whole side of the game I didn't know existed. I mean, I knew we could skate, but I didn't know there were people who signed in just to skate, and build communities around it."

"I guess you'd call what we do a subcategory of social gamin', since we're not all out killin' shit."

"I'm heading back to CK to double check everything before we go. You want to stay a little longer, or come with me?"

She stares at the ice longingly, and sighs. "I'll go. This place is crawlin' with amateurs."

We ride back to Cupcake Keep on a pair of elemental powered motorcycles called elechoppers in the style of 1960s Harleys. I'm riding Big Red, a bike with a fire spirit swirling around what would ordinarily be the gas tank, and Lilly's on the waterchopper, which has a water spirit in the same spot.

They can also fly due to them being special developer's editions, which clone the stats of other mounts. It's a perk of being the chick that made them, back when I was VWI employee, and we still lived in Meatsville. At other times of the year, her bike drips tiny droplets of water onto the earth below. but now that it's December, snow flurries dance in her wake. The cold air above the city reacts to the tongue of flame

licking out my exhaust with a billow of steam that's absent in the warmer months.

Forty-five minutes later, our bags are packed, and all but one of our group is waiting on the draw bridge in front of Cupcake Keep.

Tako straddles a wind elechopper, "How much food?"

"Same as last time, but it's less important since we don't have to worry about avoiding food in the North Pole."

Mirae pulls a sack of brown liquid from her inventory. "Merry Christmas."

I inspect it, but like most of Pehrom's creations there are no properties listed. "What is it?"

"An early gift from Pehrom."

Tako echoes, "What is it?"

Mirae grins. "Goblin BBQ!"

Lilly looks genuinely shocked, "No way! He figured out the sauce? The hubby's been holding out on me!"

Frobod, our death knight in black Deadplate straddling a black etherchopper, says "If we kill something, we can cook the meat on a fire and it'll still taste good."

Tako kisses Mirae's cheek. "I love you...r husband!" and then turns his gaze to Lilly.

"You can look but no touchin'. That dope is all mine."

It's at that moment that Pehrom exit's the keep and survey's the party. "I see you got the sauce."

Frobod nods, "Thanks man. It'll make being away a lot more comfortable, even if we end up eating BBQ every night."

Pehrom looks to his wife and says, "Sorry again I ain't goin'." He walks closer, and then kisses her on the mouth, a far more tender gesture than I'd have expected from him. "Get out there and kick some ass for me. I'll be here when ya get back."

She puts her arms around him, and bites the little spot where his neck becomes his shoulder, and says "I love you Rob, but don't go starting anymore wars till I get back."

"Get outta here. I ain't gonna burn down the joint." He looks to me. "Send a message when you complete this fucker. Ai'ight? If someone around here comes up with anything that'll help you, I'll pass it along."

Mirae surveys the group. "Is Annette coming here or..."

"Next stop's Dragonswood Forest. She'll be waiting."

The air is cool on our faces on the way to Dragonswood, and as we cross into different zones on the map, snow accumulates in the trees. There are tracks in the snow where rabbits, foxes, and other creatures have left their prints. I should be shivering, but the game preserves our comfort by making the environment brisk, but not bone biting cold since not many people would be happy about having to farm entirely new sets of gear for different seasons. I like to think of it as a magical property of any equipment with bonus stats, because the world certainly does feel cold when you remove all your gear.

I dip beneath the trees of Dragonswood Forest, at the mouth of the Ravine leading to Annette's cottage. "We're here."

Frobod surveys the environment, "Do you want us to come?"

"It's a small place, so it'll probably be better if I get her on my own."

I move down the path. My feet crunch on frosty twigs, and chilled forest debris. I don't even have to open the gate because the door of the cottage swings open, and Annette waves in greeting. She's covered

from head to toe in ruddy fur garments, with a leather backpack on her back. *Even on quests, NPCs dress seasonally.*

"You look warm."

"I am." She eyes my leathers skeptically, "Not sure I can say the same for you. Am I missing something?"

"Magic."

"Ahhhh, magic." Her tone that leaves me wondering if she's mocking my statement. "There's a lot of that here."

"That there is. Are you ready?"

"I am."

"How are the spirits?"

"Good..." She trails.

"Is Magpie going to help us?"

"I think he will."

A bird caws overhead. Black wings flutter, and a Magpie swoops down to Annette's shoulder. It has a ghostly aura, that indicates that he's a spirit rather than an ordinary bird. "Hello." It cocks its head. "Hello."

"Hello." I greet the bird, wondering if it recognizes anything of my Rodekin alt. "The rest of the party is on the main road."

"Earlier this week I had to rescue a fledgling magpie that'd fallen out of its nest. That was the cost of the moonwalk."

"Where is it now?"

She motions back to the cabin, "James is taking care of him. He knows how and what to feed it."

I nod. "Good. That'll help his Repute." She gives me an inquiring look. "Ahh.. If he does that, avian spirits, especially Magpie will like him more, and be more likely to help out in the future."

"Well that's good. I don't want to be the only one neck deep in the mystic woo-woo."

We approach everyone on the elechoppers. "You've all got to learn. I just thought you'd be the best student."

Everyone greets our final party member in a chorus of "Heys," "Hello agains." and "Sups?"

Annette looks to me with a question smeared across her face, "I'm not sure if I should have said this sooner but, I'm Jewish. Is that okay?"

Frobod shifts on his bike, "What difference does that make?"

"You know.. Christmas, Santa Claus. Can I still do Santa? Wasn't sure if there was some kind of religious exclusion."

Lilly says, "Yer in Haven now kid, there ain't no Santa. We got Winterfest and Great Uncle Winter."

Tako pulls a red Santa hat from his inventory and places it on his head. "I don't care what you say. Great Uncle Winter is Santa."

Annette looks to me for clarification. "If it helps, we're progressive Jews. We still did Santa back home. We'd put out the menorah, some 'Ho ho ho!' cookies, and a pile of joints with a card that said 'Dear Santa, Have a happy Hanukkah and smoke our marijuanaka.'" with the hope he'd leave some presents.

Tako perks up. "Did it work?"

With Satan's spinach long decriminalized, the stigma associated with smoking pot has long since evaporated.

Annette grins, "Every year."

Tako regards me, "Can we keep her? Are all Freeworld NPCs this cool?" Mirae gives him a look. "Not like that." He blows his girlfriend a kiss.

She humphs, but the tone is cute rather than put upon. "It better not be."

I give Annette a reassuring pat on the forearm. "You're fine."

Lilly says, "So what do we gotta do?"

I give the Rodekin a look, "Annette?"

The bird on her shoulder says, "Hungry?" in a voice that sounds more hopeful than demanding.

Annette pat's Magpie's head. "You're always hungry." She squats down, and scatters a fist full of nuts onto the road. The corvid happily bounces off her shoulder, on to the ground, ruffling his feathers as he descends. He happily pecks up bits of the offering as the group observes.

"I don't get it. How's watchin' a bird eat gonna help us get to the North Pole? I thought you said Squeks Jr. had it worked out."

"Relax, she does. It's all part of the process."

Annette regards the Goblin, "Actually, I think he's just greedy, but a happy Magpie won't hurt under the circumstances."

"If you say so." I look to Annette. "Now might be a good time to bring up the moonwalk."

She watches Magpie peck up a few more nuts, before starting. "About the moonwalk. We need to go to the North Pole now."

Magpie ignores her while he finishes the rest of his nuts.

Tako asks, "Is he listening?"

I shush him. "Just wait..."

Magpie looks up, and mimics the sound of a big, powerful, smelly burp.

"What have you been teaching him?"

Annette facepalms. "That's all Jason."

The bird shuffles, and cocks his head.

"Moonwalk."

"Yes." I suddenly remember that the bird isn't interested in talking to me, so I gesture to Annette to continue the conversation.

"Yes." She repeats.

Magpie cocks his head, "Go now?"

"I think so." Annette looks to us for confirmation, and several of us nod.

"The price is accepted, the favor repaid."

It's mid morning, and darkness engulfs us like a solar eclipse. A bright path, a pillar of moonlight pierces the murk in the far distance, and the ground beneath our feet illuminates in an ethereal catwalk. The air is no longer cold.

"Everyone go. Keep riding towards the light. Annette, you can ride with me." I straddle big read, and the Rodekin sits behind me.

"Whoa..." Tako takes in the change in scenery.

Lilly looks to the side, no doubt noting how the trees of Dragonswood Forrest grow faint and menacing.

"Do I even want to know what happens if we stray off the path?"

"Probably not."

Frobod revs his Engine, and is the first to advance along the path. In mere seconds the figments of trees become castles, and heartbeats later they're mountains, then a village as splotches of dark color in an impressionistic painting. With every foot we advance, the world beyond the light path twists into new forms.

Annette grips me tighter. "It's chaotic."

I look back over my shoulder. "The spirit world often is. In time you'll be able to come here at will, without the aid of a spirit."

"I can open my own moonwalk?"

"No, but you can physically enter the Astral Plane like a ghost."

"You mean back to Hades?"

I shake my head no. "The spirit worlds are layered on top of each other. The Astral Plane is like... A dimension sandwiched between Hades and the physical world. You can drop in and out of it once you learn, and peer into the real world. It's good for reconnaissance and stealth."

"I've got a lot to learn about being Rodekin."

"All weres can do it."

The darkness surrounding us grows lighter as we near our destination. The moon beam at the end of the path makes everything lighter by comparison to when we started and before long we're riding over oceans and ice as if the moonwalk were a glass bridge connecting our start and finish. I squint as the light stabs brighter. Cold air fills my lungs, and delivers brisk nips to my cheeks.

As I ride off the moonwalk, the last of our group, the darkness to either side fades. Magpie screeches, flaps his wings, and disappears like a specter. White puffs of condensation rise from our mouths, as Lilly says, "It's cold here."

"It's the Arctic."

While it's not quite as cold as the real Arctic, this terrain definitely has more bite than Durolan. It's like running around outside without a hat on a properly snowy day.

Frobod shields the sun with his hands, and looks into the distance. "We're here, so now what?"

"Look for civilization. Anything that looks manmade... a sign... tracks... Anything."

I take the moment to re-read the quest that brought us here.

Quest

Winter Dungeonland - Part 1

Difficulty: Hard

You have found a child's toy with the mark of the reclusive San'ta Elves of the North Pole. Somewhere in the North, someone is looking for this childhood treasure. Find its owner, and discover how this dolly came to be in Hades.

Objectives:

Returned dolly	0/1
Discover origins of dolly	0/1

Chain Completion Rewards (Choose One):

- A unique evolving weapon (Legendary Potential)
- A unique evolving chest piece (Legendary Potential)
- A unique evolving helm (Legendary Potential)
- A unique evolving spell (Legendary Potential)
- Logout re-enabled

Additional Rewards (Limited Edition) (Choose One):

- **Unlock Rebirthing as Ke'bla Elf**
- **Unlock Rebirthing as San'ta Elf**
- **Unlock Rebirthing as Kel'rog Elf**

Restrictions:

Can only be completed in December.

Max party size: 5

This quest can be shared if you have five or less people in your party.

Do you accept? Yes / No

Tako places his hands on his hips, and stands like he's admiring his own masterwork sculpture. "Am I the only one that expected candy cane trees, and giant gingerbread houses?"

Mirae snickers. "Isn't that Hansel and Gretel?"

I shudder, "That's one fairy tale we don't want to be caught up in."

Tako considers with his hand on his chin. "Oh yeah. For some reason I thought they looked the same."

Lilly looks to the east, and slowly turns her head west. "Not to be a downer, but I don't see shit."

Mirae smiles. "Oh, come on. We just got here. We haven't even walked yet."

"Yeah." Tako reinforces. "...but right now all I see is snow and ice."

Frobod looks back to me. "I don't even see mobs."

"I get it, everyone. It's a desolate map. Buff up just in case we run into something. After that, mount up and follow me. Worst case scenario I'll switch to my Rodekin alias, and use the seeking stone." I look to Annette. "Better yet, I'll teach her how to make a seeking stone."

Annette asks, "What's a seeking stone?"

"It's part of a rite that allows you to find a person or object. It requires more bargaining with spirits."

"Buff up, if you need to."

I wipe my hands together, to trigger the macro that triggers a whistling wind sound effect, followed by the thump-bum, thump-bump of a heartbeat.

Enhanced Dexterity.

Dexterity increased by 10%.

Duration: 60 minutes remaining.

Enhanced Vitality.

Regeneration Increased by 10%.

Duration: 60 minutes remaining.

It doesn't take long for me to equip Bite, and push myself through the motions required to cast my Flow Like Water defense. I feel a chill as the spell takes hold, and the cold forces of Yin energy, permeate my body causing it to take on the difficult to grasp qualities of water.

Flow Like Water (10)

Duration: 30 minutes remaining.

Mirae chants, "Re'amus gri atu protectus." and etches a mark into a small... *Soap?* carving.

I raise a brow. "What's that?"

"It's for you." She threads a string through the figurine and hands it for me. "It's for tank and heals, but I don't need it because I'm undying."

I pull up the properties in my VT.

Effigy of Protection (Temporary)*Heku Magic (Level 1)*

Duration: 12 Hours

Description:

This carving looks a bit like you.

"The description's ominous. Should I be afraid?"

Mirae wears a confused expression, "You can't see what it does?"

"It just says that it looks like me."

"Huh. Maybe it's because you don't have access to Heku Magic."

"What does it do?"

"It's a weaker version of Aegis, good for one hit. The next time you take damage that would reduce you to zero health, you go down to one instead."

"Thanks." I put the trinket around my neck.

"Let's hope I don't need it."

"Always better to be prepared."

Frobod says, "What's the plan?"

Lilly dismounts. "I want to walk. Better chance to pick up agro."

Tako groans. "Are you serious? That'll take forever."

"She's a summoner and wants to catch new creatures. Which reminds me..." I pull the contract I prepared after Thanksgiving dinner out of my inventory, "I've got a party contract for you all about her abilities. If you agree, make your mark."

I pass it to Frobod. "Sounds fair to me. Fifty percent of the sale price is way more than we'd get from just picking up loot."

He makes his mark and passes it to Tako, who reads over it and makes his mark. "I'd be pissed if this caused us to miss a random epic item, but I guess we'll never know."

Mirae signs, and hands the document back to me. I'm about to put it back into inventory when Annette says, "What about me?"

"I... err... Okay." I pass her the paper. It hadn't occurred to me that an NPC would want any part of the loot. She touches her finger to the bottom line. A mark appears in the way of red Xs on maps when you ask a guard for directions.

You are bound by the terms of this agreement.

You have received: Signed contract.

"It's done then. Ya could have trusted me, but I promise this is gonna make us all a lot richer."

"It's not that we don't trust you..."

Frobod shrugs, "I like magic contract escrow for automatic distribution. Less running around. As soon as you make the sale, all of our coin pouches get heavier."

"What he said." I echo. "Now that that's done, we're flying."

"Oh, c'mon. There could be anything out there!"

"We're flying for extra speed, but about six feet off the ground. That way, if we see an interesting creature, we can engage and you'll have a chance to catch it. Sound fair?"

Frobod says, "Sounds good to me, as long as we've got speed. I want to get this quest over with."

"Relax. It's the first day. We've got all month."

"Well yeah, but I want to see my daughter. Get out soon enough, and I can even do some Christmas shopping. Make up for that lost birthday party, you know?"

"Yeah..." I trail, his passion shuts me up a moment because I get where he's coming from. Being antisocial in Meatsville sometimes makes me forget that others have important people to get back to. I feel awkward as I say, "You'll see her. I promise."

Lilly says, "I ain't against going back, but I for one am glad to draw it out a bit. Who's got time for holiday bullshit, when you can come back just in the nick of time and everyone's so happy to see you that they forget that you haven't had time to do Christmas shopping, put up a tree, or prepare a roast."

Tako has genuine surprise in his voice, "Your husband makes you cook? Pehrom's a god in the kitchen."

"He didn't tell you? He can't cook anymore after a scuba accident."

Tako slaps his forehead with the palm of his hand, "Fail. He told us but I totally forgot since he's always in the kitchen."

Mirae smiles and hugs his arm. "I'm sure he appreciates that."

Frobod says, "Isn't it intimidating cooking for a real chef?"

"It ain't a problem. I got a good teacher."

"Alright everyone mount up. I'll take point."

Lilly hops on her bike behind me. Annette starts to resume her position. "Wait. Do you mind riding with Mirae? I'll be in the middle of any fighting, and I still don't know what you can do. "

Mirae gives Annette a welcoming smile. "I'm on heals, so I can teach you something."

"Fine with me." Annette gets on the back of Mirae's bike, "I trust you."

"Move out."

I lift off the ground, and advance at our bike's impressive 600% ground speed. The wind makes my cheeks feel tender. The reflection of the snow beneath our flying wheels is uncannily bright as it reflects the sun.

I switch to speaking in party chat, so we don't have to scream over the wind in our ears. Everyone else hears my words as if they were wearing headphones. "See anything?"

"Nothin' to tame if that's what your askin'."

Frobod motions with his gauntleted hand. "Just the same mountain in the distance that you can see."

"That's as good a point of reference as any. Keep going."

"Is it me, or does it feel like we're moving faster when we're flying so close to the ground?"

I look over my shoulder at Tako, "It always feels like that."

Even though there's no contact with the ground, our passage whips up snow powder cyclones beneath us. It's rather pretty.

Mirae says, "On the bright side, we're not leaving tracks for anyone to follow."

Lilly responds, "Sounds like an argument for going back on the ground. I want to tame something."

I look to the goblin, "Cool it, there'll be plenty of..." My stomach jumps as the ground suddenly disappears beneath me. Instead of six feet above the surface, We now a good sixty feet up. "Whoa!"

No other exclamations, but Frobod's kind enough to slow his pace. "You okay?"

"Sorry I wasn't looking ahead and this pit caught me totally by surprise. It just sort of jumped into my vision."

"I didn't notice either until we were going over. All the snow makes it hard to distinguish the landscape."

Mirae cups a hand to her ear, "Do you hear that?"

Frobod shrugs. "Don't look at me. I'm only human."

I try to focus. Mirae's full elven ears are superior to Tako's and my own half elven ones, but... yes... There's something. Faint, but an undeniable crash crash crash. "I hear it too... Farther into the chasm around the bend. Let's go down. Be ready to pull back up in case of an avalanche."

We descend far enough that the sun no longer hammers against my face, but we're still a good fifteen feet off the ground. The steep icy walls provide shade.

"Be gone abominations!" A woman's voice.
SNAP! CRASH! CRASH! "Be ready for incoming."

Completely ignoring my original plan, I drop to the chasm floor, dismount and clinch Bite ready for an attack. Thankfully the ground is rocky rather than icy. I run around the corner, and see a young woman with white hair, in an ethereal blue gown waving her hands in intricate patterns of spellwork. Her back's to me, and to the rest of the party. She jerks her hand, giant icicles drop from the sky above shattering against the earth.

Lilly says, "What's she attacking?"

I don't know. I look over my shoulder to see that the entire party's joined me.

The woman calls, "I will not stand for this!" She throws her right hand forward, and back again like the end of a whip. A blast of bright blue cold energy

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explodes against a large furry creature. No signs of motion.

Mirae calls, "Hey, are you okay?"

I check the woman's name plate.

Winter

Type:	NPC
Race:	Elemental Spirit
Appearance:	21
Challenge:	?????

Winter breathes heavily. "Thank Frost, adventurers! You're just in time. I'm quite tired, so early in the season. It's not right..."

Frobod shouts, "Incoming!"

Farther down the chasm, a horde of furry bodies charges straight at us. They are an odd mix of man and... beaver, wide paddle tails, only instead of cute buck teeth, each one sports Nosferatu fangs. Their eyes burn with azure coldfire, and small icicles dangle from red and brown fur.

Corrupted Kryobeaver

Type:	NPC
Race:	Beastkin
Appearance:	1
Challenge:	??

Winter groans, "There's no end to them!
Quick, engage so I can recover and finish them once
and for all."

"All in! Tank and spank until we know otherwise!
Give me five seconds from first hit to grab agro."

Shadow Step (Rank 5) - Failure.

Caliber of Success: 0

What the shit? I've never failed a Shadow Step before. I sigh and rush in the old fashioned way, fast footsteps on stone, with Bite sparking and crackling with electricity in my hands.

I come in with a low strike that smashes against the first creature's skull, wires of electricity reach out, and spider over the creatures neighbors, taunting everything in their path, so that all their attention is on me. They're small enough that I can leap over their heads with a running start. I do a back walkover to put some distance between myself and the attackers, and do just that, vaulting into the air, and soaring over their furry heads. I'm now behind them.

A cluster of three Kryobeavers seem to have been outside the area of effect radius of Bite's taunt,

because their running for Mirae. I rush in for another hit to ensure their attention is mine. CRUNCH!

CRITICAL HIT!

You hit Corrupted Kryobeaver for 23 points of damage.

You have Killed Corrupted Kryobeaver.

The creature doesn't have time to squeal before it's a red smear against the frigid Earth. Its companions don't seem to care about their fallen, as they trample the body to get to me. I back toward the nearest wall so I can't be taken by surprise by any adds.

"All in!" I begin the incantation for my newest Paladin spell. , "Lord Sune, God of Lightning, God of Travel, hear my call and consecrate this land."

Cast Circle of Blessings (Rank 2) - Success!

It's hard to see from where I'm standing, but I know whiskers of holy and electric energy are reaching up from the ground to periodically sting my opponents, and keep their violence directed at me.

I go full defensive until I know what we're dealing with. As a dexterity based tank in leather armor,

my primary job, aside from keeping the mobs' attention is to not get hit since I lack the benefit of plate armor.

A furry clawed hand swings at my face, well, reaches for my chin since they are so much shorter. I dip out of the way. Another Kryobeaver with a blue glowing dagger goes for my stomach, but I step back just in time. I duck out of the way of a thrown hunk of ice, waiting for the sound Winter's frost magic and heavy DPS engagement.

A little 3 in the top right corner of my vision tells me that I've dodge three times, when it gets up to five, if one of my opponents ever hits me, a magical blast will rebound on my attacker. It's like rubbing your socks on the carpet and building up static to shock someone with your finger.

Frobod crashes into the beavers' flank, swinging his greatsword wildly. A squishy grating sound paints his blade in red. Tako doesn't fail his Shadow Step, and appears at the other side of the crowd needling the beavers from behind. Aside from heals, Lilly's the only one not directly engaged, though she has two knives, one in each hand. The one on the right glows with hot yellow energy.

I duck out of the way of another hunk of ice thrown by one of the rearmost man-beavers, spin Bite, and smash it into the creature closest to me. It releases a high pitched "Uggggghhhhh!" sounds, but doesn't fall like my first target. That's fine, because damage isn't my primary objective as spidery lightning hops from his body, into a trio of his friends, and all of their friends.

Taunt successful.

Lilly slashes down with the glowing weapon, cutting a black rip in the air in front of her. A big, red, gnarled hand grips the edge of the rip like a monster coming out of a tent. A warped head with blood colored skin, goat horns and eyes of sunset peeks out. "Go get em' stony!"

Stone Throwing Devil

Type: NPC (Summoned)

Race: Devil

Appearance: 1

Challenge: Difficult

The monster grunts, and pulls itself out of the goblin's rip in the air as though an unseen being was giving birth. It stands a frightening seven feet tall. "I've got a rock."

Lilly indicates the Kryobeavers with the tip of her knife, and rushes in for the attack. "Assist!"

"Okay." The devil pulls his hand back like a Mariners' pitcher, and sends a stone the size of a melon flying. A splatter of red tickles the swarm of enemies, as his target loses it's face and moves no more. The devil reaches down into the earth with his bare hand. The stone cracks and shrieks in protest. "I've got a rock." He doesn't need additional instruction, as he readies to chuck another stone.

I'm pretty sure it's all just melee at this point, so I become more aggressive stepping toward the Kryobeavers, swinging Bite around the outside of my body, and bringing my left hand in to deliver a hard low blow to my nearest opponent. CRUNCH.

I think I broke something. More electric spiders crawl over the mobs. A dagger wielding foe comes in to cut me, I parry, and counterattack sending another wave of electricity through the group.

Another splash of red and a pained death cry tells me that Frobod's finished off another target. I spare a glance toward Winter having expected ice based attacks, but she's standing in an orb of magical cold energy with her hair flying around her. *I guess we're supposed to do this on our own.*

WHAM!

I collapse another Kryobeaver under the massive force of my staff. A wave of heat rolls over me, as Lilly stabs one of the monsters with her dagger causing it to catch fire. It's still burning, and it shrieks. *Damage over time magic.*

"We've got this. Keep doing what you're doing!" Two opponents strike in unison, and I'm able to evade with a quick step back. The dodge counter on my boots is now maxed to five, and has been for a while.

One of the Kryobeavers with the glowing blue knives comes in for a strike and connects. An arc of electricity leaps from the soles of my boots into him shaving off a sliver of its health. It yelps in pain. Although my flesh twists and reshapes around the blade as it enters to negate the damage with my Flow Like Water defense, my vision goes blue, and sound becomes muffled. *What the hell?* I can't move, and I'm cold enough to shiver. A new debuff appears in the corner of my vision.

Frozen

Duration: 20 seconds remaining.

Hell! What kind of immobility debuff lasts for 20 seconds in combat?

That's like a century in battle time. I can see everyone moving and fighting around me, but I can't speak or move. Another stone collides with a Kryobeaver lifting it off its feet, and knocking down one of its fellows. It doesn't move, but its companion struggles to its feet just in time for Tako to appear behind and cut its throat. Mirae, standing near Winter with Annette, has also joined the battle, losing arrows in streaks of green magic into the monsters.

Lily makes a gesture that consists of three jerks of her hand using a blade, and a giant fireball comes flying at me. *Shit! What the?* I'm getting flashes of Laurelade's friendly fire all over again, only instead of taking damage the bitter cold of the frozen debuff, is replaced with the warmth of a hearth fire. My clothes feel a little wet but I've taken no damage and my vision is no longer tinted blue. *I can move.*

"Thanks!"

We're now down to three kryobeavers.

Frobod decapitates one with his great sword, sending a whip of crimson through the air. *Make that two.*

"You can thank me by lettin' me catch one of em'!"

"You heard her!" I dodge out of the way of another dagger attack. My dodge counter rises to 1.

"Drop one and leave the other."

Lilly's dagger pulses with malignant red energy, as she sinks it into the back of the opponent that just tried to stab me. Black veins streak over his body. It's eyes bulge. A punished, "Uhhh!" and the kryobeaver explodes in a shower of liquid rust. Somehow, none of the gore ends up on my face. The weapon's glow fades after the attack.

Just one more. "What do you need me to do?"

"Keep dodgin' till it stops fighting and focuses on me. First we gotta lower it's health to less than 20%."

Kryobeaver Health: 40%.

"I've got a rock."

A stone smashes into the creature's torso reducing it's health to 10 percent and knocking it off its feet. The creature looks dazed.

"Awesome! You go stony!" She regards me and says, "I'll take it from here." The goblin sheathes one of

her daggers, and reaches for a pouch that's been dangling at her belt. She pours the contents, a black powder, into her knobby hand and then throws it over her head. Instead of the dust flying about randomly it settles on the earth in a perfect circle encasing a twelve pointed star. The goblin stands at one end, and the kryobeaver hunches at the other. The lines of the design glimmer with red and gold magic.

I'd expected some kind of conversation, but a streamer of grey smoky energy connects Lilly's forehead to that of the beaver-man. She makes conversational motions with her hands, but it shakes its head no. She makes more gestures without words, though I can imagine her pointing out the benefits of a pact. The creature's shoulders slump.

CRACK. The earth protests to my right, as the devil reaches its fist into the ground. "I've got a rock."

I shout, "Don't do that!" but it's too late. An earthen missile collides with the kryobeaver's breast. The binding circle vanishes.

"Oh my God, I almost had him! I told you to assist!"

"I assisted." He sounds pouty.

"Ya don't attack when I have a circle out. Ya wanna go home early?"

The Stone Throwing Devil hangs his head.

"No."

The pitiful scolded voice coming from such a massive body makes me laugh. Frightful as his appearance may seem, the devil's voice is more like a teddy bear.

"Now we ain't got no more ice beavers."

Tako says, "Kryobeavers."

"Whateva!"

Frobod begins gathering loot as the creatures despawn leaving small chests and coin purses in their wake. "What's done is done. There'll be more monsters later."

"Anything good?" A few silver are added to everyone's inventory.

"Common armor. Nothing magical. We can split the vendor items up when we get back."

Lilly says, "If this were realistic, we'd be able to take one of those ice daggers they used to freeze Mel."

"That'd be too easy. I'm happy with this level of realism."

BOOM. BOOM. BOOM. Massive footsteps.
BOOM. BOOM. BOOM.

"Incoming! Here we go again!" The lumbering form of a thirty foot tall giant rounds the bend further

up the chasm. I look to Winter. She's still recovering in her bubble of magic. Unlike most giants, this appears to be a creature of ice rather than flesh and blood. "Use fire if you have it!"

I unleash a loud whistle, and spin Bite around my body. "Over here!"

Taunt. Successful.

Behemoth Frostlord attacks.

CRACK. THUMP. BOOM. BOOM. BOOM.

The ground shakes as it runs at me. Mirae looses a green arrow that chips away some of it's body, but doesn't slow the Frostlord. Lilly weaves an intricate pattern with her daggers, which grow redder and hotter with every stroke, before launching a blast of fire like a jack-o-lantern at our attacker.

"Worry not allies. I've almost enough power. Just a little bit..."

The last word is drowned out by the sound of an icy fist crashing into my body, and obliterating the last of my Flow Like Water defense. My flesh can't reshape around it all, and my health drops by thirty percent.

"Oof!" On top of that, there's knockback, as I slam into the chasm wall, I'm dazed for a few seconds

as a wave of dizziness comes over me. I snap out of it just in time to roll out of the way of an enormous ice encrusted foot.

Frobod's launching black necrobolts at range rather than attacking with his greatsword, and even Tako's switched to a bow. Probably a good thing, since giant monsters usually have some kind of ground stomp AoE. Little bits of ice tumble off the frostlord's body when arrows hit, but so far as I can tell only Lilly's fireballs and Frobod's necrobolts are making a difference.

The frostlord cups his hands together and attempts to crush me under an awkward, squatting two handed fist pound. It's slow, and not difficult to avoid by scurrying out of the way. The giant stands at full height again. He kicks. I dodge, just in time so that his front of his foot smashes into the stone wall rather than my chest.

Our opponent groans its frustration, "Noooo... Be still little ones."

Winter says, "Just a bit longer."

I hope she's got something good, because DPS has been hammering this thing, I've been hit, and the mob's still at ninety percent health. Green light and the smell of cherry blossoms stirs around me as Mirae

lands her first heal. My health creeps up to eighty, then ninety than one hundred percent.

"Good work!" a single hand reaches down to grab me, which I have to tumble to avoid.

"Be still..." The frostlord rumbles.

A big fiery blast sends droplets of water flying through the air like an early spring rain.

Frostlord health: 80%.

The frostlord protests. "It... hurts..."

"Good work Lilly!"

The frostlord stomps. The foot's so large I have to leap out of the way, but I remain unharmed. Another fireball lands, spritzing me with a curtain of melted ice.

"Thank you, adventurers. Stand back and I'll finish this once and for all."

I don't know what Winter has up her sleeve, but that's an order of retreat if I've ever heard one. I turn back the direction we came, and run, leaping over large hunks of rock that stand in the way. The passage burns with blinding blue light as Winter extends her palm and hits the behemoth in his core mass.

KA-CRASH!

His chest explodes in a tsunami of shattered ice crystals, some fly up and out peppering us from even

our far distance, but most collapse into a wide mound of crushed ice.

Quest Update: Taming the Rage Babies

You've encountered Winter, a powerful nature spirit, and have gained her favor. Teach Annette to gain repute so that she may become one of her spirit guides.

Completion:

Spirit Bond Formed 0/1

Rewards:

Winter's assistance in your quest

I walk to Annette, brushing small ice pellets out of my hair. "She's a spirit like Magpie."

"Really?"

I nod, and regard Winter. "This isn't normal?"

Frodo rests his blade on his shoulder, "I'm surprised to see you fighting cold monsters."

Now that we're not combating a horde of kryobeavers and an ice giant, I see that Winter's eyes are the clearest blue, and although she wears an ethereal gown, she lacks legs to walk upon the earth. She glides towards us.

"The seasonal balance has been disrupted, and the cold is too strong."

Tako joins our gathering with Mirae and says,
"Isn't that a good thing for you?"

"Yes, I have more raw power. I can attack with more force, but fighting these aberrations drains me quickly. In the coming months I must sleep and make way for my sister."

Tako trails, "...and?"

"I will be unable if the balance isn't restored. Something corrupts this land, and would place me in a state of eternal wakefulness."

Tako says, "That sounds like a pretty good deal from your perspective."

"How would you feel if you couldn't sleep, mortal? Exhausted, unable to protect your own domain."

I motion Annette to my side, "We don't have domains, but I think I see the problem."

"I've already invested far more of my energy combating the corrupted than I should have by this time of year. How long before I run out?"

I look to the Rodekin. "This is a good opportunity. Offer to help, and form a relationship. If you become close she'll act as your spirit guide."

"What about Magpie?"

"You can have more than one guide, and he's not your personal guide yet. It's uncommon for someone with your lack of experience with the spirits to have this kind of opportunity. Winter and her sisters, Spring, Summer and Autumn are greater spirits. Talk to her. She can help you a lot in the future."

Uncertainty laces Annette's voice, "Is there something we can do to help?"

"There is, child of Rat."

"She probably wants us to investigate the source of the corruption."

Annette nods in understanding. "Do you want us to find out what's wrong?"

"Yes, but not now. First..." Winter yawns, "I need more power. I need to supplement my reserves before I run out. Every battle against the corrupted drains me... and now..." She yawns again. "I'm very tired."

"How do we do that?"

"Ureota, the frost wyrm guardian of San'ta Vale, has been corrupted. The hearts of dragons and dragon kin are ripe with spirit power. Find Ureota, guardian of San'ta Vale, slay him, and make an offering of his heart. In so doing you weaken the corrupted, and provide me with the magic I need to endure this crisis."

Tako pumps his fist. "Yes! More dragons."

"Wyrms don't have arms or legs. Close enough though... It'll probably count toward the Dragonsbane quest."

A look of surprise creeps into Annette's face.
"You just want us to kill a dragon?"

"I'll resurrect him when balance is restored. As of now, in his corrupted state, he is an adversary."

Sounding surprised, Annette says, "You can do that?"

"Frost wyrms are of the cold, and thus within one of my domains. I will resurrect him when this is done." A note of pleading enters Winter's voice. "For now... I desperately need more power."

Frobod sheathes his sword and places it on his back. "Sounds like a plan. How do we get there?"

"Keep traveling north and you'll find the entrance to a vale outside of which Ureota resides."

I unroll my map. "Any chance you can mark it for us?"

The spirit takes a long time examining the parchment, as if unfamiliar with this brand of human invention. A good thirty or forty-five seconds later, she extends an index finger, beneath which a blue snowflake icon appears. "Here. This is where you're most likely to find him."

I look at the map and murmur, "There's a lot of unexplored territory between here and there."

Lilly chimes in with a "No problem. As long as we got a compass and see the destination, we'll find it."

Annette bows, in the courtly fashion of Dragonswood Keep. "I'll do my best."

I chuckle. "Most spirits aren't familiar enough with our customs to understand bowing, but it's good that you're showing respect."

Winter yawns again, long, and wide. "Hurry. The sooner I replenish my reserves the better."



Chapter 7 - Icebeard

We exit the pit as easily as we came, all of us on elechoppers and Annette's arms wrapped around Mirae from behind. With the end of combat, the stone throwing devil returns from whence he came.

We're again using party chat while in motion. The Rodekin says, "I can't help but feel useless with all of you fighting."

"I'd like for you to learn healing but aside from Winter we haven't had that many spirits around for instruction."

"Mirae taught me some basic spells, but you barely need it."

"Trust me, there will be bigger battles, and when I need it, I'll really need it."

"So you just want me to stand around until then?"

I sigh. "I'm trying to avoid you getting hit. I know what it's like to fight as a Rodekin and it's not pretty. One minute you're good, the next you're ripping apart your nearest ally."

Mirae says, "I could teach her the bow."

"Do you have an extra one?"

"I've still got the old one."

"It ain't my quest or nuthin', but I could also teach her dagger hexin'."

I spare Annette a glance, "You have options." I then look to Lilly, keeping my bike moving straight ahead five feet above the ground. Swirls of light snow scatter with our passing. "It's a great opportunity to level your mentorship ability."

"Good point. Few extra points to spend never hurt anyone." The goblin spares looks to Annette, "So what do ya wanna learn, healin' or hexin'?"

"Can I do both until I figure out what I like more?"

"Do you have any Freeworld magic?"

She shakes her head no, "Not aside from being Rodekin."

Speaking to the goblin, I ask, "Do you have mentorship?"

"Level two."

"Teach her some of the basics once we stop since she already has a couple of spells from Mirae. That's enough for the basics. If you're lucky, teaching a few spells will bump you up to level three."

Shapes take form in the distance. "Can you see that?"

Frobod shrugs. "You're vision's better than mine. I'd say people, animals, and a big... something."

My ears perk. "I hear something."

I can see Mirae concentrating, "It sounds like an elephant, with a bit more bass."

"Keep going."

As we draw nearer it's not an elephant that takes shape, but a mountain of thick brunette fur with a bearded trunk. The distant rumble of the animal's sound moves tension in the air. Metal caps affixed to deadly tusks reflect the sunlight. It's an animal ready for war.

A stubby, bushy eyebrowed dwarf with a beard that reaches down to his belly button greets us from a saddle atop a blanket on the creature's back. Little icicles dangle from his upper lip, whereas larger ones freeze the hair beneath his chin. He's covered head to toe in warm furs, not unlike Annette's. I can't tell what kind - I've never been to the Arctic, but whatever the

animal, it had a silver salt and pepper pelt. They are well made garments stitched into a proper cape, britches, and coat.

"Hellooooo down there." His voice has a nice bass rumble, flavored by a hearty brogue.

Not very often a dwarf's in a position to say that.

We look up still hovering above the ground, but no where near the height of the mammoth. "Err. Hello."

His mount's breath is like quiet thunder when not making baritone elephant trumpets and rumbles.

"Not many travelers this far North. Where are ye goin'?"

Lilly lifts farther off the ground so she's on level height with the newcomer, "What's it to you?"

The dwarf chuckles, his white teeth stand out against the dark fur of his face. "Not here to harm ye. Got plenty of other monsters around here to do that."

"Coulda fooled me. This place is barren. Found a bunch of demonic ice beavers a few miles back, but there ain't been nothin' to catch since."

I look to Lilly, "It's fine. If he was hostile he'd have attacked already."

"At least one of ye's got common sense.

Krynn Icebeard at your service."

"Nice to meet you Krynn. If I may ask, what are you doing so far North by your lonesome self?"

"The North's me home, and I'm a trader. "

Tako says, "Then why aren't you peddling your wares?"

A look of childlike excitement creeps into his craggy face, "Were you looking to buy?"

Tako scoffs, "No."

Annette scowls and raises her hand like she's about the slap the shit out of Taco. "Hold up!"

Tako's eyes go wide in an exaggerated cartoony 'oops!' expression, I'm actually impressed Annette's kept her cool this long with that Rodekin rage riding in her veins. When I play a Rodekin I'm spitting temper every two seconds due to the rage venting meter.

I raise a halting hand to Tako. "What do you need?"

"If I'm gonna learn the green girl's style of magic, I need a proper dagger right? All I have is a general purpose folding knife. It's not made for combat."

I'm again surprised how much like a normal party member Annette seems, opposed to an NPC.

"Squeaks Jr.'s gotta head on her shoulders."

Lilly looks to the Dwarf, "What ta ya got?"

"A bow would be good too so I don't have to use someone else's."

"Probably best if you come to my camp and take a look."

I give him the stink eye. "I appreciate that you haven't attacked, but if you were a bandit, this'd be an ideal way to set an ambush."

Krynn clutches his chest like he's been shot with an arrow. "Ye wound me!"

"Then what are you doing out here alone, away from your wares?"

"I've got guards. I'm just taking everyone for a walk." He pats the mammoth's head.

Frobod unsheathes his greatsword, anticipating a trap. "Everyone?"

Krynn, raises his hands in a placating gesture. "Hey. None of that. Look!" He releases a loud wolf whistle that sets my nerves on end. I join Frobod in equipping Bite. "Just wait, just wait, they're comin'."

An explosion of white fur wooshes in front of my face, hitting me with a rush of cold air as if I'd narrowly missed my death date with a bullet train. Another white blur streaks by, and loops around the mammoth.

It's only when they choose to stop running that I make out two enormous white direfoxes waving their bushy tails like propellers. It's eerie how well their coats allow them to blend with the environment because on four legs, they're taller than anyone in our party. Standing on hind legs with their forepaws against the mammoth's wooly haunch, they can nearly touch the dwarf's outstretched hand. Their tails continue beating back and fourth as long pink tongues loll out of vulpine grins.

"Ye see? This is everyone. Part of everyone anyway."

"There are more?"

Krynn nods. "Four more running around." He whistles again. "Bosko! Get over here!" The piercing note hurts my ears.

Annette looks incredulous. "Bosko?"

The dwarf points. "Over there."

The arctic fox camouflage is near perfect in the snow, but I make out the black nose and eyes of a third animal running toward us. It's almost to the mammoth when another direfox leaps at it from the side. The two massive animals roll in the snow, play biting. Their sounds are high pitch and squeaky like a kazoo; so far from the sharp barks and menacing growls of dogs.

Mirae says, "I think we can trust him."

I'm getting the same idea. "Yeah?"

"They're adorable! The guy taking care of these guys isn't going to murder us at his camp."

In a tone of levity, Tako responds, "Direfoxes need food too."

I sigh and put my staff away. "It's fine. Give him a chance. Worst case scenario we get sent for respawn."

Mirae says, "I can't die, remember."

"Oh yeah, forgot about that. Worst case scenario, we all die except Mirae, who resurrects me, so we can both work on resurrecting everyone else."

She eyes me skeptically. "I don't think it'll come to that."

"Ye believe me now?"

"Yeah, we're good." I look to Frobo. "Put the sword away."

"Alright." The dwarf seems a touch less cheerful than when he greeted us. "Let's go to camp and where ye can see me barge."

It takes a hand full of minutes to get to his camp which is nestled between a huge snow bank beside a frozen lake. At first I don't see any guards, but then I realize a quartet of ice golems are perched at each corner of a massive sled big enough to tow a small

house. They're frozen humanoid constructs with heads like barbute helmets, and bulky clear bodies that remind me of 1950s robots. Two carry impressive transparent longswords, and the others are armed with intimidating crystalline spears.

Lilly presses her palm to one of the constructs. Faster than you'd think, it takes a step back and levels a spearhead at her. The best way I can describe the movement is precise, a single quick motion that did what it needed to get the job done... in this case ward Lilly off. "If only I could catch one of these guys."

"Ye interested in a deal? I can make more, and bind any of these so they're permanent."

"Actually, I might. I'm a collector. What'll it cost me to scoop up all four of em."

The goblin pales at the price quoted. "Maybe just one, or if I can come back later for a pick up..." She trails in frustration. "Sheesh, ain't you ever heard of a bulk discount?"

Krynn grins, flashing pearly whites behind his beard. He stirs, stands on his saddle, and then leaps to the ground like a cannonball. A puff of white fills the air as he lands on two powerful stubby legs.

"You think on it while I help this other lass." He bows to Annette. *I guess we know who's his favorite.*

"I have some of the finest blades in Arctica." For some reason, this makes Annette wince, but Krynn doesn't see it because he's already walking around on his snow barge looking for the right crate. "Ah! Here we are." He withdraws a blade that glows with phosphorescent blue, and that casts flurries of minute snowflakes as he sweeps it through the air. "The best darksteel with the best frost enchantment. What do you think? It has a twin if you're interested in a set."

Annette takes it in her hand and examines it. "It's cold."

"No shit Sherlock." She suddenly looks like she's about to throw it at Tako.

I ask, "How much is it?"

"Oh I suppose I could let this one go for say, fifteen hundred gold. Twenty five, if you want the set."

"Fifteen hundred gold? That's insane."

"It's a good price. Straight from the forge of my uncle Thoram Icebeard."

Tako says, "Is that supposed to mean something to us?"

Krynn clutches his chest as if having a heart attack. "You wound me! How can you not know the likes of Thoram Icebeard, the greatest smith in all Arctica?"

Frobod chuckles. "Reminds me of dinner theater. I have an uncle too. He's always good for a laugh."

"Awww... Ye mean to mock me? Ask anyone ye pass and you'll know. Icebeard blades are the very best."

With a smirk Frobod says, "We haven't seen anyone else, so we'll take your word for it."

I eye Frobod. "You're happy."

"Yeah... I guess I am. Something about seeing him take the blade out of the box reminded me of Christmas, and pretty soon that's where I'll be. Christmas in Vegas with my little girl. There's the whole ritual of putting gifts out under the tree and setting everything up so it's just right. For a few minutes every year you actually believe you *are* Santa, and munch on those milk and cookies. The next morning you're tired because you stayed up too late, and of course she wants to be up at the crack of dawn. It's all worth it because of that look on her face. The kind that can still believe in Santa. I'm still eager to get back but... feeling good at the same time, ya know?"

"You don't believe in Santa?" Annette asks.

I look to Frobod. "Yeah I know." I feel a smirk tugging at my mouth, because in Freeworld, however

much more like a post apocalyptic real world it might be, there's still a real bearded guy in a jolly red suit. "He's more of a myth where we come from. Parents pretend to be Santa, and set out toys for their kids."

The truth is, in spite of my words, I know no such thing regarding Frodo's experience... at least not on an emotional level. Getting back in time for Christmas would mean chilling by my lonesome with scented candles, and a warm sweater before logging back in to a game to hang out with my friends. I haven't actually visited family for the holidays in about three years. We were more about togetherness for a few years after Jordan's death, but this, like all things faded with time. We just aren't the most social bunch, and with one less family member to round up... I don't know. We've drifted to different parts of the country, for a while I was overseas... There just seems less of a point trying so hard to get everyone together. As a result, somewhere in that busy holiday schedule I'd find time to make the obligatory calls to my parents and sibs. At the same time, I feel a warmth knowing that he does have that to look forward to. *Second hand holiday cheer.*

Annette says, "It's a nice weapon, but it's way too much for me. I'm just beginning. What do you have for a beginner bow and daggers?"

That's probably the most un-gamer thing she's said since we left since the average adventurer would automatically jump at the most impressive weapon even if they were just learning.

"Ahh.." A note of disappointment sounding in Krynn's voice. "Well here's a pair of low magic daggers to get you started. They're good steal, but an apprentice did the spellwork."

"And a bow?"

"This one here should do the trick. Small magic, it'll allow you to draw faster, and become more aware of your surroundings." I can't read the stats since Annette's the one he's negotiating with, but my guess is that the stats are only plus one or two to dexterity and perception. "You can have the lot for say... seventy five gold."

Annette gives him a self satisfied smile and says, "Make it 70 and you've got a deal."

I wonder how she obtained the money.

"Done. Not too many foreign trainees here in Arctica. I'll even throw in a quiver and basic arrows. No magic on em."

"Thanks!"

I look to Lilly who's still ogling the ice golem, but I get the feeling she doesn't have enough money to pay for it. "Now that that's settled, we need to figure out how to get to San'ta Vale."

"San'ta Vale ye say?"

"That's where we're heading."

"Ye don't want to go there. I've got a delivery to the elves but it's too dangerous. Imps, corrupted snow creatures, and that damned Ureota has gone over to the dark."

"What do you know about it?"

The dwarf shrugs. "Best I can tell the source of the problem is in or around the Vale."

"We've got our own business with Ureota."

"You'd best cancel. He was surly on the best of days, but now? He'd just as soon have you for breakfast."

Lilly releases a longing sigh, and turns away from the ice golem, "I take it ya don't mean as guests."

"Ye'd be correct in that assumption."

"You got shipments, and we gotta go there regardless. Sounds to me like we oughta be workin' together."

Frobod says, "She's right, where's the delivery?"

Krynn examines his gloves. "Somewhere in that area."

"What you ain't gonna tell us? We can't help you so well if you don't say where we're goin'."

"It's not that I don't want to tell you, it's just... client confidentiality. They're secretive folk."

I fish through my inventory and withdraw the mangled dolly, a little ragdoll toy, in a red Santa Claus dress, dirty and burnt with pointed ears like an elf.

"If it's anything, we've got other business in the area after Ureota."

"What kind of business?"

"We have to return this to it's owner."

"Let me see that." Krynn holds out his gloved hand. I place the dolly in his palm. "Well, this has seen better days. Where'd you find it?"

"Hades." I say flatly.

"Well that explains it. Can't see adventurers coming all the way up here for a doll found anywhere else."

"Can you help us."

Tako snickers as Krynn looks under the toy's skirt. "Perv."

"This is Old Fiodrill's work."

I raise a brow. "You know the maker?"

"Do I know the maker? Of course I know. How do you not know? He's the greatest doll maker in all Arctica."

Tako looks between me and Krynn with a questioning expression on his face. "Is everyone in Arctica famous or something?"

Frobod says, "I guess when there's not many people there's not so much competition to be the best."

"Ai'ight... I believe ye." Krynn sighs. "But I'm not taking you in the village. We go to Santa Vale together. You handle your business with Ureota while I speak to the long ears themselves."

"But..." Frobod starts.

"I'm sworn to secrecy, and I'm not risking my trade for a bunch of adventurers. If they allow one exception, we'll meet again and I'll lead ye to the village. Fair?"

"Fair." I repeat. "So what all do you need from us in this partnership?"

"I've got four ice golems, but I wouldn't risk them all with the dangers along the way. I need ye all to work with the foxes to make sure my wares are safe."

"Caravan guarding..."

"Again." Tako says.

Mirae smiles. "I wasn't with you last time, but I think this'll be totally different. We're not on a train, and we get to work with awesome foxes."

Frobod says, "Those foxes were pretty fast. Think they can outpace our mounts?"

"Look at ye, so adorable. Everyone knows a direfox is the fastest creature in Arctica."

The death knight nods, "Like a cheetah then."

"I don't know anything about these cheetahs, but me foxes are damned fast."

"It's a cat. Very fast."

"These animals won't be outrun by some damn cat. Who are ye? You're like a baby, don't know anything about the arctic"

Frobod accepts the teasing, "You're right. We don't. So I'm glad we found you."

"Let's give it an hour to eat, and pack up. Then we're on the move."



Chapter 8 - Mush!

We all munch on dry rations rather than preparing anything. If we're gonna use Pehrom's special BBQ sauce, I want time to enjoy it. Lilly's teaching Annette the basics of dagger casting.

"Alright! Mentorship up to three! I can teach level two spells now."

"Good for you." I say, "That could be useful in the future."

"Yeah well, my student ain't half bad. She'll master this in no time."

Annette looks pleased with herself.

"How're you coming with the bow?"

"I've got the basics from Dragonswood, but Mirae says she'll give me pointers when we fight."

"Sounds like you're taken care of."

"Ye all ready to go?"

"We're good I think?" I spare a glance for the rest of the impatient party who look like they'd like to be on their way. "We're good."

I wave my middle finger in the air and call "INFERNO!!" It's the macro I crated to summon my fire chopper. Before I have time to complete the second gesture to call all the other bikes Krynn interrupts me.

"What in the cold blazes is that?"

"It's my bike, you saw me ride it."

"Yes I know, but why is it here? Didn't I tell you? Yer riding foxes."

"I thought...."

Krynn shakes his head. "Put it away. It'll only slow us down."

"They're pretty fast."

The dwarf rolls his eyes. "Care to place a wager on it?"

Lilly jumps in. "I'll take that bet. Mel, call me a bike."

I look to the goblin, "You can just use this one."

"Ai'ight." Krynn looks Lilly over as she takes her seat on Big Red, and then whistles. "Bosko!" The huge direfox pads over. Looking up at it's chin from my

standing position, I'm glad these magnificent beasts are on our side. "First one to the other side of the lake and back wins."

"Can I go over water?"

"Do whatever ye want. It won't matter. Winner...." He trails.

"I want fifty percent off one of those ice golems!"

"Agreed, and if I win..." He mulls it over. "I feel almost bad taking yer money. I've seen you teaching. If I win, ye have to teach me one of the spells from yer repertoire." He pauses. "No restrictions."

"Hey, I can't teach everything in my spell book. I ain't that good of an instructor, but I promise if I can do it, any spell I know how to teach is yours... That's pretty much up to second circle magic."

"Agreed."

"There and back. I can fly over water."

"That's the deal."

"Woo hoo! Ice golem, here I come!" in a quieter voice she says "They'll be worth a fortune in the public market."

Krynn looks to me and says, "The lass don't know what she's up against."

He reaches his hand up to the direfox. It lowers its big head, and they make long eye contact. I can

almost feel a conversation passing between them. *Is he a druid?* "Ye got it?"

A playful "Yip." sounds from Bosko.

"On the count of three." Krynn says. "One.... Two.... Three! Go!"

An abrupt wind and blur of white fur hits me in the face. The fox is gone.

Lilly revs the engine, lifts off the ground, and bolts over the frozen lake in all of Big Red's 600% ground speed glory. She's like a comet burning up the cold atmosphere in a trail of fire and steam.

Surely she'll make it.

Lilly's almost to the other side, but wait... *No way..* The fox's coat makes it hard to see, but my eyes are able to follow the puffs of light snow in it's passing. Bosko's already half way back around the lake. Lilly's lopped around and is already headed back, I can only imagine the look of determination on her face.

Fur in the face. The direfox leaps over us, lands, and rolls on the ground some eight paces behind Krynn. *Bosko wins!* His tale wags as the dwarf moves to pat his enormous white furry belly.

Lilly's just returning. "Holy crap. Those things are like..." She fishes for the right word. "I don't know,

like a bolt of lightning and a critter on speed had a hot night and made a child."

"I told ye, yer mount would slow us down."

"Right, right." Lilly huffs. "You got your spell. I'll teach it now or whenever we arrive."

Krynn nods. "Fastest creatures in the arctic. Now all ye have to do is decide how you want to ride."

I ask, "There are options?"

"Of course. Ye can ride on their backs, or we can set up a mini-barge."

"What's the mini-barge?"

"Just wait, and I'll show ya." Krynn moves to the larger conveyance loaded up with all his wares, grunts, and pulls what looks like a flat bottom sled off the back of it. "This is a mini-barge. Big enough for one person. Ye stand here." He demonstrates, "While this has a lead attached to the fox's harness. If you have good balance, and strong you control it by shifting your weight."

"Like a snowboard."

Krynn shrugs like I'm spouting nonsense. "Not quite a board, but it is flat."

"Like water skiing, without having to hold on to the tow rope."

Krynn shakes his head. "I have no idea what yer on about."

Annette holds up her hand, "I can water ski and skateboard. The mini barge is going to be a blast."

I nod, thinking that my high dexterity rating will save me. "I think I will too."

I look to Mirae who shrugs and says, "I feel better riding. I already know how to shoot from a saddle."

"Eh..." Lilly says. "I could go either way, but I don't see me doin' much stabbin' while we travel. Foxback for me."

Tako says, "Mini-barge. I've got dex, so I'll manage."

"What about ye big guy?" Krynn eyes Frobod.

"I don't know if I'll be able to stay on the barge. Foxback for me and I'll just try to launch necro bolts."

"It's settled then. Barge riders, ye gotta watch for bumps. A bad hit'll send you right on yer bum."

The next few minutes consist of us helping Krynn drag three mini-barges off the larger one, and attach them to direfox harnesses. The animals are surprisingly well behaved, and more than once I catch Krynn gazing deep into their eyes in what I can only assume is silent communication. They lay on their

bellies while Krynn sets the straps, adjusting their positions so he can work around them. When he's done, they don't seem to mind the harnesses. They remind me of the vests you see seeing eye dogs wearing, because they also have packs for emergency supplies and travel goods.

I stand on my barge, at first unsteadily as I hold out my arms for balance, and then more confidently once I get a sense of the sled's stability. I hop up and down with strong footing. Thinking of our experience running around on top of the Shroudmoon Express, the commuter train of the underworld, I ask, "Don't you have some kind of tether? What happens if we fall off?"

"Well I have special mini-barge boots that'll stop that from happening, but they'll cost you. Even so, if ye go down, the foxes will feel the change and weight and find ye."

"Are you sure about that?" I'm not sure about buying special boots just for a quest, especially if it means losing the stat bonuses from my Swiftstrike Kickers. "Who do you think I am? My foxes are the best foxes in..."

We finish the statement at the same time "... all of Arctica."

"I'd still feel better if we had a tether. Just in case something happens. I can handle being dragged a few meters if I go down. I'm less enthusiastic about being left behind."

Krynn sighs as if finding the notion ridiculous and says, "Fine. I've got some rope. We'll tie one end to your foot, and the other to the barge. The gods help you if it gets caught on something."

Images pass through my mind of getting the rope caught around a tree, and having my leg ripped off by a direfox sprinting at supersonic speeds.

"You know... On second thought..." I look to Mirae. "I'll send you a text if I go down."

"Party chat." Lilly says.

"Okay, no tether."

Frobod asks, "Are we ready to go?"

"Why don't the three of ye take a trip around the lake to get a feel for it first. Find your balance."

Annette hops up and down. "Sounds good to me."

"Ye want them to go faster, say 'Hike!' in a commanding voice." My fox takes a step forward, and he says "Whoaa...." The fox stops. "Want em' to slow down, say ye say that. Whoaaaaaa."

I repeat, "Whoaaaaaa."

"Be sure to draw out that O sound. Just keep saying that until they stop. When you're reading to start say 'Mush' and you'll be off."

Annette says, "Hike, Whoa, Mush. Got it."

"Ye ready?"

Tako nods, "Mush!"

His fox springs into action, not running at blinding speed, but proceeding to walk, and then quicken to a comfortable amble. The way his arms wave tell me he wasn't ready for the acceleration, but he keeps his balance. When finally he seems stable, he calls "Hike!" sending the fox into a quicker pace that kicks clouds of snow in their wake.

"Mush!" My fox begins to move.

"Mush!" So does Annette's.

I'm prepared for the sudden motion, so I don't flail around quite so much as my guild mate. I feel good. While I'm standing with my body facing the direction of the fox, Annette stands sideways like her barge is a surf board. I wonder if there's a wrong way to do it. "Hike!" With faster footsteps, brisk air hits my face. "Hike!" I'm stable, though my stomach thrills at the unfamiliar motion.

How do we control these things?

I put a bit more weight on my right foot, and glide that direction. I then shift my weight to the left, and drift back. *Smooth sailing so far.* "Hike!" As the fox moves faster I think I've found my new favorite mode of winter transportation.

I spare a glance for Annette who seems to be having more trouble controlling her barge. While I'm able to make clear sweeps from one side of the fox's hind quarters to the other, Annette barely drifts from side to side. She calls, "This is harder than skateboarding."

"It's easier to control if you stand like this. Think of it like water skiing!"

In all honesty I have no idea if standing straight ahead will make it more like water skiing, but I can compare it to snow skiing where weighting one foot will change your course.

"Thanks!" She readjusts her position, and I can instantly see a difference in her ability to control the barge. "This works much better."

Testing my stability as we're dragged around the perimeter of the frozen lake, I crouch and drag my hand behind to collect snow in my gloved hand. It's not too efficient, but I scrape up enough at least to form a small snowball. The important thing is that I'm able to

squat and stand up again without feeling unstable. The barges are a lot more sturdy than I thought.

I press the snow in my hands packing it in even harder. "Hike! Hike! Hike hike hike!" My stomach jumps with the burst of speed, and I feel as if the air blasting me in the chest will knock me down before any obstacles. Fortunately, it's not too bad if I stay in the fox's wake. I'm coming up on Tako, snowball still clinched in my hand. We're now side by side.

He gives me a look like 'No way!' and shouts "Hike! Hike!" *Damn. Missed my shot.*

"Hike hike!" I shiver as the speed increases, we're now side by side. *One... two... three.* I pelt him with my little snowball, and it hits him in the shoulder, leaving a snowy white mark on his dark leathers. I stick out my tongue, as I pass. "Hike! Hike!"

Tako's shouting the same as me, but now we're almost back at camp. "Whoaaaaaa..." My fox goes a little slower. "Whoaooooaaaa.." I repeat until we drift to a smooth stop.

Tako dives off his barge instead of stopping properly, scoops up a wad of snow and then smashes me in the side of the head with it. It catches me off guard, and I shiver from the cold.

"Hey!" Mirae hops off her mount, scoops up some snow, laughs and hits her boyfriend with a snowball.

I make one of my own and hit our healer with it.

Tako returns fire, with a throw that leaves Mirae sputtering when it hits her right in the face. "Oh shit! I didn't mean to."

Her nose is bleeding. She rolls her eyes. "It's fine. Espikil!" An aura of green light pops around her as she casts her minor healing. She wipes her face with her hand. "Good as new."

Annette, the only one of us not to participate in the race drifts into camp. "That was fun."

"Ye get the hang of it?"

I nod. "Easier than I thought. They're quite stable."

"Ye can even face backward if you need to attack something behind ye."

I nod having guessed as much.

"If yer all ready..."

I look to Annette. "One thing. If you're going to use your bow now I have a suggestion. Can you take your war form? You'll be able to shoot better because of the bonus..." I catch myself trying to talk stats to an NPC, "Because it has more manual dexterity."

Annette looks to Krynn, "Is he ready for it, or anyone we might meet?"

"Good point." I look to Krynn. "Don't be afraid. Annette she's... a shape changer. I promise you she's not a were, at least, not the way you're used to thinking of them."

"A were, here?" Krynn looks unsettled.

"She can change like a wererat, but she's not a monster. Her mind's intact."

Krynn gives me a dubious stink eye. "I never heard of a lass whose a wererat whose not out to tear ye apart."

I look to Annette, then to Krynn. "Just change, so you can show him. She comes from another universe. The place beyond the Rip of Worlds. Magic... magical creatures... They don't work there like they do here."

"Are you sure?"

I nod.

Beneath her furs it's hard to make out what's happening to her body though her head elongates and becomes furry. Solid black eyes replace her human ones, and whiskers begin to sprout up around what is fast becoming a rat like nose. She also gains about a foot in height, as a long rodent tail pushes out of the seat of her pants.

I look to Krynn to make sure he's not going to attack. He doesn't but I can see he's gripping the knife he wears on his belt. "Say something so he knows it's real."

"Uhhh.. Hi.. I'm Annette." Though her voice is warped through her Rodekin mouth. It's more course and...chittery.

"Ye gods. I've never..."

"Yeah..." I look to Annette. "She gets that a lot, but I assure you, she's very real. No more dangerous than she was a few minutes ago."

"How did it happen? Ye have a cure?"

I shake my head no. "You might as well think of what she is, and the wererats you know as different species..." I pause and correct myself not knowing if Havenfolk understand that word, "Races.. Her kind, the Rodekin, may have some temper issues, but they aren't mindless. We're teaching her to get a grasp on her powers."

Krynn shivers, as if something about her appearance gives him the willies. "Ai'ight. We can go, but I'm warning you, if one bad thing happens to me foxes..,"

Annette jerks her hand as if swatting a fly, "I won't touch your foxes!"

"Ai'ight..." He stirs uneasily, but cautiously on board with the plan. "That's all I care about."

"Fair enough." I turn my attention to Annette. "You should see a remarkable improvement in your accuracy and balance in this form."

She nods, but something in her body language, the briskness of the motion tells me she's still miffed at being treated like a would be psychopath. *Calm...*

The first half hour of our journey is awesome fun without a single mob in sight. It reminds me of skiing without necessarily going down hill. The mini-barges are like swift snowmobile chariots that you can control by shifting your weight.

I practice swinging back and forth on the mini-barge behind my fox. We all seem to be getting the hang of it. I'd like to initiate another snowball fight, but at these speeds, with the ground flashing beneath us in a blur, it's near impossible to scoop up a hand full of snow, much less enough to make a snowball. That's probably not a bad thing because it'd be just like this game to throw a dire polar bear at us when we least expect it.

ROAR. The sound of mauling ricochets through my mind. *Not fun.*

Krynn, unlike the rest of us, rides his mammoth which is towing the big barge of wares. The foxes are a lot faster, but we've made a habit of running far ahead, then looping back around behind the barge and up again like a relay race. Each time we make a loop forward, around and then back we give one of the other riders a chance to sprint ahead so the animals don't get too tired. The pattern is to scout attackers up ahead, as well as any we missed when we passed the first time that might be creeping up from behind.

Of course, we could all just keep pace with the mammoth, leaving three foxes in front, three in back, and user party chat to alert of any dangers, but that would be considerably less fun, and judging by the playful vulpine grins on our rides' faces, the direfoxes enjoy the exercise.

I like it fast. The speed makes my body tingle with adrenaline.

It's Mirae's turn to scout ahead, "Incoming! We've got flyers! Get ready for ranged!"

"What is it?"

"They look like frost imps. Little bat winged creatures with blue and white glowing pitchforks."

"Good work. Everyone, use fire if you've got it."

Of course I don't so I ready to throw my Darksteel Chakram. Tako also has to settle for mundane weaponry as he nocks an arrow, though I suspect some in his stock have magical properties. In fact, it's only Mirae and Lilly that seem to be able to deal ranged fire damage. I weight my right foot so that I drift to the side of the fox and catch a glimpse ahead.

A batty shape flutters in the distance. I hurl my chakram.

CRITICAL HIT.

You hit Coldfire Imp for 13 points of damage, plus 2 dark damage.

You have killed Coldfire Imp.

A spray of black liquid splashes in the air as my hit connects, chopping the diminutive creature in two as each half of the body hits the snow separately.

Krynn hollers, "There'll be more where that came from. Take them down!"

"Krynn hang back with the ice golems and protect your wares, we'll move forward. Call if you need help!"

Frobod says, "I'll stay with him for protection and party chat.

"Good plan."

Krynn, doesn't speak words in response, but grumbles his ascent. I imagine he's quietly thankful that Annette's not on guard duty.

My direfox darts around an incoming ball of coldfire unexpectedly, leaving me to quickly course correct with a shift of my weight. Fortunately the blast sores right past me. Tako looses an arrow in that direction, though he misses the mark. We're too far away from this attacker, but not for long. Our direfoxes are charging at a full sprint, and the wind chill bites into my bones.

Another incoming blast of cold fire. I want to toss another chakram, but all I have time to do is duck suddenly, so low that my fingers touch the floor of my mini-barge. Tako's on point this time, and punctures an imp with his arrow.

"Mirae can you paint?"

It's a skill some archers possess that makes their target glow a different color once hit. It's useful in coordinating attacks and setting up focus fire.

"Got it." She looses one of her magical arrows that trails green sparkly energy. It connects with the creature's right wing and it tumbles out of the sky. It hobbles helplessly on the ground, glowing in the bright

green of a glow in the dark toy. A moment later, Annette looses and ends it.

"Focus on green, or whatever color Mirae paints with. Burn em' down one by one."

Two cold magic blasts come at us from either side. We're now close enough to the imps that I can make out their features; long chinned like a crescent moon, burning blue eyes, and about four feet tall. Unlike other NPCs they just wear loincloths in the arctic chill.

One hits Annette in the chest and she drops to one knee. Her head snaps up in a violent fury, and my voice takes on a warning tone. "Calm..."

"I'll handle it!"

She must have pumped her rage into taking extra actions because she knocks an arrow, looses, knocks another and looses in the time that Mirae or Tako could only have only taken one shot. Two long arrow shafts stick out of her target, but it doesn't go down. *Maybe we should have gotten her a better bow.*

"I can't get the magic to stick to the arrows!"

Lilly waves a burning dagger, sending a streak of flame at Annette's target. "It doesn't work on projectiles! Ya gotta use blades."

"It works for her!" A note of accusation in the Rodekin's voice as she indicates Mirae.

"I'm not binding spells like Lilly. The arrows I shoot ARE the spells."

"I don't...!"

Mirae looses. Her green arrow sticks into the imp to our left, painting it in green light. "Just focus on mundane arrows , or casting spells for this battle. Try your healing if someone gets hurt."

My fox is the closest, we're coming up on it, I hurl my Darksteel Chakram.

"Arugh!!"

You have killed Coldfire Mage.

You take 8 cold damage from Coldfire Ichor.

You resist 6 points of damage.

You are blinded for 6 seconds.

The imp splatters, sending the black ichor it has instead of blood, into my eyes and face. Burn is not the correct word to describe it. It bites for a second before there's nothing at all. I touch my cheek, it's like putting my hand on a frozen steak. I can feel through my fingers but my head...? I instinctively crouch down

when I lose my vision, wanting to maintain my balance and not tumble off the barge.

"Watch out for the blood! It hurts, and blinds if it gets in your eyes."

My vision begins to clear, and I see Annette waving her hands like she's trying to cast a basic heal, but her gestures grow more frantic with every repetition. "Come closer! This is so frustrating. I can't heal from this range."

Now that I can see again I get back to my feet, and weight my right foot to ease closer to her. A wave of green cherry blossom scented magic hits me.

Annette heals you for 1 health. 9 health remaining.

"Good job Annette."

I look away from her just in time to duck out of the way of a massive snowball aimed right at my head.

What the hell?

A pudgy snowman with a carrot nose and an ugly coal frown races beside us, the snowball making up it's base spinning like the wheel of a motor cycle. It coughs, holds it's twig hands up to it's face, and pukes more ammunition into it's gnarled palms. Still moving, it's upper body rears back like a fastball pitcher, and

hurls it at me. I duck, but Tako's not so lucky as his fox cuts between Annette and myself. The nasty snowball explodes against his chest sending him flying off his mini-barge. Thirty percent of his health evaporates.

"Man down! Tako fell off. Watch out! We've also got... angry snowmen."

Mirae's fox breaks away from the pack and loops around back with Tako's direfox to scoop him up.

Lilly waves a red hot dagger, and sends a sphere of fire into the snowman that melts him where he stands. "Fire works better on the snowmen."

"And Frosty's first cup of hot cocoa turned out to be his last. Keep it up."

Lilly waves her dagger in a salute. "You got it!"

Frobod chimes in over party chat, "Krynn says we're almost there."

"Good. You got company?"

"Nothing we couldn't handle."

Another imp flaps its batty wings ahead, this time, instead of sending a blast of magic, it launches its three pronged fork at me like a javelin. I duck out of the way, and Lilly sends a wave of fire its direction. The spell impacts with a sizzling sound. The little imp screams.

Another fork comes flying, not at me, but at Lilly. A vulpine yelp sounds. She's not in a position to dodge, and it thuds into her Dierfoxes flank, creating a blossom of bright red blood in its white fur.

"Annette! Heal the fox!"

Her speed decreases rapidly, and I call, "Whoaaa... Whoaaa..." to slow and guard her.

"I'm okay, but my mount ain't lookin' too good. Thanks for askin'."

"Annette's coming."

**Coldfire Champion hits you for 7 points of damage.
You resist 7 points of damage.**

Another thrown fork slams into my side. "Ugh..!" It doesn't hurt, I take no damage, but it's annoying. It didn't even pierce my armor. "Gonna do this old school until Mirae and Tako get back. Annette, heal fox first, then focus on me. Lilly you know what to do."

Shadow Step (Rank 5) - Success!

I disappear from my mini-barge, and reappear behind the Coldfire Champion that has already been damaged. Sixty percent health remaining. I feel like

face palming because I forgot to equip a melee weapon before Shadow Stepping. I settle for a roundhouse kick to knock the imp out of the air, and shout "Hey! Over here!" at the champion that wounded Lilly's mount.

Now that I'm within hand to hand combat range, I'm surprised to see the nasty little creature is wearing a Santa hat. *We're definitely on the right track.*

Taunt. Successful.

Coldfire Champion attacks.

A new magical throwing fork appears in the far away monster's hands. It launches the weapon at me. Currently operating in full defensive mode, it's not hard for me to evade.

Hot Swap - Success!

You have equipped Lightning's Bite.

Hot Swap (Rank Three)

Weapons: Dexterity + Weapons (Weapon Type) or
Dexterity + Martial Arts

Armor and Accessories: Dexterity + Athletics or
Dexterity + Martial Arts

You may change equipment during combat without penalty. In so doing you must take purely evasive action for 1.5 seconds.

Usable Only On: Head, Hands, Weapon, Ring, Accessory

It feels good to have Bite in my hands again. I parry an incoming attack with the burned Champion's trident near me, and begin inching my way toward the one still attacking at range. I can't move too fast, or my attacker will stay put, and begin throwing like it's buddy. I have to walk slowly, keeping the monster engaged if I want to tank both at melee range.

"I just healed the direfox."

"Good. Come to use and stay in range."

Lilly, now scuttling through the snow, appears behind the burned Champion which now waddles on the ground. It occurs to me that they're about the same height which makes it easy for her to shank it, with a red glowing blade that explodes in fiery death on contact. "Cinderburst!"

"No!"

Both of us are splattered in the imp's freezing black blood, though thankfully none of it gets in my eyes. My health drops by ten percent, but Lilly's not built for tanking. The gory blast drops her life by sixty percent!

"Ugh! Watch the blood! All heals on Lilly now!"

I turn and sprint toward the final Champion which is still airborne. It hurls another fork at me, I leap out of the way, and somersault through the snow like I've been living in Arctica since the age of six.

A non-magical arrow hits the remaining imp. "Help Lilly!" Barely a sliver falls off its health. I greet the creature with a fierce jump spin hook kick that smashes against its pointy chinned face and sends it rocketing down toward the earth. I expect it to eat snow but just in time its wings begin to clumsily flap and the imp rises back in the air.

You'd think taking out a flying monster would be easy with a weapon as long as Bite, but it's horribly awkward trying to swat something out of the air that's bobbing up and down feet above your head.

I can't see Lilly, but her health bar in the interface begins to tick higher. Not as fast as if Mirae was healing, but I can surmise that Annette's whipping out her minor heals. *Gotta start somewhere.*

Lilly's up to 70% health. "I'm good!"

I give her a mental thumbs up, take a swing with Bite, and miss. It's so much easier fighting creatures that are your own height.

The Santa hat wearing imp cackles, "Freeze you!" and stabs down with its little fork.

I duck out of the way. Annette looses another arrow. It connects, shaving a little more health off our opponent.

A streak of purple color flies over my head, and knocks the vile little creature out of the sky. Coldfire Champion health: 30%. I take another swing.

THUMP.

Not quite as hard as I usually hit, and its health drops 10%.

"Hold up! Let me catch this one?"

I look back, and dodge out of the way of another fork strike that was meant for my belly.

"It's all you. Go for it."

Lilly rushes in with her weird bag of powder, tosses it in the air. It lands in the pattern of a circle enclosing a many pointed star. As with the Kryobeaver, streamers of magic energy pass from Lilly's forehead to the Imp's. Their lips aren't moving, but there are occasional gestures as if in conversation. A middle finger. A shake of the head. A shrug. A nod. A look of concern creeping into the monster's face.

Suddenly, a streak of green light from the direction we came lands squarely in the center of the imp's back. It falls dead. One of Mirae's arrows protrudes from it's flesh as it despawns leaving a red velvet sack of loot where it disappears.

"Are you frickin' kidding me?"

Mirae leaps off the back of her direfox and runs, breathing heavily. As soon as she's within range, far greater than Annette's, the green light of nature magic surrounds her hands, and then enwraps Lilly's body with the accompanying scent of cherry blossoms. "Whew, that was close!"

Tako waves.

"I almost had 'em!"

Mirae looks confused, "Oh, really?" I thought he was attacking since you're not at full health.

Lilly throws her hands up in frustration. "I swear it's like ya don't want to make any coin."

"Sorry." Mirae looks sheepish. "Sorry we were late. Decided to loot the mons we killed on the way here."

"Anything good?"

"A few gold and..." She hesitates in amusement.

"And...?"

"They all dropped Santa hats or festive reindeer antlers attached to ear muffs. Who wants them?" Tako puts one of the hats on his head.

"Any stats?"

"No. It's just a skin that transforms whatever you've got to look like earmuffs or a red hat."

"Show me."

Red Winter Festival Hat**Type:**

Misc

Quality:

Uncommon

Use:

Transforms your head gear into something festive.

Duration: Until dismissed.

*Note: Transformed equipment cannot be hidden in the user interface.***Jolly Muffs of the Winter Festival Reindeer****Type:**

Misc

Quality:

Uncommon

Use:

Transforms your head gear into something festive.

Duration: Until dismissed.

Note: Transformed equipment cannot be hidden in the user interface.

Mirae grins, "Who wants one? Between all of us we killed five imps, a dirty snowman, and a dire penguin."

Lilly huffs. "Two more imps over here, no thanks to you."

Annette says, "I'll take a reindeer." Mirae forks a set of ear muffs over, they're the cutesy cloth antlers that you can find in party stores.

"You look like a proper Jackalope." I take a Santa hat, and everyone else follows. I raise a brow, "Who got the penguin? I didn't see it."

Lilly asks, "Ain't those supposed to be rabbits?"

I shrug. "Close enough."

"I guess Frobod. It was near the mammoth tracks."

I bend down to collect the loot, finding another hat and placing it in my inventory. "Ho ho ho." The parallel between the red loot bag, and a Santa sack is not lost on me. "What do you think these will sell for back in Durolan?"

Coldfire Bracers of the Invoker**Type:**

Cloth

Slot:

Wrist

Quality:

Rare

Equipped Bonus:

Intelligence +2, Stamina + 2

Special Properties:*20% Cold Resistance, +10% Mana Regeneration*

Tako says, "Probably a lot since it's a seasonal item, and everyone's stuck here."

I nod. "I guess there will be more demand for vanity items this year since we can't log out and experience them in real life." I hold up the bracers. "Anyone need them?"

Mirae shakes her head, "I've got better."

Lilly also shakes her head no.

"Guild vault then unless..." I give Annette a look. "Can you use these?"

I hand the item over. She studies them for a long moment. Tako looks aghast that I'm offering loot to an NPC. I don't care, she's in our party, and the longer we're stuck in game, the more the distinction between player and non-player character seems to fade. I consider reminding him that his girlfriend, is a digital construct now that she's digitized, but that feels mean so I ignore him.

Annette rolls up her sleeves, straps them over her fur, and nods her head.

"They'll help you with casting. Everything good for everyone else?"

Tako shrugs. "Saw another pack of five or six, but they were going the opposite direction."

It's at this point that Frobod and Kryn timer arrive, the dwarf sitting on the mammoth's back, and the death knight perched on the barge itself beside one of the ice golems.

"Caster bracers dropped. I assume you didn't want them, but if you do you can roll for them like usual."

He shakes his head no. "Who did they go do?"

"Annette."

"Huh..." He takes in Annette's appearance for a long time, even though the items are now hidden beneath her coat. "Merry Christmas."

"I'm Jewish."

"Oh... I forgot. Happy Hanukkah then."

"Thanks."

Krynn calls down from his Mammoth. "We're almost there. Pretty soon you'll get yer face time with Ureota and I'll deliver my goods to the elves."

I glance to Lilly knowing what she's thinking. *'What about the other patrol?'* It kinda sucks that she hasn't been able to tame anything. "Let's keep following the quest. If at the end of this you don't catch anything, I promise I'll Thunder Bridge us back to the arctic so you can catch some later."

That steals away some of her salt. "Whenever I want?"

"Hey, if we get more summoners in the guild we can make it a thing. The more out of the way places with no portals I visit, the more exotic creatures you can collect."

"Alright." Lilly nods. "Your Christmas gift from me is gonna be a bunch of maps to the ass end of nowhere."

"You're so thoughtful." I pause. "I thought you were supposed to keep gifts a secret."

"I forgot. So sue me."

I look to Krynn. "Does Ureota have a lair?"

"He does, but yer just as likely to find him out near the border of the vale. I want ye to take me to the border, once there, I'll tell ye how to get to the old wyrm's home."

Contrary to Krynn's proclamation, it takes nearly forty five minutes to reach the edge of San'ta Vale due to more and more frequent Coldfire Imp attacks, paired with a few chance encounters with dire polar bears, snowmen and tainted penguins. Every single time Lilly tries to tame something, fate conspires to snatch it from her grasp.

"Oh, come on!" She kicks the corpse of a dire polar bear before it despawns. "I was this close." She measures with her knobby thumb and forefinger, "And this thing decides to get hungry?"

She pulls the body of a Coldfire Mage from it's mouth. It despawns leaving a red sack of goods in its place.

Tako grins, finding the goblin's predicament hilarious. "We've got bear meat if we decide to barbeque."

Annette surprises me by kneeling over the great animal, and performing the Rite of Gratitude. "This fur will keep us warm."

Good job.

I guess it's easier for her to remember than most players since this crazy world is her real life. A couple of times she got hit by imps bringing her dangerously close to entering the blood rage, which would have forced her to attack anything, friend or foe, she could sink her claws into. I totally understood when she chose to fall back to healing. She's steadily improving on the mending front, delivering mini heals whenever someone takes damage, thus giving Mirae more time on her bow. All in all, her training's coming along nicely.

Annette looks to Lilly, "I don't understand why your magic won't work on arrows. Healing is hard because of range. If I could just put healing spells on my arrows, there'd be no problem."

"It doesn't work that way. Only daggers, knives, and short swords, and you have to stab someone to trigger the spell. There's no point in healing if you're going to hurt someone in the process."

Annette sighs, "There's got to be a way."

I don't know how to explain that the game just wasn't built that way. I try to comfort her by saying,

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"Maybe some time in the future someone will figure out how." Mental translation: Maybe there will be new casting options in a future update.



Chapter 9 - Sacrifice

We're standing at the edge of San'ta Vale, a snowy gentle sloping valley with evergreens that have been largely absent from the Arctica landscape. It feels indescribably peaceful. I can feel myself wanting to walk forward and forget the monsters we've been battling in the last few hours. I see no signs of habitation, but I can tell that the Vale is no small place.

"Deals a deal then, give me yer map." I hand it over. "Ye'll find Ureota's lair here." A red mark appears beneath his gloved fingertip. "Not too far."

I nod and take it back. "Thanks."

"When yer done, come back here, and I'll tell you the elves' verdict on whether ye can come in." Under normal circumstances I'd be tempted to ask, '... but how will you know if we're done?' but here, in a game, I'm

just going to assume magic. "Be safe. Ureota's ornery at the best of times, and these are not the best of times."

"We will."

"In that case," He gives us a toothy grin from behind his icicle encrusted beard. "Be gone with ye." He waves and descends the gentle slope. I notice two of the ice golems in back are sticking their spears in the snow to create drag so the barge doesn't slide faster than the pace of the mammoth. Our direfox mounts follow, running around each other, jumping, rolling, and playing in the snow, happy to have reached their destination.

"I think I'll miss them. Is it possible to get one as a mount in Haven?"

Mirae shakes her head no. "I know, right? They're adorable. There's nothing that fast on the ground available outside of quests, unless you've got something from Freeworld."

I sigh, and stretch. "Next stop Ureota." I wave my middle finger in the air and shout "INFERNO!!!" then pump my fist and say "Let's ride."

The elechoppers pop into existence with the sounds of hungry engine gurgles, and bursts of color

corresponding with their elements. I straddle Big Red, Annette sits behind Mirae, and we all lift off the ground.

"What are the odds I can tame Ureota?"

"None?" I give the goblin a look.

"We have to take his heart for the quest."

"It's a frost wyrm. Maybe he has two."

Tako says, "I'm no expert on frost wyrm physiology, but I'm pretty sure it doesn't work that way."

Lilly sighs. "I'm pretty sure I ain't bringin' nothin' home for the holidays."

"Dude!" Mirae says, "We should do secret Santas when we get back. I've never done it in game but it could be so much fun."

I spare her a glance, and then look to Frobod.

"I'm game once we finish this quest. If the logout button's permanently re-enabled, and I build up the courage to sign back in, I'm down for some Santa action."

I frown. "What do you mean build up the courage? Are you leaving us?" I mean... It's not like we're a couple but... Okay, we're totally not a couple so I shouldn't be thinking about this.

He must have picked up on a sour note in my voice. "The game's already messed up once in a really spectacular way. I don't know if coming back is worth risking my freedom. Maybe we can play some other game."

I sigh. "I guess... It's just... This is where Jordan's legacy is. Everything Archangel's said has been true. If we complete the quest, logout gets re-enabled. There's no reason you shouldn't be able to log in and out when you want."

"I'll have to think on it when I'm out. For now, I'm focused on making up for a lost birthday, ya know?"

I nod.

"I know it's not my fault we're stuck in here, but I worry about everyone. Mandy, even my ex wife since she hasn't been receiving child support for a few months."

I frown. "I take it Mandy's your daughter?" Frobod nods. "Your wife, you still love her?"

Frobod shakes his head. "Ex-wife, and no, not like that, but I've got responsibilities that I haven't been living up to since I got stuck in game. It's hard for a single mom to take care of two people when she's been used to getting a check every month. I worry about things. Does she have enough cash to make the rent, if

she's got rent, is there food on the table? Did she have to find an extra part time job, putting Mandy in child care, or on her own in the evenings? Those kinds of things."

"I see your point." I trail, having never been responsible for another human before. "We'll try not to dawdle."

"Are you worried about your job?"

He shakes his head no. "Not really. It's easy when you're your own boss."

I raise a brow, having never asked him what his real world profession was. "I'm a DJ. I might have to figure out about some recurring gigs I haven't been doing, but beyond that... My guys who helped out were all part time."

I laugh. "Wow, I can't believe it. Some how I never pictured you as a DJ."

He shrugs. "What did you think I was?"

"I don't know. Something more serious, like pharmaceutical salesman, an office worker or something." Office worker, of course being a relative term, the vast majority of people telecommute to virtual work environments, these days.

Frobod returns the laugh, "No, no cubicles. I'm an entrepreneur, carving my own destiny."

I consider that, and measure it against his behavior since Archangel; his single minded determination to do what needed to be done to get out. "I think I get that. Being an entrepreneur that is, and having a hand in your own fate. Being stuck here doesn't sit well with you."

By way of agreement, he simply states, "It doesn't."

"Ya know, Rob and I talked about whether or not to come back in game. For me, I'm gonna risk it. As soon as I get the logout option, I'm headin' back to Cupcake Keep, spendin' a nice night with my man, and then signing the fuck out to see my family. We'll have a nice dinner, tell Ma we're okay. I'll let em' know all about life post-Archangel, before comin' back to you guys. If I get stuck again, so be it. My guy's here and that means this is where I've gotta be."

I look to Tako, "What are you going to do when we get out?"

He shrugs. "For the holidays? Chill with family, and watch old Christmas movies I guess. I'm also gonna talk to Mirae's family to let em' know she's still alive in here."

"I don't envy you."

He looks to me. "What do you mean?"

"What are the odds that they'll accept that she's been digitized? It's not exactly tech that was available on the open market."

Confusion clouds his voice. "They should be happy, right?"

"They should..." Should being the operative word. I trail, trying to find the right words. "Speaking as someone whose lost a family member while they were still young, the message could either be a ray of hope, or salt in an open wound." I can sense the question in the air between us, but he says nothing. "When my brother died, my mom didn't want to hear anything about the supernatural. No ghosts, nothing. She just wanted to put Jordan to rest, so she could imagine him in a happy afterlife. Anything that threatened that world view made her really uneasy, like she might have to start worrying about him all over again."

He starts, "Yeah, but this is different..."

Mirae nods. "Once the logout's fixed they can even come here to visit. It'll be like old times."

I sigh, unconvinced. "Just be careful. Grief is a touchy thing. The things that'll give some people hope, are the same that'll suck all the joy out of another person's world." I look to Mirae, "Are your folks religious?"

"Eh... So so. We went to church on Christmas and Easter."

"Criesters." I chuckle, trying to remember who introduced me to the term. "Who knows then? I imagine digitization is a lot harder for the truly devout to accept."

I pause to think on it. *What happens to the soul of a consciousness that has digitized? Does it go on as a spirit contained in an inorganic body, or does the digital copy remain as devoid of spiritual essence as the hardware that created it?* I don't know. Glancing at Mirae I don't want to ponder the implications, but I like to think she's a ghost in a machine.

I point, "Over there."

We're coming up on a wide yawning cave with a great bolder propped beside the entrance. Long ice stalactites give the opening teeth like a gaping maw.

We drop to the ground and Frobod dismounts, equipping his weapon. "This looks like it."

I confirm by checking the moving map, and seeing we're right on top of the mark Krynn made. "Buff up." I wipe my hands together to trigger the macro I made to cast the Enhanced Dexterity and Enhanced Vitality buffs.

Wooooooooosh. A whistling wind. Thump-bump. Thump-bump. A heart beat sounds in my ears. I equip Bite, and push myself through the katas required to cast my Flow Like Water defense. Three new buff icons appear in the upper right hand corner of my vision.

Enhanced Dexterity.

Dexterity increased by 10%.

Duration: 60 minutes remaining.

Enhanced Vitality.

Regeneration Increased by 10%.

Duration: 60 minutes remaining.

Flow Like Water (10)

Negates 10 physical damage.

Duration: 30 minutes remaining, or until 10 damage has been nullified.

Frobod casts the Elemental Weapon spell Leroy taught him in Hades. A moment later, the entire length of his Greatsword ignites like a torch. *I totally forgot about that spell.* I too cast Elemental Weapon, along with Tako. His daggers burn where as my staff,

already an elemental weapon, has small arcs of electricity rising up and falling at either end, interrupted by subtle tongues of fire that leap to kiss them every few seconds.

"Looks like we're ready to go." I say, then look to Annette. "Hang back with Mirae if you want to focus on healing." She takes a sharp breath. Not wanting to set her rage into high gear by implying that she's useless, I follow up with. "This is where I always put ranged attackers and healers. We get hit so you don't have to."

She nods and flicks her larger than life rat tail in understanding.

Into the mouth of the cavern we go; into the lair of the beast. My first impressions are not encouraging. A smear of blood stripes a cold grey wall, with dark splotches of red beneath our feet. *What was killed here?* I grip Bite tighter, taking point because I'm tank and that's my job. I try listening for sounds up ahead, but I can't make anything out just yet. The only nice thing about this place is a gentle blue magic hanging about the ceiling painting the environment in comfortable light. I imagine it's so the resident can see.

I wonder if Ureota's a mage.

A crash sounds deeper in the passage, I stop, look back and communicate via party chat. "What was it?"

Mirae tilts her head to listen. "Don't know. Doesn't sound like fighting."

I try to make out another sound but it's quiet, at least up until the moment another stony crash hits all our ears.

"I don't think it's fighting but be careful." I continue my advance.

We come to a ledge overlooking a room with a shallow pond filled with crystal clear water. Beside it is a giant serpentine body with shiny frostlike scales, smeared with bright red blood. Its head somehow reminds me of a lion, or a Chinese dragon, with a mane composed of rumpled snow colored skin, and the long whiskers of a bottom feeding fish. Clumsy smears of blood decorate the wall nearest its head.

"I think it's dead."

Mirae asks, "What is?"

"Ureota."

Tako asks, "Are you sure?"

"No."

Mirae asks, "What killed it?"

I find it amusing that they're all whispering in spite of using party chat since no one else can hear.

Frodo joins me at the front of our procession, and looks down. "I don't know. Maybe another group?"

I shrug. "Haven't seen anyone else since we got here. Let's go."

There's a passageway to our left that descends toward the pond. We take it down, and as soon as we step into the chamber the white worm's body moves. It slowly, groggily, raises its head, looks to either side, and then smashes itself into the cavern wall. It doesn't seem to have seen us. A new splotch of red appears where it impacts. Ureota rears up, and once again beats his face into the side of the cave.

Mirae looks confused. "What the..?"

Tako eyes the monster skeptically. "Is he bugged?"

My grip is just beginning to relax on my weapon, when suddenly Ureota's head snaps around, and flickers a forked tongue at us. "Tressspassers!" His eyes burn with the same blue fire as the imps and tainted Kryobeavers. The left half of his face is red, broken, and pulpy.

I'm about to launch into an attack with Bite, when the fire goes out, leaving only glacial blue eyes with slitted pupils.

"Help me." Blue light flickers in his eyes, trying to take control. "Winter said you'd come. "I must die." The creature abruptly turns, and beats its head against the wall, reducing its own health by another ten percent. "Kill me. Save Great Uncle Winter. Help Winter." The wyrm moans and snaps at something that's not there. "Get out! I'm not... I'm not me anymore!"

The liquid splat sound of the wyrm's head hitting the side of the cave makes me feel a little queasy. Ureota falls to the ground limp.

"Is he dead?" Lilly asks.

I shake my head. "Just knocked out."

Frobod hefts his greatsword looking unsure. "So we're just supposed to kill him while he's unconscious? Not quite what I expected."

Mirae says, "I could try to heal him?"

Lilly shakes her head. "What and have him attack us? We came for his heart, remember?"

The end of Ureota's body twitches. *Screw it.* "All in!"

I rush forward and bring Bite down hard on the monster's body, sending animated wires of lightning crawling over his skin. Frobod chops with his greatsword leaving an ugly cesh nearer to his head, and

Mirae looses one of her green arrows. Aside from the occasional twitching Ureota fails to move or even try to fight back.

Tako says. "It's not even a challenge."

Frobod shrugs, swinging his sword back and chopping again at the same spot he made his first cut. "It's the objective of the quest. Not gonna complain if nothing tries to kill us."

Lilly says, "I'm just gonna let you melee people deal with this. I'm gonna save my manna and spells."

I nod. In a final moment of bloody butchery, Frobod swings, and decapitates the wyrm. Blood spatter hits me in the face. I don't know whether to feel horrified or grateful that it's done. "Does anyone feel as weird about this as I do? I mean... It's one thing when they're fighting back but this...." I shake my head.

Lilly says, "I feel ya."

The body despawns, leaving a red velvet Santa sack in it's place. I open it, not actually wanting to find good loot for such an easy kill.

Ureota's Heart*Quest Item***Description:**

Offer this to Winter to help restore her power.

Jolly Muffs of the Winter Festival Reindeer**Type:**

Misc

Quality:

Uncommon

Use:

Transforms your head gear into something festive.

Duration: Until dismissed.

Note: Transformed equipment cannot be hidden in the user interface.

"Heart and antlers." I hold them both up, then gesture to Annette. "Take the heart, since you're making the offering to Winter. Anyone want antlers?"

Tako grins, "I'll take them." Clearly he's not bothered by the ease of this battle, if it can even be called that.

I sigh, staring at the place the loot bag had occupied. Six months ago this wouldn't have bothered me, but now? Helpless creatures actually feel helpless since there's no way for us to go home and put them out of sight and out of mind.

Mirae must see me staring, because I feel her hand on my arm. "He knew he was being corrupted, and we did him a favor."

"You're right... I don't know why I'm weirded out by this."

Frobod asks, "Do we have to go all the way back to where we found Winter for the turn in?"

* * * * *

I shake my head. "I don't think so. She's a spirit so... I think Annette can call her like any other spirit. Let's go outside and give it a shot."

Outside the cave, I'm glad not to see any imps. There's nothing more annoying than having a random patrol interrupt your ritual. The environment's quiet save for our boots crunching in the snow. The air is crisp and fresh, a slap in the face of the butchery we just completed.

Annette looks to me, "I don't have any seeds or nuts."

I shake my head. "I doubt that's what Winter's interested in. Close your eyes and remember what it was like to be in her presence. Once you lock on that memory and association, hold your hands up, the same as you did with the seeds, only replace them with Ureota's heart."

She follows my instructions, kneeling in the snow, and holding the heart above her head as if in offering to the sun. The wind stirs in an otherwise calm day. Annette looks serene... as serene as any Rodekin can look in their war form. It takes longer than I expect, in fact... I'm beginning to worry that Frobod might be right about having to return to the chasm with the Kryobeavers, but another stirring of the wind gives me hope. Annette's still concentrating, so I leave her to it, knowing I won't be helping anyone if I break her focus.

Finally, it seems like an eternity... The ethereal outline of the woman battling tainted ice creatures begins to take form. She becomes more solid, setting her non-existent feet in the bedroom slippers of physicality. She looks tired, the light in her eyes not quite as bright as it'd been when we last met.

"Child of Rat..." She says.

Annette holds the massive heart to her. "It's Ureota's."

Winter closes her eyes and takes an exhausted sigh of relief. "Thank you." As soon as she touches it, it pulses with magical white light. She cradles the organ like a baby, and presses her cheek to it. "Thank you."

Tako scrunches his nose. "That's morbid."

... and yet he had no problem butchering a defenseless frost wyrm.

Annette stands. "I don't know what to do now. I'm new to this."

Winter ignores her for a moment, given the grisly scene we just came from, I half expect the elemental to eat it. Instead, her chest opens as though having a hither to invisible mouth; an open portal to her internal anatomy. The wyrm's heart shines bright as she brings it closer, until tendrils of spirit reach out and embrace it like little arms. They hug the organ close to her body as it sinks deeper into her chest cavity, each moment shining brighter until we're all forced to squint and shield our eyes with open palms.

The light vanishes. The heart's gone, and Winter is beautiful and radiant as if in a dream.

Winter's voice is strong now. "Child of Rat, you need guidance. Help me restore winter's balance, and I will be your guide."

Yes, quest objective!

"How do I... We do that?"

"Find the source of the corrupted, and cleanse it. I will aid you in your quest."

Frobod says, "Krynn says the ugly's thicker here, so I say we start with the San'ta. These are probably linked quests."

I nod. "That's what I was going to suggest anyways."

"Go now, before the corruption is complete. To call on me, repeat the rite you just performed, or quench a flame in my honor."

I look to Annette. "Since we're about to meet a reclusive tribe of Elves, it might not be a bad idea to drop back down into human shape."

Frobod asks, "What's the plan if they won't let us in?"

"They will, otherwise we wouldn't have a quest to go see them."

The death knight nods. "That makes sense."



Chapter 10 - San'ta

We find Krynn waiting for us at the gently sloping entrance to San'ta Vale, with another figure, taller than him, and a touch shorter than me in a bulky, hooded fur coat. He has a thin blonde beard, almond eyes, and gloved fingers.

"Lady Lord Melpomine." I check his nameplate to see who I'm dealing with, as it turns out, we're meeting a celebrity.

Fiodrill**Type:** NPC**Race:** Elf (San'ta)**Appearance:** 6**Challenge:** Hard

"It seems my reputation proceeds me. Lord Fiodrill" I trail. "The doll maker?"

"Yes, yes." He says a touch impatiently if I'm not mistaken, though it is subtle. Perhaps toy making is serious business in Arctica and he's burdened by adoring fans. "Are you the one with the Dolly?"

"We are." I'm sure to include we so that he understands that everyone in the party comes as a package deal.

"May I see it?"

I raise a brow and exchange looks with Mirae and Frobod before pulling the Mangled Dolly out of inventory. "Sure..." I hold it out to him.

He takes it in his hands and immediately looks under the dress.

Tako snickers. "Perv."

The elf sighs, the unease draining out of his body language. Perhaps I was too quick to judge his earlier reaction to my greeting. "It's real. You have my apologies. You wouldn't believe how many warmlanders try to sneak in here with fakes, forged documents, or pretending some legitimate business."

Tako says, "Man, I hate when people try to get in my house with fake toys. I feel ya."

Fiodrill doesn't seem to catch the sarcasm, because he nods gravely, giving the doll another look over, noting the patches of burned fabric. "Horrible... So horrible what happened."

Tako wears an expression that suggests Fiodrill takes his toy maintenance way too seriously, but I'm not convinced that's the issue.

Frobod asks, "What exactly did happen?"

The elf sighs. "A sad story, and one directly related to our current struggles. Please join me to find her parents. You are welcome in San'ta vale."

We begin our descent and the air feels lighter, as if this entire section of the map falls under the umbrella of divine protection. It's peaceful and winter vegetation grows more lush with tall evergreens and snow covered branches.

"Is this like... " Tako muses, "A thing where people call their dogs children, but with dolls?"

I scowl, but Fiodrill answers. "No. If only it was. I speak of the parents of the girl who owned this doll."

That's surprising. "You remember them?"

"Of course." Fiodrill says. "I remember all my custom creations, especially this one. It's rare that one of our number meets their final end, especially one so young."

Mirae looks to her boyfriend. "It did come from Hades, remember. There's only so many ways to create a relic."

"Indeed." Fiodrill says. "This doll was well loved. She named it Samantha."

I look to the Elf, "What was the girl's name?"

"Reilynn, or Rei for short."

Snow crunches underfoot.

As we proceed deeper into the Vale I discover more signs of habitation. Occasional trees sparkle with white fairy lights, which become colored as we draw closer to the village. Then, as if stepping through a magic mirror, a winter wonderland appears. One step nothing, just trees and snow ahead, the next our vision is obscured by a pink fog, and the step after that...

Candy cane fence posts, happy snowmen, and a sign that reads "Winterland."

A red sleigh is parked just outside the candy cane gate, behind hedges trimmed to resemble nine reindeer.

I think the snowman are ordinary children's creations, until one bows, removing its top hat, and winks a coal eye. "Happy Winterfest, and welcome to Winterland!"

The residents I see on the well plowed street, poke each other's shoulders, point and murmur shocked words that sound like "Visitors!" "Adventurers!" and "Are they here to save Great Uncle Winter?" I'm half expecting them all to burst into a Disney musical number. Every single building is strung up with holiday lights, and gaudy holiday decorations, giant snowflakes, jolly snow men, and sculptures of laughing bearded fat men in red suits.

The San'ta themselves are much the same height as other elves, taller than gnomes and goblins, a few inches shorter than me. Their features could best be described as Nordic Asian, with long blonde hair and blue eyes fit for any valkyrie, and the round single eyelided faces I'd come accustomed to seeing in Korea.

I look to Fiodrill. "You don't get many tourists I take it."

A street side vendor sips a steaming cup of cider, beside a table full of heavy wool blankets, and quilts embroidered with Christmas trees, snow flakes, milk, cookies, and reindeer. A whiff of cinnamon creeps under my nose as a cozy cafe door opens and shuts behind a blonde haired, red and green beanie wearing customer in a warm coat.

"You could say that." His voice is hesitant in a way that suggests he can't tell whether I'm cracking a joke, or not. "Few warmlanders come to Winterland."

"At least it's not Christmasland." We pass an eighty foot tree, covered in lights with reflective baubles the size of watermelons. Fiodrill, Frobod, and Lilly give me inquisitive looks. "It's from a book a read about a guy who kidnaps children and brings them to 'Christmasland' where they lose all sense of morality."

Frobod says, "I must have missed that one."

In time we break away from the main street which serves as a marketplace filled with toy stores, clothiers, restaurants, and every type of shop you can imagine for Santa's gifts in between. The residential homes, log cabins and winter cottages, also have

Christmas lights, but the decorations are more subdued; the kind that make you want to go inside and curl up in front of a nice fire.

"Here we are..." Fiodrill speaks in a solemn tone. "This is the home of little Rei's family." He sighs, as if confessing a terrible secret, "The only San'ta in Winterland who dread this holiday season. They aren't expecting visitors, and adventurers are rare so perhaps I should knock on the door first."

"We're guests. Do what you think is right."

He nods. "Just a moment." He walks to the front porch leaving footsteps behind him. A collection of gaily wrapped gifts decorates the doorstep beside a mini-Christmas tree, and a mail box, sheltered from the snow. I wonder how long it's been since the family has left this home. Maybe it was snowy before we arrived. Perhaps they've lost the will for holiday cheer, and the endurance for Winterland's festive atmosphere.

The door opens. A San'ta woman answers in her bathrobe, and flickers her eyes between Fiodrill and our party. Her eyes are dark, and hair disheveled, which is impressive given that Elves don't require much sleep. A few moments later Fiodrill motions with his wrist

inviting us to come forward. He bends down to pick up some of the porch gifts.

"Lady Lord Melpomine, Miss Annette, Lord Frobod, Lord TakoStar, Lady Lord SalemLilly, Lady Lord Mirae... This is Alvawynn, Rei's mother."

"Please come in." Her voice is tired as she steps out of the way, as we enter, I see many more gifts, perhaps from the porch, lining the walls of a living room with a careless Christmas tree, and a weak fire.

Boot steps on wood sound as a man descends from upstairs, a blonde San'ta man, in a work shirt and simple brown trousers. "Who's there?"

The woman looks over her shoulder. "It's Fiodrill, and a collection of adventurers. He says it's about Reilynn."

He meets my green eyes with his blue ones, devoid of holiday cheer. "What about her?"

Fiodrill says, "This is Perolon, Rei's father."

I glance at the others in the party, and they aren't saying anything. "We found something that might have belonged to your daughter."

"There's no might about it. That's the doll I made for her."

Perolon looks to Fiodrill. "That doll's all burned up. He took it from us the same day he took her."

"Yes, indeed, but..."

"... but what? Is this your idea of a joke? Bring me a replica to spread some of your damned holiday cheer?"

He kicks one of the wrapped presents in the entry hall. "I've had it with your consolations. Take your doll, and tell everyone in the market to stop leaving presents. We're not doing Winterfest this year."

Fiodrill gasps, scandalized. You'd think Perolon just proclaimed that he'd stabbed the San'ta deity. "Not doing Winterfest?"

"We're not doing it!"

Alvawynn, touches her husband's arm. "Just go back upstairs. I'll deal with the adventurers."

"I'm not going upstairs." His voice is stern implying there will be no argument. He looks to me, then to Fiodrill, then his wife, as if caught, not sure what to say. "... I want some porridge." He abruptly turns, and walks off, retreating into what I can only assume is their kitchen.

Alvawynn shakes her head. "He's not doing so well. Please, sit down." She leads us into the family room, gesturing to number of chairs. She seems to realize that there aren't quite enough for everyone in our party, and sits cross legged on the floor. Instead of taking one of the seats, our entire group joins her on the ground. "Now, what's this all about?"

Fiodrill motions to me. "Show her."

I pull the Mangled Dolly from my pack, and give it to her. A white hand rises to her mouth, and then tears leak from her eyes.

She wipes them, embarrassed, and sniffs hard. "Where did you get this?"

"We found it..." Frobod says.

I finish his sentence. "... in Hades." I feel bad for her. "We thought we should bring it back, and that you might be looking for it."

You have gained 3000 personal reputation with Alvawynn.

Current level. Respected.

You have gained 1500 reputation with the San'ta Elves.

Current level. Friendly.

Alvawynn nods, wiping more tears from her face. Her voice breaks as she says, "It's just so hard to accept that she's really gone, and Great Uncle Winter at that..."

Frobod asks, "What does this have to do with Great Uncle Winter?"

"He's a madman! Ever since the snow rats got into his stash he's been going bad."

Annette looks to me and whispers, "Great Uncle Winter's like Santa right?" I nod. "How does Santa go bad?"

I shake my head and whisper back. "I don't know."

Alvawynn says, "I can hear you."

Damn elven hearing.

She sniffles and says, "You've done me a kindness coming all this way to bring back little Rei's dolly, so I'll tell you a secret about Great Uncle Winter." All of us perk up, sensing the next leg of the quest. "Do you know why people leave milk and cookies on the last day of Winterfest?"

"Uhhh.. Because Santa likes them?"

Alvawynn seems confused by Tako's statement.

"He means Great Uncle Winter."

The elf nods. "Yes, but it's more important than that. He needs milk and cookies to maintain his essential goodness. He's a magical being, like a God. Without them, the land becomes corrupted, he becomes evil, and winter becomes as cold and permanent as his black heart."

"All of this over milk and cookies?"

Alvawynn nods. "They are essential for keeping Great Uncle Winter good. On top of that, after he eats his fill he sleeps for a very long time, while we, the elves of the San'ta get to work on making next year's toys."

Frobod asks, "What exactly do you mean by Evil?"

"After Uncle woke up, this typically happens in early Autumn everyone was happy to see him.

Including Rei. We didn't know he was in a bad mood. How could we? Who's ever heard of a cantankerous Great Uncle Winter?"

I shake my head. "Not me, but what..."

Alvawynn speaks over my question. "She ran up to him for a hug as children often do. He had a lantern, and broke it over her head spilling burning oil everywhere. She screamed."

Frobod looks a little pale. "Jesus." I can only imagine what's going through his head.

Alvawynn swallows hard. "She screamed, but we couldn't put the fire out... Uncle looked at us and said, 'Shut the brat up.' I ran for her of course, but I was too slow. No one else moved. I think they were in shock. This wasn't the Great Uncle Winter we knew and loved. He picked her up by the coat, impervious to the flames and threw her head first against a stone wall. She was dead before she hit the ground, as her body lie burning. We couldn't even see her blood against the red suit. "

Frobod clinches his fists. "We're going after that fucker." Tears roll down Alvawynn's face. "We're going to kill him."

She shakes her head no. "You can't kill Great Uncle Winter. He's immortal. He must be redeemed."

Speaking in a dangerous voice, Frobod says,
"Then tell us how to redeem him."

Alvawynn sobs. "Milk and cookies!"

I put a calming hand on Frobod's arm. "I don't mean to make light of the situation, but why hasn't anyone baked more cookies for him? There are a lot of elves here, and what happened to his old supply?"

The elf woman snuffles. "An abominable snow rat infestation got to his stash before he woke up. by the time he was awake, there weren't enough to tip the balance for the year toward goodness. We didn't realize at first until it was too late."

"Okay..." I consider. "That explains what happened to his stash, but not why you can't make anymore."

"We can make more cookies, and believe me our bakers are turning them out by the hundreds, by the thousands even, but they aren't good enough. There's only a few recipes in the world that can correct a goodness deficit like this, and restore balance, and we don't have them. If we'd known about the issue right away we might have been okay, but weeks had gone by before Great Uncle Winter turned violent. By that time it was already too late."

Frobod takes a deep breath. "Alright. So how do we get one of these redemption recipes, and why don't you already have them?"

"Centuries ago, the last time Great Uncle Winter turned evil, a third of our number abandoned Arctica taking the recipes with them. There was a revolt, as they felt that Great Uncle Winter had bound them in slavery. Today, they are known as the Ke'bla, though they are even more reclusive than the San'ta for fear of bondage."

Frobod says, "So you're telling us we have to find these Ke'bla elves and convince them to give us a recipe to save Christmas."

"Christmas?" Alvawynn cocks her head.

"Winterfest." Frobod amends.

"That's correct."

Quest Complete: Winter Dungeonland - Part 1

Quest Update: Winter Dungeonland - Part 2

Difficulty: Hard

Alvawynn has revealed to you the secret history of the Ke'bla elves. Find them, retrieve a recipe to restore great uncle winter, or convince them to bake the greatest cookies in all the land for you and bring them back to Winterland.

Objectives:

Retrieve Recipe or Cookies	0/1
Return to Winterland	0/1
Redeem Great Uncle Winter	0/1

Chain Completion Rewards (Choose One):

- A unique evolving weapon (Legendary Potential)
- A unique evolving chest piece (Legendary Potential)
- A unique evolving helm (Legendary Potential)
- A unique evolving spell (Legendary Potential)
- Logout re-enabled

Additional Rewards (Limited Edition) (Choose One):

- Unlock Rebirthing as Ke'bla Elf**
- Unlock Rebirthing as San'ta Elf**
- Unlock Rebirthing as Kel'rog Elf**

I ask, "Do you have any idea of where to start?"

Alvawynn shakes her head no. "If we knew where they were hiding, some of us would have tried to reconcile with them long ago."

Thinking of the Rite of the Seeking stone, I ask, "Is there anything in Winterland that might have belonged to one of them? We might be able to use it to find them with magic."

Alvawynn's about to say no, when she closes her mouth and appears thoughtful. "I.. don't know, but..."

"But?" Frobod asks.

"There's a woman in town who may be able to help you. Her name's Tiasol Her entire family left with the Ke'bla, but she stayed behind to be with her then lover, now husband. If anyone has a relic of our lost kin, it'd be her."

"You mean she's still alive after all this time?"

Mirae, gives me a look. "We elves are a long lived race."

"Huh..." It's weird to think. Before living here, the longevity of elves was just a list of stats you read in an info screen, but now I can't help but feel infantile by comparison.

I stand. "We'll go talk to her." The rest of the party follows.

Alvawynn says, "If you don't find her in town, check by the lake. She loves skating."



Chapter 11 - Get Your Skate On

I get why Alvawynn and Perolon have been shut up in their home when we re-enter the commercial district. It's too cheerful. A happy snowman tips his hat and says, "Good day to you! Happy Winterfest!" We pass a cafe, one of Tiasol's supposed haunts, where a flustered shop keeper moans, "Oh no! Adventurers! I just took down the mistletoe!" Mirae and Tako exchange glances, and Tako plants a kiss on her temple. Frobo and I settle for an exchanged look.

The pleasant little woman in her red sweater, blinding green apron, and holly leaves in her hair acts as if missing the chance to see adventurers kiss beneath her mistletoe is the most tragic of holiday tragedies.

She offers a tight smile to Mirae and Tako as if to say, "Thanks for trying."

She sighs, "Next time mayhap. What can I get you? A cup of cocoa to warm your frozen bones?"

I shake my head no. "We're looking for someone named Tiasol, do you know her?"

"I know her." The woman says, "But you just missed her. I think she said something about buying a new scarf. Why don't you check Poinsettia's? That's where I'd go to get a new one this time of year."

I nod my thanks. "We're new around here. Can you give us directions?"

"Oh sure, walk outside." She motions with her hand, "Turn right, and keep walking about two hundred feet. You'll see it on the corner."

"Thank you."

We turn to go.

Poinsettia's is a shop that most definitely lives up to it's name. On it's roof is a giant red and green plant that serves as a welcome sign. It's like seeing the now showing billboard of a movie theater, only floral. I can't tell if it's actually a plant, some kind of sculpture, or a magical illusion.

We walk inside.

Racks of colored scarves, stylish winter gloves, and other fashion accessories greet us with shades of red and green featuring most prominently. I stroke the fabric of a deep red scarf that I'd call burgundy with my fingertip, when a wiry man, in black slacks and a red vest says, "That color would look wonderful on you. It matches the lovely Winterfest cheer of your green eyes."

"Oh.. err. Thanks. Actually, we're looking for someone named Tiasol. Do you know her?"

"Lady Tiasol? Of course. You just missed her. She bought a new scarf, a bit thicker than that one, would you like to see?"

I shake my head, "Just some pointers on where to find her, if you have any."

He grasps the end of his chin like an ice cream cone. "Well, you might try Frosty Skates. She often goes there in the morning to see if she has any last minute students."

"Students?"

"She's an ice skating coach."

"Huh..." I look to Lilly, who purses her lips.

The goblin grumbles, "We'll see about that."

"Thank you. Can you give us directions?"

"To Frosty's? Sure. It's near the lake. Just follow the road that way." He gestures to the left, "And take the path to the right just before the residential district. You'll see a big snowman. Can't miss it."

I give him a friendly smile as we depart.

I look to Lilly with an inquisitive expression. "I thought you'd have been happy about ice skating."

"Ice skatin' sure. I'm all about it but she's a trainer. She doesn't teach skatin', just a bunch of fluff so people can spend their points. People ain't got respect for all the hard work it takes to learn how to do it in the real world."

"I guess I see your point. I'm no more a martial artist in Seattle than you are a summoner."

"Exactly. People go to trainers like her and can do jumps that look cool as shit without actually earning it. It bugs me. It bugs just about everyone whose a pro."

My mind goes back to Pehrom's rants about Haven cooking being bullshit. "I think I get why your game character's so different from what I know about you in Meatsville. Freehaven Online's about wish fulfillment, and when you're already an expert you've accomplished the dream."

"Whateva you say boss. I just don't like hacks."

We turn right along a gentle slope leading to a lake. A giant illuminated snowman waves twig arms like a real world advertising balloon. *He wasn't kidding when he said we couldn't miss it.* We step inside, and are greeted by an elf in a black fleece vest with a mini-holiday wreath pinned to his chest. He's startled at first to see us, "Adventurers? Happy Winterfest!"

Lilly says, "Yeah, yeah. We're lookin' for Tiasol, you seen her?"

Taken aback, by the Goblin's confrontational demeanor, the guy behind the counter shakes his head. "You just missed her."

"Of course we did. We've been missin' her all afternoon. What's new?"

"If you're looking for a lesson, you can find her on the lake. She has no students today. Would you like..."

"Guy... No disrespect, but I can skate circles around that pointy eared..." She fishes for a word, "Somethin'. I don't need lessons."

The shop keeper, Frosty by the name plate, (*That must be a nickname.*) explodes in a torrent of laughter. "Ah ha ha!!" He beats the counter with his fist. "I'm sorry. I also don't mean to be rude, but do you have any idea what you're saying?" He's still struggling

to keep his giggles under control. "She's Arctica's three time reigning champion. It's good to be confident but..."

"If that's a challenge, I'll go against her any time or place."

The mirth leaves Frosty's face. "You're serious."

"As a heart attack." The way she says heart sounds very Bostony.

"Let's go down to the lake, and you can show me your skills. Impress me, and I'll arrange the competition myself."

"Sounds great, but what do I get when I win?"

"What do you want?"

Lilly looks around the shop, first walking over to a wall of boots that are on display, and then to a showcase full of blades which attach separately. "Damn. You actually got some nice stuff here. Mad respect. I haven't seen this kind of selection outside a private collection."

Frosty puffs up, under the praise. "Winterland has some of the best blade and boot makers in the world."

"If you were the dwarf I'd be laughing, but with these wares, I believe it. Tell ya what. I skate against

Tiasol, and if I win she gives me a personal favor."
She mouths the word quest to me.

"I can't agree for her, but if she's amenable that should be no probl-"

"...AND you give me that set of blades." Lilly grins widely.

Frosty gags like he's got something caught in his throat. "Those? Are you sure. Most people can't use them."

Curious what all the commotion is all about I inspect the item.

Ultima Blades of the San'ta**Type:**

Misc

(Figure Skating Blades)

Quality:

Epic

Bonus Stats:

+8 Dexterity, +3 Stamina, +4 Charisma

Restrictions:

Must have Skating (Figure Skating): 15 to use.

*"Toe pick!"***Use:**

Attaches to figure skating boots

Cost: 4,000 Gold

"Damn. Those are expensive."

Tako gapes, "They don't even kill anything."

"Oh they slay." Lilly pauses, "The competition!"

She winks and cackles.

"Ooooooggggg. That was painful. You'd really spend so much money on something that doesn't even help you with questing?"

"They'll help with skating quests, but it don't matter because I ain't payin' cuz I'm gonna win."

Frosty, now coming out of his shock says, "I can't give you a set of our best blades based on one match." Lilly frowns. "I'm willing to lend them to you if you win, and agree to sign a magical contract. Come back for our annual competition, and if you place then, they are yours."

Before anyone has time to react, Lilly says, "Done," She looks to me. "I just got a quest. Now lets go see this lake you're so proud of."

I get the sneaking sensation that she's actually referring to the AI skate trainer, rather than the actual lake. Approaching our destination, I can see six or seven skaters of varying skills gliding across the ice. A few less experienced elves take their tumbles, while others engage in simple jumps, momentarily lifting off the ice, turning and landing smoothly. There's one woman however in a red vest with white sleeves that stands apart from the rest, as she jumps once, twice, three times in a row spinning multiple times, and landing like a ghost.

I look to Lilly, "That must be her."

"I hate her."

I arch an eyebrow inviting explanation.

"Look how happy she is, all pale blonde and perfect. If I see someone workin' on a routine I want their face to show concentration."

I snicker, "Sour grapes?"

"Fuck that. I'll beat her. I just don't like happy people in training."

We're now standing at the edge of the lake which pulses with red, yellow, green and blue lights like someone had frozen LEDs in the ice. It's a cool effect that reminds me of disco bowling.

"What's up with the colors?"

Frosty motions to the lake. "They're fish. When people skate they like swimming up to the surface. You see the light when they open their mouths."

"They must be magic."

Frosty nods. "They are. At night you can sit on the bank and the lights are smaller, like swirling stars."

I nod, imagining a scenic moving picture in my mind's eye, and then sigh remembering our quest. "I'd like to see it. Perhaps if I have a chance to come back."

"We'd be glad to see you Lady Lord Melpomine." Frosty turns to Lilly. "Put on your skates, and we'll see if there will even be a match."

She grumbles going through her VT... something about not having any faith or respect. "This'll be weird."

Never worn in any of my skating' gear on my goblin alias, but I don't feel like switching over."

Rather than stripping down on the side of the ring, she makes a few taps on her VT, and suddenly adventuring gear is replaced by white skates, and an elegant black ice skating competition dress with one long sleeve, with glittering silver rhinestones.

"Alright, I'm ready, what do ya want?"

"Why don't we start with a basic jump?"

"Basic jump." Lilly grumbles. "We ain't got time for this. Just watch."

Lilly makes a large wide circle over the lake, no doubt to warm up, though truth be told I've never heard of Freeworld or Haven imposing penalties for not stretching. It must be a carry over from her real life training. She moves fast, gracefully, and up in the air she goes opening with a triple leaving the ice on her outside edge, spinning three times, and coming down on the outside edge of her other skate. A few seconds later she comes in for another jump where she takes off from a backward position, spins twice in the air and lands.

Looking pleased with herself, she returns to us on the side of the ice. "Good enough?"

Frosty nods, "Good enough." He motions to the blonde elf woman putting everyone else to shame. "Tiasol!"

She glides over with a chipper expression on her face. "Hello! That was a nice triple you landed."

Lilly grumbles. "Thanks." It's praise, but not coming from the source she'd like.

"Are you here for a lesson?" She at least has the sense to look to the people who aren't Lilly when she asks this.

"Actually" Frobod begins, "We heard you're descended from the Ke'b-"

Frosty says, "The green one wants to challenge you."

Clearly talk of skating is more interesting to Tiasol, and her attention drifts between Frosty and Lilly. "Well I'm always up for a good skate. Is this a formal competition?"

"Kind of." Frosty says, "If she wins she wants a personal favor from you, and something from my shop. If you win..."

Tiasol considers. "I think asking a favor from her is just as well, as for prizes..." She eyes Frosty. "Are you willing to make me the same offer."

"Fine..." He says, "... but you're bound by the same terms. If you win it's a loaner until the next annual contest, after that you have to place first, second, or third to keep the item. You also have to hang around and meet people in my shop if you place and keep the item."

"I can accept that."

"Are we gonna skate this thing or what?"

Frobod asks, "Who are the judges?"

Frosty looks back to his shop. "I'll judge. It's the same risk to me either way." He whistles a loud sound that carries over the ice and echoes off the surrounding mountains. "Gather round everyone! It's time for a contest."

* * * * *

Lilly beams at her new blades. "Ya know, even if it weren't for the log out quest item reward, I've gotta say coming here has all been worth it." She hugs her prize to her chest.

We're sitting in Frosty's shop with Tiasol, who took her defeat with smiles and disgustingly good grace. I can see how someone like this could get on your nerves. "So what favor did you ask of me."

"Lilly hops on a chair to stand taller and more imposing. I want your blood!... and a hair sample."

That makes the elf's smile falter. "Excuse me?"

"Pahrem sit down, please."

Frobod begins, "It's about Great Uncle Winter. We've heard about what's going on and Alvawynn told us that you're descended from the only elves that have the recipe to fix him. We're pretty sure we can find them if you can let us borrow something connected to one of your family members."

Tiasol frowns. "That was a long time ago, and I don't have much. Anything I do have is sentimental. How would you use it?"

"We think we can use..." I pause wondering if I should use the word 'alien' or not and decide to leave it out. I cover by clearing my throat and starting again. "We think we can use magic to find them if we have an object of personal significance to them."

Lilly says, "Blood and hair! C'mon, think about it. That's gotta be more potent."

A worried expression crosses her face. "This is a big favor. You're warmlanders. You could hex me."

"We could also save Christmas."

I correct Lilly, "Save Winterfest."

"Yeah, save Winterfest and the San'ta if this works. You'll be a frickin' hero."

She sighs, "I want to save Great Uncle Winter, but blood magic worries me. If I agree to this...." She pauses. "Can you do me a favor?"

Lilly looks like she's about to protest, so I speak before she can mess it up, "What is it?"

"Take a portrait of our family to my father, so he can see his grandson, and return with any word he might send. His name is Rurodin, and my mom's Helsidol."

I nod. "That's reasonable. Do you have any idea where they fled?"

She shakes her head no. "At the time everyone was just angry and upset. The plan was just to leave here, and make a life for themselves wherever they ended up."

I sigh. "I guess that's why we need magic. I agree to your terms. We'll bring a portrait and a message to your father if you provide us with the ritual components we need to find them. We'll also return with any correspondence they choose to send."

Tiasol looks uneasy, "It's only because of Great Uncle Winter that I agree to this. Blood Magic is... unclean and taboo. We don't do it here."

I glance to Annette whose just been watching the interaction until now, "If it makes you feel better it's

more like druid or shamanism. It's not like the blood rites you're probably thinking of. We are working with Winter, with a capital W to restore the balance."

Tiasol's eyes widen the tiniest bit. "I... Wow... This changes everything."

"How so?"

"Few of us have ever seen Lady Frost in person, and yet... she's sent you on a mission. That makes you... something of a priestess or a prophet."

Probably because we have a Rodekin in the group. I shake my head no, and indicate Annette. "If we have a priestess it's her."

"More like a priestess in training." Annette says.

"Wow. It'd be honestly surprising to hear something like this from the short eared." I raise a brow. "You and him are both short eared..." She also indicates Tako, the other half elf in the group. "The humans are round eared."

"What does that make me?" Lilly wiggles her enormous batty ears. *I didn't realize goblins could do that.*

Tiasol just shakes her head, as if to say she had no words for Lilly. "... but a round eared human? It's a wonder you even know of Lady Frost's existence."

"She's ah... not exactly a normal human. Her kind have a close bond with the spirits of nature."

"It seems so." Tiasol muses. "There's no other explanation, in any case it makes me feel better about giving what you ask, if Winter requests it."

Tako says, "Technically Winter just asked us to restore the balance.... Which means redeeming Great Uncle Winter.... Which means asking you for help..."

Tiasol considers, "I'll do what I can to help restore the balance then." She seems less easy after Tako's comments.

Going out on a limb I say, "Would you like to meet her?"

Tiasol inclines her head, "Meet who?"

"Winter... Lady Frost. We'll need to call on her soon. Would you like to be present to see her."

The elf blinks, then stares blankly. "Me? Meet Winter?"

I shrug, "Why not?"

She opens her mouth but no words come out, "I'm hardly worthy. You should be speaking to a priestess."

"We could, but it just so happens that it's your blood we need." I shrug, then consider, "If you're afraid of the actual cutting we could try calling Winter and see

if she can make do with just having your body for the ritual, rather than bleeding. For all I know it could work even better with you physically present." Tiasol looks overwhelmed. "How about this. For now, give us a lock of hair. We'll try the spell. If it doesn't work we'll call Winter."

Tiasol nods, and takes the end of her long pony tail in her hands. I look to Annette. "Give her your knife." The Rodekin obliges, and Tiasol cuts away a small bunch of her hair. She returns the knife with the hair sample back to Annette.

"Let's see if this works."



Chapter 12 - Flux

We walk around the lake until we're well away from the skaters, and we have privacy. It's now time for me to try teaching Annette the Rite of the Seeking Stone by tying the hair off at the end of a string, and having her dangle it in front of her.

"Reach out to Winter the way you did before, and give mental voice to your intentions."

The wind stirs a bit, then stops. Annette tries again. The wind seems to pick up, and abruptly dies. This goes on for about ten minutes, and Annette's losing her patience.

I sigh, "Wait. I'll switch alts and try for myself."

I pull up the Alias menu in my VT, and pick my Rodekin character.

Alias:**Lilly****Magical - Human (Wererat - Rodekin) - Female****Rank: Perfect (Grandfathered)****Options:****Change Alias****Infect Current****Cancel**

I select change, as streamers of psychedelic magic swirl in the air engulfing me. I'm colder, as my default gear changes with the shifting alt. I'm now wearing bellbottom pants, a tie-dye shirt, and oversized pink heart shaped glasses. There are now two Lillys in the group, the goblin, whose official user name is SalemLilly, and me L, i lower case l, capital i, y. aka Squeaks, as goblin Lilly likes to call me.

I'm in human form. I take the lock of hair attached to the string in hand, and concentrate on winter, and performing the Rite of the Seeking Stone. It fails immediately.

Rite of the Seeking Stone Failed.**Target out of range.**

I sigh, pull out my VT, and switch back to my half-elf Melpomine character before my rage venting meter starts building up. Streamers of black and deep brown to match my adventuring gear, enwrap me as I change back to my main character. "It's not Annette's fault. The Rite isn't powerful enough to find anyone on the planet. We have to be within a certain range."

Frodo asks, "What's the range?"

I shrug, "I don't know. Never heard of it failing before, but then I've also never heard of someone trying to use it on a different continent from the target. It's a level one rite."

"Alright, so what's the plan?"

"I say we march back around the lake, get Tiasol, and ask Winter for the help she promised." I look to everyone. "Sit tight while I go get her."

Tiasol takes a moment to get out of her skates, and walk around the lake with me. I'm not up for skating. She looks apprehensive. "Sorry the hair didn't work out. The spell we had in mind doesn't work when you're looking for something so far away."

She nods. "I don't know how to act around Winter."

"Relax. She's nice. It's no big deal."

Tiasol looks unconvinced. "So far she's been nothing but helpful."

We're now approaching the rest of the party. I look to Annette, "Ready?"

"Do I need to...." She makes a jerking motion with her whole body to mime changing.

I shake my head. "No, it doesn't matter what shape you wear when you call the spirits. They'll recognize you for what you are."

Lilly passes her a candle from her inventory, makes a simple motion with her dagger, and touches it to the wick. It ignites. "Here ya go. She said somethin' about quenchin' fire."

"Alright..." Annette pinches the flame out with her bare fingers, it makes a little 'tsss' sound. Now she has her eyes closed and is trying to focus. She places the spent candle in her hands as the offering, and holds them cupped above her head like she did before.

The wind beats about our clothing. Tiasol tenses. Compared to our summoning outside Ureota's cave, Winter's appearance is damn near instantaneous,

bursting into our little clearing in a pop of cold blue and white magic.

"By Frost..." Tiasol murmurs, and drops to her knees.

Winter regards Annette, then eyes the elf. "Child of Rat, I answer your call. Who is this?"

Annette hesitates, "This is Tiasol. She's an elf."

Winter seems to be getting bored, now that she has more power, and her attention drifts taking in the environment. "Explain..."

I move closer to Annette so I can guide her through it. "Go ahead and tell her about the source of corruption and how to fix it."

Annette nods. "We've found the source of the corruption. It's Great Uncle Winter, and we know how to restore the balance."

This seems to interest the elemental, and her attention stops wandering as her eyes meet Annette's. "Well done, child." She offers a genuine smile. "I trust you are now in need of my assistance to accomplish the task I've set for you."

Annette nods, "There's a..." She stumbles over the word, perhaps finding it too silly to speak to a major spirit, "Cookie recipe in the world, that can return Great Uncle Winter to goodness, and restore the

balance, but we can't find it. We tried to use a Seeking Stone, but it didn't work."

Winter nods, "Yes, I've felt it."

"We need you to help us find them, and take us there."

"I see." Winter considers. Looking over the San'ta. "... and who is Tiasol the elf?"

"Her family was among the many San'ta who abandoned Arctica centuries ago taking with them the recipe that could restore the balance. We're hoping..." Annette looks to me for confidence. I give her a thumbs up and motion for her to keep going. "We're hoping you can use her to find her relatives, who can then provide us with the recipe."

"A tall order." Winter says musing, "Far more complex than a simple seeking stone, and I trust you'll want to take all of these with you." Winter waves her hand to indicate our party, Annette nods.

"This I can do, but first you must do for me."

Annette tenses, having not expected additional demands from the spirit, but keeps her mouth shut. *Relax, this is how the spirits work.* "Yes?"

"Winterfest comes to this world, and I am of the understanding a child brought you here." Annette nods.

"Reunite the child with her family, and I will do this thing."

"You want us to kill her family?" Annette asks.

Winter smiles. "Must you?"

"I don't know she's dead, it was her doll we found in Hades that brought us here." Winter continues to smile, waiting for the Rodekin to come up with an answer herself. "You want us to bring Reilynn's ghost to Winterland."

"I do. To accomplish this, bring the doll you mentioned to the Flux Place, and combine it with my winter essence." She pushes a small crystal into Annette's hand that shines like a light bulb of pure white light, the technical item name is 'winter core.' "When you have returned I will teach you a rite of spirit binding, so that she and her family can be together."

I look to Annette, "Flux is dangerous, but we can handle it. Winter should take us there."

Annette nods.

For the first time I can remember, Winter addresses me directly, "... and you Tutor of Child of Rat. See that she makes new magic. She's among the first spirit born of this world. I'd like to make an offering to her new hosts. Think of it as chimnage for her passing into this world."

"Err... Okay. I'll... see that she does that."

Until now, I wasn't even aware that Winter had noticed me. Non-corporeal elementals don't tend to give people who aren't Freeworld weres the time of day.

"Good. Go now, and return quickly." Winter waves her pale hand and tears a rip in the air in front of us, not unlike Lilly's summoning of the Stone Throwing Devil. Unlike that rip however, nothing climbs out and it seems not to disappear as quickly as it came. Peering through is a continually shifting landscape with a yellow sun and green trees that melt into rock formations beneath a purple sky. Then back to trees, to waist high shrubberies.

Quest Update: Winter Dungeonland - Part 2a**Difficulty: Hard**

Winter has offered her assistance in finding the Ke'bla elves, in exchange for reuniting Reilynn with her family. To do this, you must journey to "The Flux Place" to merge a relic dolly, with a winter core. While she's there, Annette must also learn a new method of healing, to present to the people of Haven.

Objectives:

Enter Flux	0/1
Merge winter core with dolly relic	0/1
Annette discovers new magic	0/1
Reilynn's family reunited	0/1

Mirae, Lilly, and Tako eye the opening, but Lilly's the one that speaks. "Do any of you know what the Flux Place is?"

Tako asks, "Is that like the thing those Coldwash ghosts did?"

Frobod nods. "It's a Freeworld thing, but I've never been there."

I indicate the portal, and then look to Tako. "Kind of, and no. It's a spirit realm where everything is mutable. Things and creatures change by the second and take on new properties. Sometimes they lose them. It can also be a place where you combine things, merging the essence of two objects to create one unique item."

Frobod nods, "I've heard of people going in there as werewolves, and coming out as were-panthers, or spiders.

Lilly looks aghast, "It can change us like that?"

I nod. "It can, but it's pretty uncommon. You have to spend a lot of time in Flux for it to change you into something you didn't want. According to the lore it happens all the time, but from a business perspective, players would be pretty mad if every time they went there they came back as a new race or had a new set of abilities. Now it's more of an 'enter at your own risk' situation where probably nothing will happen, but maybe it could."

Frobod says, "Sounds like it's time to go get that dolly."

* * * * *

About forty five minutes later we've reconvened at our spot beside the lake where the portal to Flux continues to shimmer and undulate. Alvawynn was understandably loathe to give up Rei's dolly, but Tiasol came as a surprising help in explaining Winter's role in our quest. I guess it helped to have a local vouch for our story. Apparently, she's akin to a local deity here that the Winterland residents refer to as Lady Frost.

"Dolly, check. Winter core, check. ... I think that's everything we need." We leave Tiasol behind since I suspect she's no combatant. "I'll take point."

I step through the portal.

WARNING: You are about to enter Flux. Entering Flux may result in permanent changes to your character's appearance, race, and or abilities. As of Freeworld Online becoming Freehaven Online, the chance for mutation while in Flux has been increased by 25%, however all changes incurred may be undone via rebirthing within one month of the transformation.

Do you wish to proceed? Yes / No

I whistle. "Damn. Do you see this prompt? I think the old mutation rate was like two percent."

Lilly laughs. "Awesome. Maybe we'll get something good!"

"Maybe, or you might get a monkey arm growing out of your butt instead of a tail. Just... stay focused, and try not to touch anything. If you can do ranged attacks it should reduce the risk of changes. The faster we can get in and out the better."

Frobod unequips his greatsword. "Got it."

Tako says, "What if I want a monkey arm for a tail?" but equips his bow anyway.

"Here goes nothing."

I choose yes.

I step through the portal, and arrive into what appears to be a rocky fissure. The air is room temperature. The sun is green... and now it's red... and a proper yellow... Now green again. It shifts through random colors like it's a giant peering at us through different colored sun glasses, and it can't decide which pair to wear. And now grass is growing on rocks that were bone dry moments before.

As the rest of the party files through the portal behind me I say, "This place is trippy."

Frobod asks, "What are we supposed to do now?"

"Let's not stray too far from the portal since it may be our one constant. Annette, let's see the Winter Core and dolly."

She holds one in each hand.

"I wanna go home."

I startle, and look around, trying to spot incoming creatures.

"I wanna go home."

Annette says, "It's the doll, it just started talking."

"I am winter." A few second pause. "I am winter."

"I wanna go home."

"I am winter."

Lilly comes in for a closer look. "They're both talkin'.... like they're having a conversation or somethin'."

"I wanna go home."

"I am winter."

It's so strange, though the words each time are exactly the same, the tone of voice shifts so that I can almost imagine that they are having a conversation. I look to Annette. "I think you have to convince them to come together."

"I wanna go home."

She looks to me. "How am I supposed to do that?"

I shrug. "I'll try." I move closer to the objects in her hands. "Reilynn, is that you?"

"I wanna go home."

"Do you want to see your mommy?"

"I wanna go home."

"It's kind of hot out here, huh?" In fact, it's comfortable in the mid 70s or so degrees if I had to guess, but it's positively blazing compared to Arctica.

"I am Winter."

"You're a long way away from where you should be."

At the same time, I hear "I wanna go home." and "I am winter."

Mirae says, "This is weird. I don't know how to explain it, but I think they understand you."

I nod. "This is a spirit world where objects, creatures, and forces have personalities."

Mirae tries addressing the objects. "Do you remember what home was like? Do you remember Winterland?"

"I wanna go home."

"I am Winter."

Mirae reaches for the doll and looks to Annette, "May I?"

Annette, looking flummoxed nods, and hands both objects over.

Mirae strokes the doll's hair. "We met your mommy today, and she misses you."

"I wanna go home."

"I know dear, but we can't get you home without Winter's help."

"I am winter."

"Yes," Mirae continues, "You're part of winter, and she'll need you back soon, but we brought you here to help bring Reilynn back."

"I wanna go home."

"I am winter."

I raise an eye brow. "Are you sure you've never been to Flux before? You're good at this."

She shrugs, looks to me, and says, "I think I know why Winter needs us to bring these two together. It's all about domains... or spheres of influence that they have or don't have control over. "

"How do you mean?"

"Winter is a deity of cold and the season of winter, so in order to act upon Reilynn, she needs to be connected to one of the things that Winter represents. Reilynn's... " She pauses, eyeing the doll, "In a place that Winter doesn't have control over, and this relic is a connection to Reilynn. By infusing the relic with the Winter Core, it brings her spirit within Winter's influence."

I nod, "I think I understand."

Something bellows in the distance, somewhere in the canyon.

"We better hurry."

Mirae nods. "Winter?"

"I am winter."

"I need you to take hold of Reilynn's dolly so we can bring you both back home."

"I wanna go home." A tone of nervousness in that voice.

"I am winter." A note of thoughtfulness.

Mirae strokes the doll's hair, "It's okay love. We're going to bring you to see your family for Winterfest. Wouldn't you like that?"

"I wanna go home." I can almost imagine a little girl sniffing "Yes.." while wiping away tears.

"I need you to take Winter's hand then and hide it in your pocket. I need you two to come together so we can bring you home as one. Wouldn't you like to get out of this."

"I wanna go home."

Mirae puts the glowing Winter Core into the doll's arms and something happens... The core shines brighter.

"I wanna go home." Uncertainty.

"I am winter." *We can do it!*

"I wanna go home." *I'm scared.*

"I am winter." *Open up.*

"Shhhhhh..." Mirae says, and places a kiss on the doll's forehead. "Be brave little one, and let Winter

inside. It wasn't too long ago that I was in a situation just like you, and I was scared..."

"I wanna go home." *Really?*

Footsteps pounding. An bestial moan. "Guys... Try to hurry if you can, Something's coming this way."

Mirae nods as if to say 'I'm working on it!' and coos in a soothing voice. "I was, and now I'm back and everything is okay. Just like you, I had to change. I was away from my friends and family, but now I can see them every day."

"I wanna go home."

"I am winter."

Three things happen at exactly the same time. A bright blue light flashes in Mirae's palms causing a globe of Winter's magic to encapsulate the dolly. A massive hippo, the size of an elephant, with a tail that reminds me of a blue whale bursts through the side of the canyon wall. It's like the Kool Aid Man, only uglier.

It bellows, and breathes hot breath that smells of pina colada. *This place is so weird.*

"Guys... I can't let go of the doll. My hands are stuck to it."

"Crap! Can you heal?"

"I can't do anything but talk and run away."

"Do that, but don't go to far! Annette, you're on heals!"

"I.." Annette starts, "I don't know if I.."

The hippo snorts. It's face pops like a bubble, and becomes a baby's head. It's so small relative to the gigantic body, it's like a little pimple.

Lilly scrunches her face looking up, "Are we supposed to attack this thing?"

It stomps it's oversized hippo foot, and then "WAAAAAAHHHHHH!!!" The ear splitting shriek of a colicky baby. As it's mouth opens to wail, rainbows shoot out like unicorn farts, bathing the entire world in Lifesaver colors. At first I think we're okay, until I realize my armor's smoking, I look to Lilly and her gear has tendrils of darkness rising from it, and Frobod.

Rainbow Hits you for 4 Acid Damage.

You resist 4 points of damage.

Rainbow hits you for 6 acid damage.

You resist 5 points of damage.

Rainbow hits you for 7 acid damage.

You resist 7 points of damage.

Lilly sprints the opposite direction, yelling "Holy shit! That baby barfs acidic rainbows."

I'm not far behind joining her, we're all running the same way, just barely out of the rainbow's reach. I'm breathing heavy. Something about the attack makes me feel winded. "I'm not even going to try to engage with my staff, less I come out of this with a baby head. "

The creature stops, "WAAAAHH!" and starts spewing more caustic rainbows that we all continue inching away from. My ears are rattling.

I launch my Darksteel Chakram at the monster's chest and shout, "Hey!"

Taunt. Successful.**Fluxbeast Rainbowpotamus Attacks.**

I sprint away from the rest of the party, bathing in residual rainbow, and taking another ten percent damage. Thank God for stamina. The squishier party members are far worse off.

I switch to party chat. "Ranged DPS go! Heal!"

Mirae's hands and the dolly are still encased in the magic blue globs, "I can't do anything while I'm holding the dolly, so don't count on me."

"Understood. Stay safe."

Lilly's health slowly creeps up, thirty percent... forty... The same with Frobod's. It's so much slower than with a trained healer. Suddenly Tako's health jumps from fifty percent to one-hundred.

Annette says, "I don't know what just happened. My spell exploded."

"This is Flux, expect weird shit to happen. It's getting into your magic."

Rainbow's heavy footsteps pound behind me as I retreat, as the little head screams, throwing deadly waves of color on everything it passes. Grassy purple rocks melt and turn to sludge, only for a fully grown

palm tree to spring up in their place. The creature's so big, I can't see exactly what everyone else is doing, but Lilly gives some commentary.

"What the hell? My Cinderburst just turned into a flying broken air conditioner!"

"Did it do damage?"

"Yeah but..."

"Then keep going!"

By now Lilly's almost back to 80% health. That's good.

"I've got a rock."

Sounds like she called stony.

"This place turned my devil into the Easter Bunny!"

A fleshy impact paired with a renewed shriek tells me that it's still throwing rocks. Rainbow health, sixty percent.

I turn back to throw another chakram, when I'm hit with a new debuff.

Flux Poisoning

Random Stat (Dexterity) reduced by 80%

Duration: 10 seconds.

I go down, with a sharp pain in my ankle and my face in the dirt. Rainbow wails, bathing me in hurtful color.

Rainbow Hits you for 3 Acid Damage.

You resist 3 points of damage.

Rainbow hits you for 5 acid damage.

You resist 5 points of damage.

Rainbow hits you for 10 acid damage.

You resist 8 points of damage.

I'm now at seventy percent health, on the ground, prone, and bathed in pina colada brightness that's consuming my defenses. The baby suddenly stops. I'm afraid to look as I scramble to my feet. It burps, slow and powerful. The face contorts, warps and explodes like a wad of bubblegum transforming into the head of a Baboon with a polka dot bow tie.

It looks down at me and says "Dear Lord, are you alright? Miss, you look positively dreadful. What ever did you fall in?"

I'm beginning to think this incarnation of the Rainbowpotamus may be non violent, when a spell strikes it from behind, creating a mushroom cloud like a nuclear warhead. It's health drops by another forty percent leaving only twenty remaining.

The baboon groans."That wasn't sociable. I won't have it!" It begins to turn. Lightning bolts spark from its eyes. "Hey monkey. Eat this!" I chuck my darksteel chakram. It leaves my hand just before the dexterity debuff wears off, so I miss by a mile, but at least the taunt works.

Taunt. Successful.

Fluxbeast Monkeypotamus attacks.

I'm expecting laser lightning eyes, but instead, the hippo baboon comes in for the classic trample. There's not much space for me to dodge, and I'm swept under it's massive body.

I'm down on the ground again. Bones crunch within my body. I whimper. "Help..." Pain, in this game

is diminished, but it still doesn't feel good to be crushed.

My health's down to thirty percent, and I have no idea where I'll respawn if I die in this place. Bowtie Baboon says, "You're not being sociable!"

Here comes the lightning.

Annette screams, "I'm too far away!"

A jolt of electricity hits me, seizing up every muscle in my body. I can feel my hair rising and standing on end. Ten percent remaining.

Fuck.

An arrow hits me.

"What the..?" *Friendly fire?*

I expect to be staring down at my lifeless corpse as a ghost, in just a moment, but instead my health leaps back up to fifty. Another arrow hits me in the chest, it stings for half a second before my life springs back up to eighty. My bones are mending. It's like Cupid's arrow, but instead of falling in love I'm ready to kick ass.

"What are you doing?"

Annette shouts, "New magic!"

Tell me about it. Monkey hippo comes in to stomp me. THUMP... CRUNCH... against the rocky

earth, but I'm able to roll out of the way and scramble to my feet.

"Boss at 20%, burn it down."

The hippo's eyes light up, as I prepare for another blast of lightning. Frobod hits it in the face with a necro bolt, and Lilly launches a ball of fire... that transforms into an air conditioner, that detonates on impact sending shrapnel everywhere.

SalemLilly casts Cinderburst

Cinderburst (FluxWarped) you for 3 damage.

You resist 3 points of damage.

Wacky place.

Tako shoots an arrow which turns into a viper mid flight, and sinks its teeth into our opponent. It drops to the ground, "Ugh!" My heart quickens, as I scurry the opposite direction. *I hate serpents.* Thankfully, it goes the other way.

Boss health, five percent. It's bleeding from its wounds, and its face looks red and puffy from Tako's snake-arrow thing. My dexterity's back, I aim, and launch my at the Fluxbeast's body. THWAK! It embeds deep in the creature's flesh. It falls to the

ground, as a monkey head whispers. "not... sociable..." Citizen Kane, Rosebud style.

The body despawns, not in the customary silent fade to nothing with a tidy chest in it's place, but with the sound of New Year's party poppers, and sparklers. In it's place, however, is a small velvet sack in a shade of blood red.

A giant, pot bellied Easter Bunny chews on a hearty carrot. I give Lilly a questioning look.

Her face looks as confused as mine feels. "That's what came out of the portal."

Frobod says, "I want to get out of here. This place is too weird."

I bend down to gather the loot. "I agree."

You have received:

Rebirthing Crystal x5

Rebirthing Crystal

Special Object

Description:

A small prismatic stone filled with limitless possibility.

Use:

Swallow to initiate rebirth.

Mirae holds up the Mangled Dolly. "Whatever was happening before, it's done. I can move." Frost crystals cling to its face, and snowflakes fall from beneath its dress like a frost weapon enchant.

Quest Update: Winter Dungeonland - Part 2a**Difficulty: Hard**

Winter has offered her assistance in finding the Ke'bla elves, in exchange for reuniting Reilynn with her family. To do this, you must journey to "The Flux Place" to merge a relic dolly, with a winter core. While she's there, Annette must also learn a new method of healing, to present to the people of Haven.

Objectives:

Enter Flux	1/1
Merge winter core with dolly relic	1/1
Annette discovers new magic	1/1
Reilynn's family reunited	0/1

Return to Reilynn's family home in Winterland and complete the necessary binding ritual to complete this quest.

"They merged then?"

Mirae nods. "I think so."

"Then let's get the hell out of here."

Stepping back through the portal from Flux fills me with a sense of significant relief. It's so good to see sky a proper color again. The air is cool, and I like it. It makes me feel alive. Before I forget, I give each PC a rebirthing crystal, since I doubt they are of any use to Annette.

I look everyone over. "Everyone got all their limbs?"

Frobod says, "I think so."

"Anyone have any extras?"

Mirae laughs, "I don't think so."

Lilly looks like she just ate a sour fruit. "That place messed with my magic."

Tako nocks an arrow and looses over the lake. He frowns. "It didn't turn into a snake... I was hoping that was permanent."

"Some things stick, and others don't. In your case, I think it was just the arrow that changed, rather than your archery ability."

Lilly pulls out her daggers, "Awe shit, are you sayin' my spells might be broken? Take cover. I'm about to set something on fire."

She waves her blades in an intricate pattern, and they glow bright red. A wave of heat hit's us in the face,

as the goblin target's a stump a dozen paces away. It explodes in a fiery burst.

"Thank God! No air conditioners!"

Tako chuckles. "I don't know, I thought they were kinda cool. You'd be the only one to have them."

"We ought to get to Reilynn's house and get summoning."

Tako says, "I'm kinda hungry. Do you guys mind stopping for food first?"

"I'm good with that."

Mirae says, "Sure, I'll bet there's a cooking shop in town with ingredients so we can make our own stuff."

I nod, "Don't forget we've got Goblin BBQ."

Tako smiles, and pulls a dried strip of meat from his inventory. "I totally forgot about that."

"We'll get supplies, build a fire, and eat before we summon."

Frobod nods, "Sounds like a plan."

Tako says, "Just like my momma always said, never summon a ghost on an empty stomach."



Chapter 13 - Reunion

We're sitting around a campfire near to where we departed and returned from Flux. The Winterland merchants had indeed unprepared hare meat, and venison for purchase. We stuck with rabbits to keep things small and simple, and roasted the meat slathered with Pahrem's BBQ sauce on spits. There's no special food buffs, but my it's tasty. The sun's going down, and I realize that we skipped lunch.

Frobod says, "I never notice I'm hungry until someone says something, and then it's overpowering"

"It's usually like that for me to."

Mirae shrugs. "I haven't been hungry because I've been chewing on jerky all day."

Lilly smirks. "I guess that makes you smarter than the rest of us."

Annette scrunches her nose. "I'll never understand how you all eat that stuff. It's so...." She shudders, and consumes a fully prepared meal, a portion of roast, that was purchased in the market. "Just because you put something in a fire doesn't mean you're cooking."

"It's an adventurer thing. All of the food you like to eat, tastes to us like a whole lot of nothing. We get texture, but no flavor."

"That sounds horrible, and doesn't make any sense."

I shrug. "It's difficult to explain." with added *to an NPC* in my mind.

"Congratulations, by the way, on your magic. Your arrow heals are pretty impressive."

Annette shrugs. "It wasn't logical that I could infuse a dagger with a fire ball, but not an arrow with restoration."

I just nod, and shrug, because I don't have a good answer.

If this were the real world she'd be exactly right, but it's not. I didn't think the game was made for that. Annette's new form of healing, a cross between Lilly's

dagger hexing and Mirae's archery and heals, infuses mending and protective spells into arrows so that they heal whomever they hit. Unlike Lilly however, she's lost the ability to bind harmful spells to daggers.

To her, and given the nature of Flux, it makes sense. Objects and concepts in close proximity are the most likely to merge, as well as those that are in the forefront, or even back of a person's mind. In that way, 'The Flux Place,' as Winter calls it, is a bit like a dream that teeters back and forth between simply intense, and lucid.

It kinda makes me wonder what Pahrem was thinking about when she manifested window air conditioning units and the Easter Bunny. From a developer's perspective I wonder who took the time to skin something like that, then I consider the magical post apocalyptic Freeworld cityscapes, and realize there are probably quite a few broken ACs in the game. *They didn't have to work.*

Mirae eyes Annette's noobtastic bow. "We're going to have to get you a better bow. You think you can teach me to do that?"

"She might be able to..." I think, still in my developer mind. "Winter said the whole point was for it to be a gift to the people of Haven for welcoming

Rodekin, and I guess other Freeworld weres, amongst them. I didn't read all the patch notes, so maybe this was something they snuck in while I wasn't looking."

"I dunno." Frobod says, "But it's pretty useful."

"Tell me about it." Lilly starts. "What I wouldn't have given to have had a bunch of healin' archers on top of Cupcake Keep when we were attacked. They wouldn't have stood a chance."

"That reminds me..." I look to Annette. "You're welcome to join our guild if you want to try. We've never had an NPC member, but I was once able to send in invite to one." She stares at me blankly, as the eyebrows of the rest of the party creep higher up their heads.

I decide to address the players first. "I guess none of you were around for that." I look to Lilly, "Your husband had a mage helping him with his garden. On a whim I threw him a guild invite and it worked. He declined, but he was able to receive it."

Mirae considers, "I've never heard of that before. I wonder if it's somehow related to people like me." referring to players who digitized.

"In any case, it looks like the option is open." I look to Annette, prepared to restate my last prior

statements without gaming lingo. "We've never had one of the Havenfolk or Freefolk join our guild. Until recently, we believed it was impossible to have both adventurers and non-adventurers in the same guild, call it a magical prohibition, but that seems to have changed. In any case, if you want to join, we'll have you."

Annette nods, "Of course." I raise a brow, that's a far more ready agreement than the last NPC I invited. "You're the only ones in Haven that know about Rodekin, and the rest fear us for the monsters we resemble." Mostly true, but I don't interrupt her sentiment to inform that other adventurers might know more about Freeworld weres than I do. "This is to say nothing of freeing us from those leeches in Hades. Of course I'll join. How could I not join? You don't even have to ask."

That was, quite possibly, the most impassioned guild acceptance speech I've ever witnessed. It's touching in a world where the typical response to being asked to join is, "Thnx for add."

My VT materializes in my hand, I select Annette, and pull up the guild interface. "I'll send you an invite then."

Annette has joined the guild.

Guild Achievement Unlocked: Local Cooperation

Add an NPC character to your guild by using the invite function.

Rewards:

+1 Diplomacy to guild members

1% Discount on Havenfolk and Freefolk Goods

"Oh." There's a surprised and impressed tone in my voice. "Looks like being cooperative has some benefits."

Mirae adds, "I wonder if they get better if we recruit more."

I shrug. "Don't know, I'm not complaining."

Lilly stares at the achievement in her VT. "I'll bet they do, we should go around recruitin' everyone in Durolan, and give them their own faction in the guild."

I shake my head, remembering Pehrom's mage, "I don't think it's that easy. The essence of the achievement seems to be cooperation, which probably means forming relationships before they accept. The first guy I tried was disturbed when I offered."

"That's odd. What's the point of pushing us to make friends with NPCs?"

"Well..." I begin, "They're a lot more real now, so... maybe that is the point. To form relationships."

Tako looks to Mirae, "This game's becoming a lot more social."

Frobod finishes off the last of his meat. "What do you mean?"

"Look at me. Before I pretty much just signed in to kill stuff, get loot, and sign out, right?"

Frobod nods. "I'm following."

"Now, even if I wasn't stuck in game, I have a reason to come back that has nothing to do with adventuring." He flicks his eyes toward Mirae, she dimples. "Dungeons are cool, but with everything coming more alive this is becoming a better place to just hang out."

Lilly says, "It's been like that forever, There's a lot of social shit that most people never bother with, but with the NPCs bein' real and people digitizin'... You're right. It's less like a game, and more like. I don't know.. Takin' a vacation."

I stand. "Well I'm full. Everyone done eating?"

The rest of the party nods. "Let's go see Rei's family."

Returning to the house, I have the doll in hand. It's cold to the touch, whereas before it'd just seemed like any other doll. The eyes are bluer, and a film of frost clings to its face. We knock on the door, and I see there's a collection of new presents. Presenting joyously wrapped gifts must be how the San'ta comfort each other in times of woe.

Perolon answers, and meets me with his ice blue eyes. "You took her dolly." Not a question.

I nod. "We brought it back."

He grunts. "I don't know what Alva's on about. Lady Frost. No one sees the lady, much less a couple of short ears." He holds out his hand. "Give it here."

"We're... not quite done yet. Winter's asked us to... reunite you... for the holiday. "

"A reunion?" He scoffs. "That's a laugh. Just give it here." He reaches out to take the dolly from me, and his hand brushes against its cold face. He freezes in place, as if having been touched by a ghost. It's the kind of frozen that comes with your first ever experience with the supernatural. Chilling, and awed. All I can do is watch until he pulls his hand back. He swallows hard. "Come in."

Frobod turns his head to look at him as he passes into the cozy home. "What was that all about?"

"I don't know."

Perolon says, "Please sit. I'll... I'll get Alvawynn."

He marches out of the front hall and into the kitchen, which has a small door leading to the side of the house.

The steps creek as his wife descends from upstairs. "You've come back."

I nod. "Winter asked us to hurry."

She makes a gesture with her hand like she's tracing an asterisk with her finger. *Is that a snowflake?* I wonder if it's these elves' equivalent to the sign of the cross. "What have you to tell?"

"We're not quite done, but... Winter, Lady Frost, wants your family to be together."

"Thank Frost." she says, "The husband wasn't too pleased when I told him you took Rei's dolly."

Heavy boots stomp as Perolon re-enters the home with arms full of wood. His eyes flicker to his wife. He appears embarrassed, having forgotten his excuse for leaving us. "See you found her then." He dumps the wood in a pile beside the fireplace which has burned down to hot coals. He looks at the doll, staring

intently... and then back to his chopped wood. He assembles a pile of logs, and dry twigs within the hearth, and speaks magical words in his native tongue. "Relenar fiodore!"

The entire room brightens as the fireplace illuminates with crackling flame. No slow build to an inferno like in Meatsville. Our surroundings start to feel more like a home, than just a place people live. Not ours, but welcoming. A place that should have a family.

Perolon, looks to the mantle and then to his wife. "Dearest.. Please fetch the stockings." A quiet settles between them as they meet each other's gazes. A line of thought that feels like it could be cut with scissors. "... All of them."

"I..." Alvawynn begins, and again covers her mouth with her hand. She gives her husband a solemn nod, and finishes simply, "Okay."

She retreats to the upstairs, her footsteps quick compared to the rate at which she descended, with three large stockings in hand. One red for her husband, trimmed in white fur, and gold embroidery. A Green one for herself, with the same white cuff, and elaborate gold designs. She goes about hanging them above the fireplace from small nails I hadn't noticed. The last of the three, the largest and positioned between the other

two, is a cloth booty of pure white. White fur on top to make a matching set, with red embroidery. and a little green bow.

I smile, imagining the girl it must be for.

Mirae must have the same idea as she eyes the largest stocking, but her expression falters. "What if she has heavy death marks?"

I grimace, luckily most ghosts lack outward indicators of how they died, but a few, especially those who suffered horribly violent deaths wear their fatal wounds in the afterlife if the marks of their death have imprinted themselves upon their identity. "Let's just hope that's not the case, or that Winter has made her better."

Alvawynn's about to sit when she says "Oh! I almost forgot." as she darts off to the kitchen. She returns with a hand full of red and white striped candy canes. She eyes the hearth, and then down to us, her guests sitting in a circle on the living room floor. "One for you... and you... and you.." She passes them out to each member of the party before stepping over Tako's head, for he's the closest of us to the fire, and places one in each stocking. She meets her husband's gaze, and drops a second into the largest stocking, with quick last

minute hands that seem to say, "It'll just be our little secret."

I'm just staring, glancing around, marveling at how quickly an environment can transform without the aid of magic.

Tako sucks on the long end of his candy cane, having forgotten they have no flavor. He holds it with his teeth. "At least they still give fresh breath."

I decide to follow his example.

Frobod says, "I guess now's the time to call on Winter."

Alvawynn's breath catches. It can't be easy to hear people speaking casually about summoning your goddess... or whatever Lady Frost is to them.

I pass the frozen dolly to Annette, "Whenever you're ready."

She holds the frigid artifact over her head, and closes her eyes in concentration. Perolon meets the doll's eyes, and looks away, while his wife is transfixed. The air shimmers, as if in a heat haze, but instead hits us with a wave of coldness that contrasts to the hearth fire. *I suppose that's to be expected.*

A miniature image of Lady Frost materializes, so she meets our sitting gazes. "Child of Rat."

"Yes?" Annette asks. She seems more confident calling Winter than before. She must be getting the hang of it.

"You've done well, and I accept your service." She taps Annette's forehead with her index finger. A radiant blue fingerprint shimmers against her skin for a moment like a puddle, before fading. "I give you the knowledge to bring this family back together. Do this for me and return to the lake, there I will send you on your way. The blood I need awaits you there."

Winter's image breaks apart like drifting snowflakes in a snow globe, as a brisk sensation touches my face. I think we're all staring at Annette, but it's Frobod who asks, "What do we have to do?"

"It's..." Annette begins, "Not what I expected." She stands and looks at the tree, only half heartedly decorated. "This needs to be grander." She motions to the kitchen, "There needs to be good smells hanging in the air." She looks to Alvawynn and Perolon, "You need to make this a place Rei will be excited to come home to."

* * * * *

It takes some hours, but you'd be amazed how fast an elf can prepare a feast when properly motivated. Instead of decorating the current tree, poorly watered,

and browning in places, Perolon carted the whole thing out to the back yard, and returned forty five minutes later with a larger, lusher tree strapped to a toboggan. I'm worried it might hit the ceiling, but once erected, the height seems just right. Not very interested in Haven cooking, we all take a hand in hanging ornaments.

Perolon surveys his work with a sad smile. "It's beautiful, but there's still one thing remaining."

I admire the tree, "What's that?"

"Tinsel... If Reilynn had her way every tree would look like it was dipped in silver." He holds out a box of the stringy foil material. "It was her favorite part. Why don't you do the honors?"

I take a small hand full, and begin spreading it about the tree. He does the same, Mirae takes a bunch.

"Daddy?"

My heart about stops when I hear that voice. The red tinsel box hits the floor. Tugging at Perolon's shirt is a little, long eared, yellow haired, elf girl with the most enchanting blue eyes that glow with winter's magic. "I wanna do some too."

The father swallows hard, choking down his emotions, and bends down to pick up the box of tinsel in his left hand, while lifting his daughter with his right.

He takes some of the metallic decoration and pushes it into her little fist. He releases an exaggerated groan as fathers often do. "You're getting so big!"

As it turns out, Rei does in fact, delight in silvering the tree...

"The ham is almost read-"

"Mom!" Rei squirms out of her father's arms and rockets across the home like a bullet for her mother. She hit's Alvawynn with a hug, generating enough force to make her step back.

For the mother's part, she mouths the words "Thank you." while holding Rei's head against her body, and drawing that snowflake symbol in the air with her free hand with bright tears burning tracks down her cheeks.

Mirae smiles, eying the two. "She's pretty solid for a ghost this side of Hades. I'd expected her to be... More transparent."

Annette speaks quietly. "It's only temporary" and approaches the father with the doll. "Give this to her when she sleeps, as it is her anchor, and she will always come back for the winter holiday."

He nods. "I don't know how to thank you."

Annette shakes her head. "You don't have to. Just... be aware this year is special. She is solid. In

years to come, she will always come home, but begin as a specter. Perhaps you'll see her in a mirror, or in the reflection of one of your baubles. As Winterfest progresses she'll become more solid as she's strengthened by your holiday cheer, and her age will change reflect how she sees herself. It's only on the last day of the holiday that she'll be as she is today, solid and able to partake of your food. You must always remember to let her sleep with her dolly. It's her anchor, do not forget it."

Quest Complete: Winter Dungeonland - Part 2a**Difficulty: Hard**

Meet Winter and Tiasol at the lake, and take a moonwalk to find the Ke'bla elves.

You have gained +1000 reputation with the San'ta Elves

You have gained +5,000 personal reputation with Alvawynn.

You have gained +6,000 personal reputation with Perolon.



Chapter 14 - Made in Taiwan

We return to the site where we built our camp fire used in our barbaric adventurer cooking. I ate a little of Alvawynn's feast so as not to be rude, but she must think we adventurers have small stomachs. If I'm being honest with myself, I doubt she cared in the wake of seeing and touching her daughter again.

This time we don't have to summon Winter, because she's already waiting beside Tiasol who seems to be asleep and encased in a magic floating bubble. Beside her is a canvas wrapped in thick fabric.

"Is she going to be okay?"

"Take this. " Winter notes the object beside Tiasol. *Ah, right. The portrait.* "The magic I used to find her kin was draining. They are well protected, I

wasn't able to pinpoint their exact location. Even so, she will be fine and I will deliver you as close as I can."

"So where are we going?"

Winter makes a sweeping gesture with her arm. "Along the moonwalk. Are you ready?"

I glance to my party mates who all seem ready to go. "We're ready. Oh, wait." It seems like I haven't ridden my elechopper in forever with all the minibarges and portals. I wave my middle finger in the air and shout, "INFERNO!!!!" My fire elemental powered motorcycle roars into existence with a pop of red color. I then pump my fist in the air and call "Let's ride." Which summons the other four bikes in bursts of yellow, blue, green, and grey corresponding with their elements. "Mount up everyone." Without needing direction, Annette takes a seat behind Mirae. "Now we're ready."

It's already night this time, so the dimming of ambient light is less noticeable than when we traveled by moonwalk from Dragonswood Forest, but the Winterland city lights grow dim. A path, which looks like a bridge of glacial blue ice though it is not slick, leads over the water and beyond. The horizon grows indistinct from our starting position. As soon as our wheels touch the walk, our surroundings shift and warp

much as they did when we traveled to Arctica, though with less scenery outside of San'ta Vale, it's not as disorienting. We mostly see snow drifts, then a chasm, then a few feet farther a differently shaped snow drift.

This time we travel over a great deal of water, which is uniform in its appearance. The thing that catches me off guard is not any change to the water or land surroundings but the reddening of the sky over the horizon.

We're either traveling through time or all the way around the world. Where are these Ke'bla hiding?"

In time water fades to land, and shadows of trees begin to emerge in what I'm certain is broad daylight. It just doesn't seem like it because the world is darker along the moon path. I catch glimpses of tall pagodas that remind me of the far east, and temples with a whole lot of incense. Color seeps back into our surroundings as the sky grows brighter. The pillar of moonlight marking the end of the path looms ahead.

"We're almost there."

"Farewell, Child of Rat."

I'm not sure what to make of our surroundings. We dismount. It's not cold, but there's snow

everywhere. Stranger still, we're standing in the middle of a bamboo forest.

Annette lowers her hood. "I'm sweating." She removes her glove and reaches down to grab a hand full of snow. "It's like seventy degrees out here, and the snow isn't cold."

Mirae bends down to examine the 'snow' too. "What is it?"

Annette shakes her head. "Hell if I know."

Lilly looks up at the sky, as if it could answer all her questions. "Where are we?"

I check the minimap on my VT, zoom out, and do a double take. "Can't say I've ever been here before." Lilly looks expectant. "We're in Taiwan, or... whatever the Haven equivalent is. If we run into players it's a trippy experience, their lips move, but the sound comes out like a dubbed movie because they speak a different real world native language and the system translates to common."

I scratch the back of my head, and squint against the sun. "Doesn't look like we're close to any cities though. I don't even see a road."

Mirae asks, "You think Winter made a mistake?"

I shake my head no. "Spirits don't make mistakes unless something intentionally misleads them."

Which..." I ponder. "May be why we're not standing in front of a bunch of elves. Winter said she couldn't get an exact location."

Lilly claps her hands, "It ain't all bad."

Tako seems less pleased to be in an empty forest, "Why?"

The goblin rubs her palms together. "Taiwanese monsters."

Frodo asks, "Does anyone even know what the name of the kingdom is here? I'm pretty sure Haven is just North America."

I rub my temples trying to think. "There are a few of them, but I can't remember Taiwan specifically. I know Korea is Seong Yeok, which basically translates to 'Sanctuary' or 'Haven' in English so they might just name each Haven Online country after the word for Haven in language of that market."

Lilly trails, "So Taiwan would be..."

"Mandarin."

The goblin looks impressed. "How do you know about so many Asian languages?"

"Lived in Korea for three years, studied Mandarin in high school and college, as well as two years of Japanese, and a year of French. Oh, and I learned a bit of Indonesian from friends, and Thai..."

and Greek... Really anything people wanted to teach me."

Now Frobod's staring at me uncomprehendingly. "I thought you were a game designer... Why?"

"It's interesting. I like talking to people from different places."

"You're a strange lady. If I had those skills I'd be putting them to work."

"Game design is more fun than translating legal documents."

Lilly nods, "She's got a point. Anyway, miss smarty pants. Based on your extensive study of Chinese, what's the name of the Taiwanese kingdom?"

I shrug, "Same as China I guess, so... Ying Can Chu? Bi Nan Suo, maybe? Doesn't really matter unless we go to a city."

Annette ties her coat around her waist, revealing a short sleeve, linen top. "I'm still trying to figure out what this white stuff is." She toys with a bit of the not-snow, and sniffs it in her hand. "Doesn't smell like anything."

"Just try not to... I don't know, snort it."

I type a quick message to guild chat, in case any other groups are still hunting.

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Melpomine: Ke'bla Elves are somewhere in Taiwan.
Still haven't found them, but we're close

Laurelade: We're still in Arctica.

Sajina: We just found Winterland. No one's
mentioned the Ke'bla elves.

Laurelade: They bake cookies in trees, it's in the lore.

I eye the bamboo.

Melpomine: Thanks for the tip. We'll look for a tree
big enough to house a bakery.

Melpomine: Right now we're standing in a bamboo
forest.

Laurelade: How did you get to Asia?

Melpomine: Winter gave us a moonwalk.

Laurelade: Who gave a what?

Melpomine: I take it you don't have one of the rage babies in your group.

Laurelade: We didn't bother.

Melpomine: If you have a Freeworld were with you, it unlocks a side quest with a seasonal spirit who offers to help in exchange for bringing the ghost girl back to her family.

Sajina: Really? Leroy has the toymakers building us a boat and trying to piece together some kind of map.
Melpomine: Our quest line is totally different. Good luck. If they send you after the Ke'bla, you'll probably end up in Taiwan. I'll let you know if we find them.

Sajina: Okay, but we might be going after Kel'rog elves.

Melpomine: What are they?

Sajina: Long lost orphans, with a talent for making delightful breakfasts.

"Huh..." I look to the party. "Sounds like anyone who could cook disappeared when the Ke'bla fled. In any case, Laurelade says they bake cookies in trees, so maybe look for a big one, or some really small people."

Tako shakes a bamboo stalk dubiously. "No tiny elves."

"Is anyone else getting tired?" A few nods, it's morning here but our body clocks still think it's nearing bedtime. "Let's walk around and see if we can find anything. Keep an eye out for a good place to set up camp. I don't see any mobs, but be ready."

I equip Bite, and buff up just in case we run into something dangerous. Whistling wind and the heartbeat thump-bump thump-bump of the enhanced dexterity and vitality buffs sound in my ears. Mirae and Annette string their bows, Frobod hefts his sword, and Tako and Lilly ready their daggers.

Enhanced Dexterity.**Dexterity increased by 10%.****Duration: 60 minutes remaining.****Enhanced Vitality.****Regeneration Increased by 10%.****Duration: 60 minutes remaining.**

The not-snow crunches underfoot as we pass between tall stalks of green bamboo. The fake snow seems to collect along their lengths like inch marks on a ruler.

Lilly says, "I hate being on a new map with no idea what to do."

"You and I both." For the time being my minds more on finding a place to make camp than finding the elves, since I've yet to see trees spaced far enough apart to pitch a tent. *We might end up sleeping beneath the sky.* "Well... It is pretty here, if nothing else."

Happy birdsong sweeps from the trees. Sometimes leaves and branches shake, which makes me feel good to know we're surrounded by non-plant life, even if it's not likely the sort to drop any loot. I'm feeling good, but I can tell that forty five minutes of

walking around and looking at trees is wearing thin on the male party members' nerves.

Tako kicks a mound of unsnow as he complains, "Everywhere we go looks the same. This is taking forever."

I can't argue. It's a nice hike, but not what we came here for.

"Alright. Let's make camp and hope we come up with a better idea when we wake up."

Frobod eyes our surroundings, "Where do we put the tent?" He's more reserved in his complaints, but I can tell he's burdened by our lack of progress due to the determination in his steps, and reserved posture when we stop. It's like he wants to keep going, but doesn't have any idea of where so taking a moment to look around may be just as good an idea as any.

"We'll just have to sleep under the canopy." I recheck the map and see we're still right in the middle of a forested area. There are no landmarks, because we haven't found any. it only auto-populates when someone marks your map, or you've seen it in person.

Mirae's already setting up her stuff. "You know, since this white stuff isn't cold, it can actually make a decent bed if you don't just want to sleep on the ground

with a bedroll." She licks some of the not-snow from her fingers. "Guys..."

Tako gives her a questioning look, "Yeah?"

She sucks another one of her fingers. "It tastes good. It's sugary."

I look from Mirae to Annette, back to Mirae and inspect her to see if she has any debuffs from eating the stuff. There are none to be found. Then back to Annette, "Why didn't you say something?"

"I didn't taste it. Didn't seem like a good idea to put something in my mouth that I just found on the ground."

"... good point." I look to Mirae, "Why did you taste it?"

Her face is filled with an expression of 'I don't know.' "I guess it seemed like a snow cone or something. If you've got to warn against eating the yellow snow, the white should be okay, right?"

"I'm just going to call this a happy accident, and be glad that it doesn't seem to be sticky like sugar."

Lilly marvels, as she chews a mouth full. "Rob would love this. It's harder than you think to replace sugar in Haven. Usually he's gotta sweeten with fruit n' berries, but they have their own flavors."

Tako says, "I thought you sold pies for Thanksgiving."

"We did, and they were good, but not quite like they were back home if you know what I mean. He had to jury-rig the shit out of that recipe with some kind of root that doesn't even exist in real life. Wait, I'm gonna tell him."

I laugh, "Use guild chat so we can see his response."

SalemLilly: Rob, we found sugar.

A minute passes.

SalemLilly: Rob, sugar. We found it. A whole fricking forest of it.

No answer.

SalemLilly: Rob!

Pohrum: He's sleeping.

SalemLilly: Wake his ass up. I got news over here.

Pohrum: Are you sure?

SalemLilly: I'll take the blame. He is not allowed to get mad at you over it, and we got guild chat as a record.

Another couple minutes pass, and Lilly implores. "Send out an announcement, and tell him to check his chat."

The rest of our group is thoroughly amused by the exchange. It's a sign of how mind numbing our empty search has been this past hour. I pull out my VT, go to the guild interface, and push out the alert.

ROB, CHECK GUILD CHAT.

BLAME YOUR WIFE FOR WAKING YOU UP.

Pehrom: Fuck. Dude. I was dreaming about a magic carpet, a pastrami sandwich, and these two chicks with the biggest knockers... Like fucking watermelons. No, county fair pumpkins, but all squishy and shit.

Mirae scrunches her nose. "Uhhh..."

I glance at Lilly with shifty eyes. "Awkward."

She laughs and shakes her head, "It ain't real. He's just bustin' my chops for wakin' him up. It's all good."

SalemLilly: Ha ha. Very funny. You're such a slut, but I guess I deserve that for waking ya..

Pehrom: Shoot. What do ya want, babe?

SalemLilly: We found sugar. There's a whole forest of it.

Pehrom: Like sugar sugar, or bullshit sugar?

SalemLilly: It ain't real, but it's tasty. I ain't tried to cook or nothing, but I think you can use it. It's like snow, only not frozen.

Pehrom: Does it melt?

Lilly grumbles, "That's actually a good question, but I ain't gonna tell him that. It did kinda go to water in my mouth."

SalemLilly: What do you think? It's snow.

Pehrom: You said it ain't cold. Where is it?

SalemLilly: Taiwan.

Pehrom: Made in Taiwan. Well I ain't there so bring me a bag of the shit. If it's as good as you say, make it a really big one. Better yet, make it two.

I try to be helpful. "It'll probably keep in inventory if we can come up with a container. "

SalemLilly: You're gonna love it.

Pehrom: Thanks for waking me.

SalemLilly: I love ya.

Pehrom: Love you too.

SalemLilly: Good night.

Lilly stretches. "I guess now we gotta get workin' on findin' a container."

"Got any lockboxes?"

Lilly pulls one out of her inventory, along with a set of lock picks she to open the lock. "It was big enough for a shield so..." She begins scooping the white substance off the ground and into the box like she's making snow bricks. "A few cubic feet of the stuff should be more than enough to get him started."

Mirae, Tako, Annette, and Frodo have already settled into their bedrolls. I settle on top of mine, looking up at the canopy. "Let's get some rest." The sun is bright, but there's enough green shade from the trees that it's not beating on my eyes.

You are in bed.

Would you like to sleep? Yes / No

I choose yes.



Chapter 15 - Goh Tchu

As an elf, Mirae's the first to rise, followed by me and Tako a few hours later. I stretch. It's still daylight, but the sun is closer to the opposite horizon from when we arrived. I stretch. The air is clean and crisp in my lungs. I'm surprised not to feel dirty, and it feels wonderful. I don't think I've ever slept in a forest without a tent, either in this world or the other.

"Glad we didn't get eaten."

Mirae nods, and looks thoughtful. "We didn't." There's a weight to her words beyond morning banter.

"I'm sensing there's a but..."

She nods. "A few of them. Do you want the quest version, or the not getting eaten part of it?"

"Let's start with the quest, since that's why we're here."

Tako yawns, "Good morning."

Mirae offers a quick smile to her boyfriend. "Check your inventory for the painting. We all got a copy of it when you picked it up in Winterland, but now my copy's gone."

I reach into my inventory and fish around with my hand, usually the item I'm thinking of just appears under my fingers and I'm able to pull it out, but nothing comes up. I then check my VT, to see the full list of items that should be in my virtual bags.

"It's not here." Heart pounding, I scroll through all my other unused gear, to make sure it hasn't been deleted. I don't know what I'll do if Jordan's gear is missing.

Mirae's more calm. "I already checked my stuff, it's all there except the painting. I'll bet yours is too."

Tako's also frantically scrolling through his items, though the urgency of his swipes and taps seems to fade as he spends more time looking. "I don't see anything missing, but I didn't even notice that I had a copy of the painting in the first place. I thought it was all Mel."

Mirae sounds hopeful, "Do you still have it?"

Tako shakes his head no. "I was just taking your word that I got it. No painting."

Mirae sighs. "This is a problem. If the quest is bugged, we might not be able to complete it since there's no tech support."

Tako scratches his head. "Maybe there's a way around it?"

It's nice to see him optimistic, because I'm thinking, "Maybe that's why this place is so empty. Quest item, equals encounter trigger, equals monsters and NPCs that will advance our quest."

Mirae says, "Maybe? My guess is that we need the painting to gain the trust of the Ke'bla. "

Tako nods, "So it's a rep grind. Could take longer, but still doable."

I groan, "If we can even find them. They hid from Winter. She's a major spirit. How do you gain rep with a faction you can't even see?"

Mirae nods. "Yeah..."

"No painting means no encounter. No encounter means no trust. No trust means no cookies. And no cookies means no saving Christmas, and getting the quest reward." I look to Frobod whose still sound asleep. I'm suddenly glad that humans are

automatically out for eight hours unless otherwise woken. "Let's not panic the big guy."

Tako smirks. "Who's panicking? I'll only freak out when I can see that loot slipping through my hands." Mirae stares at him long and hard, and then hugs his arm. I feel like a whole conversation just happened that I wasn't a part of. Fortunately, Tako seems to feel the same way because he scratches the top of her head. "I like hugs as much as the next guy... Especially when they're coming from you, but what did I do?"

She beams. "You just talked about the loot slipping through your hands."

"Yeah.. So?"

Her smile falters. "I thought that meant you were planning to choose one of the evolving legendary items."

Ahhh... So that's it. Mirae thought he just announced that he'd planned to stay with her instead of going back to his family for the holidays. I try to lighten the mood. "Technically the items are just 'legendary potential,' they probably start as rares."

That doesn't seem to have helped, because Tako looks completely baffled. "Of course, I want an evolving item, but the logout's what everyone wants from this."

Mirae frowns. "What happened to just waiting for them to fix it?"

Tako shifts uncomfortably. "I'm still okay with that. I'm not chasing anything, but if it's there, why not?"

"Well, it is a chance to get a one of a kind item with legendary potential."

He looks back and forth between me and Mirae, torn and unsure of what to say. "I do like loot. I just thought you wanted me to talk to your family and stuff. If the quest is broken, I'm still cool to sit back, enjoy Freehaven, and wait for them to fix it, since we're not dying in Meatsville."

Mirae's face twists like she's taken a big bite out of a rotten apple.

I put a comforting hand on her arm. "Cheer up. You've got a guy willing to give up Legendary Potential gear for you."

Tako stares down at his VT, trying not to make eye contact as he types something in his interface. A private message arrives.

TakoStar: Thanks, dude. You're my wingman.

I roll my eyes. "This whole conversation has become way too serious. What's the other thing you were going to tell us?"

That snaps Mirae out of a daze, and she stands, motioning us to follow. "We weren't eaten but..." She leads us a few paces away from our bedrolls, and then points down and into the snow. "Look at this."

I follow the line from the tip of her finger to the earth, and my breath catches. "Wow..." Not just a footprint, but a tangled jumble of footprints with five clawed digits, not so surprising considering that we're in the forest, until I place my foot beside it and see that it's more than double its length.

"That's... big." Of course we've seen bigger monsters, we just fought one in flux realm, but I'm not sure how I feel about them wandering around so close to where we are sleeping. "What is it?"

Tako says, "Looks like a paw print."

I give him a flat look that says, 'Are you serious?' and flash him a mocking toothy smile.

Mirae squats beside it, and motions with her finger. "My tracking skill's not so good, but it could be a bear."

Tako says, "Dire bear is more like it."

She nods. "That's what I was thinking except for one thing." She motions from the jumbled tracks in front of us, to a long line of them reaching deeper into the forest. A few paces off. "What do you see?"

Tako smirks. "Footprints."

I give him another sarcastic smile, but Mirae touches my arm before I can respond. "He's right. Like I said, my tracking skill isn't so good, but it looks to me like it was walking on two legs."

"A were maybe?"

Tako shakes his head no. "If it was a were we'd either be dead, or something would have woken us up."

Mirae nods her agreement.

'... but the size is right. I've never seen a Haven were, but in the Freeworld they're typically a few feet taller than their human selves in war form, with correspondingly larger hand and foot sizes."

Tako, apparently feeling the need to be right, says, "Yeah... but that doesn't change the fact that Haven weres rip into anything that has a pulse."

I shrug, and look back to where the others are sleeping. "That's all I've got. Seems reasonable to assume that whatever it is might be intelligent since most upright walking creatures are."

Tako smirks, "Starving vampires. Once men."

"Ostriches?"

I sigh. "Whatever. I'll let you figure it out."
Quietly, my money's still on weres because it 's the
Winter quest, started by Annette, that brought us here.

"Let's go back and wait for everyone to get up."

* * * * *

"Good news and bad news."

Frobod's packing his bedroll up. "What is it?
Start with the bad."

"The bad news is we lost Tiasol's painting."

"What happened to it?"

"We woke up, and it disappeared from inventory,
but don't worry nothing else is gone."

"That's not good."

I nod. "I know."

"What's the good news?"

"We found tracks near our camp, and we can
follow them."

Frobod brightens. "Well that's good then. Maybe
whatever left the tracks stole the painting."

My own palm hits me in the forehead. "I'm an
idiot."

"What?"

"For the last two hours we've been going back
and fourth about footprints, and how we're going to

complete the quest, and you wake up and state the obvious that went right over all three of our heads."

Frobod looks more baffled than smug. "Glad I could help."

Tako says, "You didn't tell him that the prints have claws."

"Do they?" The death knight seems unbothered. "A lot of things have claws, and since the game hasn't left any other clues, that's probably it."

Lilly, sucks on a mouth full of sweet not-snow, when she talks. "Only one way to find out."

"We follow the trail then." I take a moment to survey the surrounding area, noting the densely packed bamboo shoots. "Hoofing it will be better than trying to ride through all the trees."

"No complaints from me."

"Let's go."

For ten minutes, I feel as if we aren't making progress. We're on the trail, but everything on this map looks so similar. Birds singing, 'snow' crunching under foot, it's also filled with the same forest sounds. Then a note of red catches my eye, something round and tasseled like a bearded bubble. *A bird feeder maybe?* It's some twelve feet off the ground, and twenty off the trail stuck on a tiny bamboo branch.

I stop and point. "You see that?"

Lilly squints. "What is it?"

Tako says, "I can probably shoot it down."

I nod for him to give it a try. THWAP! a fast arrow whizzes toward the object, and just as soon it falls to the earth. It's a slow fall, a bit like a plastic bag caught in the wind.

"Stay here. I'll go get it." I return holding the crimson item. "It's a paper lantern."

Lilly says, "Finally."

I nod. "Looks like we're not alone." I can't help but feel vindicated in saying that. "Keep on the trail."

The lantern is only the first sign of intelligent life. Before long, wind chimes jangle as nature decides to stir them, and a series of tall pilings carved and scorched with foreign pictographs appear several feet to either side of the clawed tracks. I linger at the first of the poles, examining and tracing the marks with my fingers. The characters aren't Chinese. It feels like if I had razor sharp and strong claws, I could make similar markings, with precise rakes of my hands. It's starting to feel more and more like a settlement as opposed to a lonely soul out in the woods somewhere.

This suspicion is all but confirmed when the mouth of a cave set in a sizeable rock formation looms

up ahead. Before it stands a sturdy wooden structure like an empty doorway. It's still a ways off, but from here I can see a convex bowing roof that could cradle the sun. A top beam is painted red, with bands of gold. I take these to be cultural symbols of good fortune.

"Please stop." It's a low rumbling voice that sounds like a mountain, but it's not unkind. It is however startling since it comes directly behind our party.

I turn, to see a bear... man... panda standing a good nine and a half feet tall, with a bladed spear on his shoulder. From the way he's standing it's hard to tell if he's wearing a long kilt, skirt, or extremely wide legged pleated pants in the kendo style with a rope belt. His top is a simple white linen tunic, with pink embroidery. I like the colors.

We all turn, having expected an attack if approached from behind, not a soft, furry, warrior.

"We've been watching."

"O...kay..." My eyes dart to the surrounding trees and sign posts looking for others, but so far as I can tell there's no other we in the vicinity.

Lilly says, "It talks..."

I cock my head toward Annette, "She talks."

"Yeah, but she's special."

The panda man asks, "Have you eaten?" I shake my head no. "Then lets sit and enjoy a meal together?"

"Alright..." I begin walking toward the gate.

I only make it a step before a furry hand catches my shoulder. "This way."

Tako says, "At least, I don't think he's going to eat us."

The panda laughs, a deep throaty sound that reminds me of how Santa's supposed to be. "Of course not. We don't eat people." He shakes his head and chuckles. "Goh Tchu eating a person. Just imagine."

I, notice that unlike us, he's not leaving footprints in the snow, and take a moment to inspect our host.

Lao Fan

Type:	NPC
Race:	Goh Tchu
Appearance:	4
Challenge:	????

He leads us to a round gazebo with a square upturned roof. At it's center is an eating table, with cushions for up to eight people to sit around the table.

Decorative scrolls painted in foreign calligraphy depict fierce panda warriors in fantastic poses in the heat of battle.

Lao Fan motions with his heavy paw. "Please sit, and be welcome."

He sits, and a hummingbird zips into the structure buzzing around the panda's face. He extends a finger which the little creature perches on. He says a quiet something in a language I don't understand. Certainly not Chinese. I'm also surprised to notice that Lao Fan has a thumb and five extra fingers. I guess I always associate weres in their anthropomorphic forms to be more or less human in body structure in spite of the fur.

"There." He says sitting cross legged, resting his spear behind him and putting his hands on his knees. "Food will arrive shortly. Will you do me the honor of showing your true selves for this meeting?" Though he speaks to all of us, his eyes are locked on Annette.

I'm pretty sure I know what he's getting at, but Lilly is slower on the uptake. "Whattaya mean? This is as true as I get." She pauses, and then looks to me, "Unless he somehow knows about our aliases? You think we have to switch to our mains?"

"I don't think so." I look to Annette, then back to Lao Fan whose eyes are set on her. "I think he just means shape changers."

Annette points at herself, "Me?"

I nod, and address Lao Fan. "She's still kind of new to this."

Lao Fan returns my nod. "Even so. Know that you are welcome."

Annette's hesitant at first, and then sheds her human skin. Bristles of fur spring up on her face like a beard, then cover her arms, and now her entire head. Her entire face stretches forward becoming more mousey with long whiskers. Seconds later, she sits a good head taller than she did.

"Child of Rat..." He says, "Or do you prefer Plaguebringer?" At first I think it sounds like an insult, but the tone of voice imposed upon the latter title makes me feel it's a tone of respect. "It's been some time since we've heard of your kind." He chuckles. "At least you're not a wolf."

"You can just call me Annette."

Frodo stirs in his clunky armor. "You don't like wolves?"

"We all serve the mother, but... Some breeds are prouder than others, and touchier to deal with."

Speaking to Lao Fan, "What exactly is this Plaguebringer business? I'm supposed to be teaching her but that one's new to me."

"You're teaching her? She has no Rat Mother?" Pandas don't exactly have eyebrows, but the skin above his eyes lifts a bit, as his face grows skeptical.

I give a tight smile. "It's a long story. How do you even know anything about what she is?"

"That's a long story too."

"I don't doubt it."

The panda's words are cut off by another panda entering the gazebo with a good eight stalks of bamboo over his shoulders, which he deposits behind Lao Fan. Behind him a panda woman scurries, as well as any seven foot tall woman can be said to scurry, in a red and black dress. It's interesting that she has a full mane of human black hair atop her hair pulled into a pony tail, unlike Lao Fan who just has fur. I wonder at the difference between sexes.

She places a tea set on the table, distributes small ceramic cups to each of us, and fills them from the steaming pot. Accompanying the tea is an assortment of cookies, sugar, coconut fudge striped, and chocolate discs that remind me of Girl Scout mint cookies.

"Help yourselves. "

"Thank you." I smile. More than anything else, this appetizer assures me that we're on the right path. "These cookies look delicious." I help myself to one of the mints, and take a disappointed bite to discover they taste like nothing. *This is tragic.* The more I look at them, the more convinced I am that a real chocolate mint cookie is exactly what I need to hit the spot.

I hadn't noticed her arrival, but another panda woman, this one in yellow and pink appears at my side with a glass and a pitcher full of sweating milk.

CRUNCH!

Lao Fan takes a shoot of bamboo in hand, and bites clean through it.

"This may be the only chance to ask this, so please don't be offended."

"Yes?"

"Why do pandas eat so much bamboo."

He snorts, smiles, and CRUNCH-CRACK, he takes another bite, chewing enthusiastically. "Isn't it obvious?"

Mirae shakes her head. "Not really. Aren't pandas built to be carnivores? I think I learned that as a kid, like their.. your... bodies are built to digest meat, but they... you eat bamboo anyway."

CHRUCH-CRACH... nom nom nom. "Are those sweet treats healthy?"

Tako takes a sugar cookie in hand, examines it, and pops it in his mouth. "I don't know. I can't read the label, but seeing a plate of them makes me feel festive."

"Yeah." Frobod, adds. "It may not be good for you, but they lift the spirit." He smiles sheepishly. "Mandy and I make Christmas tree cookies every year to take back to her mother. Sometimes I try to get her to try stars or snowmen, but she insists that trees are our thing."

KA-CRUNCH... smack smack smack. Gulp. Lao Fan smiles, "The same with bamboo."

Now everyone who's tried a cookie has a glass of milk, and Frobod sports the beginning of a one sided milk mustache. "It lifts the spirit?"

I look at him dabbing the corner of my upper lip, and he wipes it off.

"... and it tastes good." CRUNCH ...nom nom nom... He sets the shoot he'd been destroying aside, and sips from a cup of tea. The cup is miniscule compared to his wide bear face. "In the First Home, Plaguebringers were Rodekin who kept the population under control. If a species became too plentiful, populated, magically resistant to illness, or immortal,

they would come to restore the balance by spreading incurable pestilence."

I note use of the words Rodekin and species, "You're not from Haven." He also didn't have any reaction to Frobod's use of the word Christmas.

He inclines his head in a way that says, "What do you think? I'm not going to tell you."

I've never heard of a Freeworld were-panda though, there are were-bears, but so far as I know they only come in brown, black, polar, and grizzly. "You might say I have some experience with Rodekin magic." I think back on the story we told Zarentu about the origins of Adventurers, and decide to spin it to Lao Fan. "I'm an adventurer. We all are, save for Annette. I've been a Rodekin before."

I expect this statement to be met with incomprehension, but he nods in acceptance. Your ancestors are strong, if you bear their memories. I shake my head no. "It's not exactly like that. We're, like disembodied spirits ..." I think again, realizing this could get us side tracked. "Forget I said that. You are correct to say that I have memories from another life. It just doesn't work quite the way you imagine."

He nods, serenely and takes another sip.

"I have to say, you're remarkably calm."

"We Goh Tchu are the most level headed of the mother's children, except perhaps the spiderfolk."

He reaches for the rest of his bamboo stalk and takes a crunchy bite, as the panda woman in red and black enters with a tray filled with many plates of dumplings. I inwardly wince, finding this part of the game way too cruel. Everything I see, I want to eat with flavor.

Behind her, another male enters, in a similar tunic and baggy pants, holding the covered canvas.

"Ah, the main course."

The panda in red and black distributes bamboo chopsticks to each of us. My eyes follow the canvas. "You took our painting."

"Yes." Lao Fan, puts a dumpling in his mouth. "...and you are trespassing. You don't seem hostile." He indicates us with a wave of his big hand, "...and we prefer not to kill if we don't have to. Unnecessary violence is bad for the spirit, and we don't care for enemies."

Mirae asks, "You're pacifists?"

"We'd be having a very different conversation if you showed up with an army."

Frobod says, "Glad to hear that. So what do you plan to do with us?"

"Under normal circumstances, we'd put you to sleep, cloud your mind, and put you on a boat bound for the mainland. No harm done, and you'd forget all about it."

I have a feeling we'd all be wondering why we were in China.

Frobod puts a dumpling in his mouth and swallows. "But these aren't normal circumstances."

Lao Fan motions to the painting with an extended claw and makes a twirling motion. The Goh Tchu man removes the covering revealing an image that none of us had seen yet. Tiasol, a smiling San'ta man and a lovely blonde haired little boy with long pointed ears, and freckles on his cheeks. The portrait resonates with holiday cheer.

"What can you tell me about this?"

Tako leans back a bit. "It's a portrait."

I sigh. "The woman in this picture is named Tiasol, and she asked us to bring this to her parents so they can see her family. The father's name is Rurodin, and his wife is Helsidol. She also asked that we bring any correspondence from then with us when we return to Arctica."

"I see." Lao Fan crosses his big arms over his chest, and stares intently at all of us. The seconds of

silence feel like they're dragging on for hours. I can almost see the wheels turning in his head, trying to decide our fate.

Frobod breaks the silence. "So... Can you help us?"

Lao Fan looks to Frobod, "What makes you think I can help?"

The death knight indicates the picture. "We wouldn't be here talking if you didn't find the portrait so, the tells me you know something about it."

The panda shakes his head. "Even without the painting, we'd be talking. A child of Rat in this world is remarkable, and we will always greet our cousins."

"What do you mean 'this world?' Where do you come from?"

Lao Fan shakes his head again. "No. Even I don't have the authority to speak of this. At least, not without council."

Frobod interjects, "So what about the elves then?"

"For this, I must also call council. Please wait while I do so, and be welcomed as our honored guests."

Lilly sighs, "Sounds like it's gonna take a while."

Mirae nods, "More waiting."

"Hey, before ya go. Can ya at least tell us where ta find some monsters? We walked forever through the forest and didn't see a thing."

"You... want to find monsters?" He sounds surprised. "You like danger."

Lilly shrugs, "Little tamin', little huntin'. Ya know how it goes, it passes the time."

I hold my breath hoping the proposed activities don't offend Lao Fan's pacifistic sensibilities. but he nods. "This part of the forest is well protected. You won't find any here, but if you'd like to help protect the wild borders while you wait," He whistles a pair of notes which calls a hummingbird to him, he addresses it in the same rumbling language he used before, and it flies off. "I'll send, Xiao Guo to help and show the way."

Lilly claps her hands and rubs them together. "Finally, some good news."

"When you return we'll have made our decisions."



Chapter 16 - Taming

Xiao Guo is a youthful Goh Tchu, dressed in the same flowing pants as the other males we've encountered, black instead of white, with a blood red linen Tunic. I find his name funny, Xiao meaning small in Chinese, considering his towering, strong armed, pot bellied size. His enthusiasm, which is great, unfortunately isn't quite matched by his intelligence as for the third time since leaving the pagoda, he stops, scratches his head, looks up to the sky, and through the trees to the distance.

Lilly asks, "You know where we're goin' right?"

He taps the flat of his spear against the side of his head, as if somehow it would make the way clearer.

"Oh yeah. I've been lots of times. It's just uhmmm." He looks into the distance with a slack jawed

expression that makes me think he's got a hamster running on a wheel somewhere to keep his brain going. "Right over there, I promise. "He pulls on a stalk of Bamboo, breaks it, tosses one end over his shoulder, and puts the other in his mouth. "It sure is great to have visitors. I've never seen people that look like you." He gives Mirae a look. "I guess I've seen some look kinda like her but their hair's all different."

"You've met other elves?"

"Oh yeah." Xiao Guo munches on his stalk. "They make great snacks in their tree."

Frobod says, "You've seen the Ke'bla."

Xiao Guo looks startled. "Uhhmm.. I don't know."

Lilly piles on, "Do ya know where to find em'?"

The panda looks at his feet and shuffles uneasily. "Uhm. I can't remember." *This guy's a bad liar.* I almost pity him. "But yeah, I've never seen a child of Rat before, so that's awesome. You guys living in Haven now? Where'd you come down?"

Annette's slow to answer, "Come down?"

"Yeah, like.. Your ship. Where've you been living."

"I live in Dragonswood." It's a statement but it sounds like she's asking a question.

"Oh wow, I've never heard of that. It must be nice. How many are you? I guess you got dragons too."

Annette nods, "Lots of dragons, but only three of us."

"Wow. That's awesome. I mean the dragons, not that there's just three of you. That's pretty sad cause you know. Rats. There were so many. That's what the elders say, anyway."

Annette looks to me, and then to the panda like she's wondering if they're having the same conversation.

There's a red flash up ahead, followed by a screech, and a flash of blue.

"What's that?" Frobod asks.

Xiao Guo hefts his spear unperturbed. "Just a bunch of rats." He looks to Annette, "No offense. You're good, but those are the bad kind. C'mon you'll see. They're always trying to steal the elves and their food."

I nearly facepalm on his behalf. Even I can tell that the Ke'bla are supposed to be a secret, but this guy...

We come to the top of a steep incline, at the bottom of which are two rat like creatures, not unlike the Kryobeavers. They're about four feet tall and seem comfortable running on either two or four legs. While

their tails are similar to Annette's, goat like horns protrude from their greasy heads, and a fan of violent spines stick out of their backs. Also like the kryobeavers, they've got a single Nosferatu fang in place of what should be a pair of flat rodent incisors.

"Rat fiends. Each is bound to a corrupted spirit that serves the devourer. We get all kinds." He points with the end of his spear. "That one's frozen, and that one's burning. They're the most common, but sometimes you'll see rotting and void fiends too."

"Do they often sneak into your ahh... territory?"

Xiao Guo shakes his head, "Not usually. The warders and Father Owl do a good job of keeping them out, but we still patrol out here a bit for practice beating on live targets and to keep their numbers down."

"So this is an Owl Tribe?"

Xiao Guo blinks, "I don't know what you mean by tribe, but we remember lots of spirits."

"A tribe... you know... Your group, what do you call your community?"

"Oh, we're a clan."

"Right..." I nod.

It's always hard to tell when you're dealing with weres that are solitary animals. Wolves have packs, Crows have murders, Spiders have nests, and Lions

have prides... but Pandas? I guess these are a clan.

Tribe is the term commonly used in the Freeworld used to describe a group or community of more than one kind of shifters.

Xiao Guo stands in plain sight of our would be foes. "So yeah, about fighting. One day we'll get serious and wipe them all off the island, but for now we just keep em' out of our area."

"Alright!" Lilly rubs her hands together before withdrawing her daggers and waving them to cast a spell. I can't see what it is, but the blades glow red. I'm guessing that means fire since they remind me of branding irons. "This time I'm gonna catch one."

"Buff up." I wipe my hands together. Wooosh. Thump-Bump Thump-Bump. Two buffs appear in the top right hand corner of my vision before I push myself through the motions for casting Flow Like Water.

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Enhanced Dexterity.

Dexterity increased by 10%.

Duration: 60 minutes remaining.

Enhanced Vitality.

Regeneration Increased by 10%.

Duration: 60 minutes remaining.

Given that Xiao Guo indicated Frozen and Fire varieties of our enemies I also focus and activate Shield of Harmony, Aura of Emptiness in case of elemental attacks. "You might want to hold off on the fire Elemental Weapon since one of the types are fire monsters. They might be immune to it."

Another buff appears.

Shield of Harmony

7% chance to negate elemental damage.

Duration: 60 minutes remaining.

"Everyone ready?"

Lilly holds up her hand. "Wait."

She waves her knives in an intricate pattern that reminds me of wand casting. It ends in a long vertical strike that cuts a hole in the universe, forming a long dark rip that hangs in the air like a closed tent flap. A furry pink clawed hand pushes through the opening and widens the gap, followed by another holding a large carrot. Then a twitching bunny nose, and buck toothed bunny teeth.

Lilly gapes as fluff ball rabbit ears emerge, and then giant, furry, hind legs in a shade of bubblegum pink.

"You've gotta be kidding me."

The rabbit, twitches it's nose, and takes a big bite out of the carrot. With its free hand, it reaches down, disturbs the earth, and comes up with a big sharp stone, "I've got a rock."

I can't help but laugh as I inspect the summon.

(Fluxed) Stone Throwing Bunny

Type:	NPC (Summoned)
Race:	Devil, Beast
Appearance:	3
Challenge:	Difficult

"We were warned, before we entered."

Lilly protests, "No way! My other spells went back to normal."

The rabbit takes another bite of carrot and juggles the jagged stone in one hand. "I've got a rock."

The goblin moves her mouth to say something but then closes it. "I don't know whether to be horrified or thrilled. He doesn't look too intimidating, but who else has got a Stone Throwing Bunny?"

Frodo eyes our opponents down the hill, and speaks in a distracted voice. "Not me. I'm ready to go."

Tako makes a show of checking his VT, then snaps. "I left mine at home."

Mirae reaches her hand out to touch the creature. It nuzzles into her palm. "He's adorable."

"I've got a rock."

Tako says, "You should ride it around through town like a mount... I would."

Lilly's voice is caught between agitation and wonder as she directs her summon. "Bunny. Attack whatever she's hitting." and motions to me. "I'm ready."

"I've got a rock."

I use Bite to point at the rat fiends. "Let's go."

We charge down the hill with weapons in hand, picking up speed like a formation of cavalry. Tako

vanishes from my side and reappears behind the snarling mob with reddish fur. I follow his example. Stepping into Xiao Guo's shadow, and out of the red monster's beside Tako. I waste no time. Bite slams into the back of the rat fiend's leg causing its knee to buckle. Tako pierces it with his dagger.

The combination of our two strikes drops it's health by 30%.

It screeches in rage, and whirls to face us. It's just in time for a flash of green light from one of Mirae's magic arrows to hit its back, and Lilly to step out of its shadow. Lilly connects with a burning FWOOF and dull POOM that marks a direct hit with the Cinderburst stored in her dagger.

Tank plus double DPS shadow step. OP. I file that away as a viable PvP tactic in case we're ever in a mass battle.

SalemLilly has Killed Burning Rat Fiend.

Lilly howls. "Noooooooo!!!" As the rat fiend drops to the ground; fur crackling on fire. *Zero health.* "I crit! I can't fuckin'... Oh my God! UGGGHHH!"

So much for taming.

"I guess now we know they're not resistant to fire."

"Oh it was. but I also landed 14 fricking, physical damage on top of whatever you put out. FML."

To add insult to injury, the Easter Bunny smashes the rat corpse's head with a heavy rock before it has a chance to despawn. Nose twitch. Nose twitch. "I've got a rock."

"It's alright. You'll get the next one."

Lilly nods with a look of grim determination settling onto her face.

Xiao Guo smashes into the blueish white frozen rat fiend's flank with his powerful spear. The weapon crashes into the mob with an efficient three hit combo.

The creature stumbles back, and I hit it with my Darksteel Chakram a second after Mirae sticks it with another one of her green comet arrows. Annette looses a mundane shot which hits the mark, but the corrupted beast doesn't seem to notice. It just hisses and claws at Xiao Guo with icy drool, and frozen breath puffing out of it's mouth in spite of the temperate climate.

Frozen Rat Fiend health: 80%.

As the only other close ranged combatant without a teleportation ability, Frobod's finally showing up to the battle. Swinging his greatsword down across

the monster's chest, then across into it's side, ugly red gashes appear in the wake of the impact. It makes a snarling screech that grates on the ears that's caught somewhere caught between wolf and raptor.

The fiend's claws are enshrouded in icy mist, a localized fog. It swipes across Frobod's chest plate, and the squeal of nails ripping into metal peals from his armor.

Frozen Rat Fiend Health: 50%

Frobod: 90%

"Hey!" I whistle loud to get the monster's attention.

Taunt. Successful.

Frozen Rat Fiend attacks.

It bolts at me, the first few paces a lope on all fours, that bleed into a two legged sprint with a vile hand in the air ready to come down on me when it closes the distance.

"Don't do anything too deadly! I want to give Lilly a chance."

"Thanks boss."

I tuck out of the way of the wicked frost claws, and counterattack with Bite, aiming to knock the

creature off balance rather than do significant damage. It works, because the fiend stumbles past me with its hairless tail dragging in the dirt.

Annette hits Frobod with a mundane arrow, and his health hops from 90 to 100%. I'm glad to see she's practicing, and sees the wisdom of not being in the middle of the fight when you have literal rage issues. I imagine doing this quest with someone like Jason would be a lot more difficult. In fact, I'm certain we'd have lost at least a few party members to red fury friendly fire by now.

I eye Xiao Guo wondering, if rage might become an issue for him as well, but he seems happy and in control, coming down with a two handed strike with the business end of his weapon, which creates another red gash in the Rat Fiend's flesh. It whines in pain and rage, as it spins to face us.

Frozen Rat Fiend health: 40%.

I spare a glance for Lilly. "You need 20% right?"

"Yeah, before that there's no use tryin'. They're too willful and attack immediately."

I nod. "Gentle stabbing! No special abilities unless they reduce your damage!"

A big, course stone the size smashes into the rat's shoulder, dropping it's health by another 20% at

the same time as Frobod knocks it with a squiggly black necrobolt, reducing it by another ten.

Frozen Rat Fiend health: 10%.

A voice from up the hill calls. "I've got a rock."

Lilly shouts. "Bunny, no! Hold your fire!"

"I've got a rock."

The goblin reaches for her pouch of black dust that always seems to land in the pattern of a perfect circle surrounding a many pointed star when she tosses it in the air. It's quite pronounced on top of the unsnow. A streamer of magical energy connects the space between Lilly's eyes to the rat fiend.

"HA!" The Panda rejoices, as he thrusts his spear through the creature's chest. He jerks it out leaving a red streak along the length of his blade.

I shake my head. "Dude..."

Tako wipes his brow. "I'm starting to feel sorry for her."

Frobod stares at the corpse as Lilly's circle fades, and the body despawns. "That's not cool."

The goblin grows red in the face, an impressive feat, considering she's green. "I..! What...! YOU!" She points an accusing finger at Xiao Guo.

He laughs merrily. "A successful hunt! Worry not, we will all share in the glory. The spirits will hear of our deeds."

I groan. Everyone's silent, except for Lilly who's making a punished choking sound.

The Panda's flummoxed. "Did I do wrong?" I can hear the bewilderment in his voice.

Lilly howls, "DID YOU DO WRONG? Every... frickin'... time! ...and there's no more around here!"

Mirae sighs. "She was trying to catch it."

A look of incomprehension crosses Xiao Guo's face. "Catch it? For what?"

"To sell, to tame..."

"These creatures serve the devour, they won't be pets."

I sigh, "She can still use them."

"Sorry..." Xiao Guo frowns, having caused offense. "... but hey we'll find more. There are always more rat fiends!"

"Alright!" Her words bare the sharp edge of agitation. "Onward. Let's find some more rat fiends."

Tako bends down to gather the loot. "Rat fiend pelts, and an uncommon dagger."

Short Frostclaw**Type:**

Dagger

Quality:

Uncommon

Equipped Bonus:

Dexterity + 2

Special Properties:

Chance on hit: Freezes target for 1 second.

"We'll put it in the guild vault in case we recruit someone that doesn't know how to use daggers."

Tako shrugs, and stuffs it all in his inventory.

I'm starting to feel dubious of Xiao Guo's claims when we've been walking six minutes and haven't seen any new monsters. It's almost like the map's been picked clean by other adventurers, but we haven't seen any so it just must not be a very populated area. We come to a cliff of about fifteen feet and peer over. A trio of Frozen Rat Fiends, a Burning Rat Fiend, and a Void Rat Fiend mill about, and occasionally erupt into an explosion of snarls and clawed swipes aimed at their fellows if they draw too close to each other. The

Burning and Frozen rats seem particularly hostile to one another.

"See?" Xiao Guo points. "We found more."

Lilly casts a spell to hold in her daggers. "Let's go get em'."

"Wait. Something's moving. What is that?"

I thought it was a rock. A massive spiny green dome with moss growing all over it, only now it's shaking and wobbling in place. Slowly but surely a snapping turtle's head pops out of it, big enough to bite one of the fiends in half.

"Oh..." Xiao Guo considers. "That's old, Shan. We don't hurt him. He's good for the forest."

The huge aged turtle slowly opens it's mouth revealing a dry reptilian tongue.

A note of nervousness creeps into Lillys voice. "What's he doing?"

"I don't-"

A bright flash interrupts the panda's speech, as forks of yellow lightning leap out of the turtle's mouth, and into the quintet of rat fiends. They fall dead where they stand, smoking. Slowly, in the way of turtles, Old Shan extends his neck, bites, and crunches on a Frozen Rat Fiend's bones.

Lilly roars. "You've got to be kidding me!"

Old Shan tilts his lethargic head, so that his large black eyes peers up to our spot on the cliff. "I'm starting to get hungry for turtle soup!"

Old Shan blinks, slowly and carelessly.

A humming bird flits between the trees, and darts around Xiao Guo's head. He extends a big finger, and the little creature lands on it. "Oh. Okay." The little creature beats its wings and flies off. "Elder Fan says council's finished, and we should head back now."

It seems there will be no taming today.



Chapter 17 - Questions

Sajina: I don't know where you are, but Leroy says Taiwan doesn't exist. If you check your map it's not there. It's like the lost city of Atlantis, only an entire country.

Melpomine: Uhhh... I've checked my map. I've been looking at it a lot since we got here because this place is so hard to navigate. Taiwan exists.

Sajina: I don't see it on mine. Just China, and the rest of Asia.

Melpomine: I don't know what to say. Maybe it's only visible once you've been here.

The walk back is largely quiet, though every time I glance back at Tako he wears an amused smirk on his face. I feel a pinch of that amusement too, but still feel bad for Lilly. Remarkably, Xiao Guo only seems to get lost once on the way back.

Lao Fan and a blonde haired, blue eyed elf await us. They stand together and bow to greet us. "I trust you enjoyed your hunt?"

Lilly grumbles, "Frickin' wonderful."

"The council has made two important decisions." I incline my head in invitation for him to keep going. "The first is that you will be allowed to see and visit the Ke'bla. This man here is Iorian. He will lead you to the family of the woman in the portrait, and grant you immunity to the Ke'bla enchantment."

He gives us a pleasant smile that invites warmth and good will.

Frobod takes a small step forward in anticipation. "Wonderful. That's exactly what we wanted to hear."

"The other is that these two..." He indicates me and Annette, "Will have Goh Tchu enchantments lifted, to facilitate an exchange between our peoples. For centuries we have dwelt upon this world alone, and in

secret. It is with great anticipation that we receive a child of Rat. I will be the one to remove this enchantment."

"Lady Melpomine, Lady Annette, please come." He gestures us forward. We approach somewhat cautiously. I don't have any debuffs, so I'm not sure what he means by 'enchantment.' Lao Fan holds out his hands, palms up. "Please place your hands in my own."

I do so. They are soft, like a cat's paws, with just a hint of calluses. They are also warm like a persons. He places his thumbs over my fingers and closes his eyes. I feel warm, a silent anticipation stirs within me waiting for something to happen. His eyes fall open. He reaches for a little bell that had been sitting on the table.

DING!

With that sound I feel as if a weight has been lifted off my shoulders that I hadn't known was there. I look around, expecting something to be different, but it all seems the same. It's just this feeling of... release.

I step out of the way for Annette to go through the process.

DING!

"It is done. From now until you have acted with dishonor, you are welcome."

You have gained:

+1500 Reputation with Goh Tchu

You are now friendly with Goh Tchu.

"Should you encounter any of the Great Mother's other children in these lands, send them here with your seal, and they too will be welcome." Lao Fan steps back, and gestures to Iorian. "We will speak when you are able."

It's only now that I notice that the portrait of Tiasol and her family is still in the gazebo, re-wrapped in it's protective cover.

The elf drops to his hands and knees on the floor and begins sketching symbols onto the floorboards with Chalk. I can feel some of the characteristic jolliness I've come to associate with the San'ta in his voice. "If you'll all stand together in a bunch..." He's drawing a circle of magic glyphs around us.

Tako follows his progress with his eyes. "Should I be worried?"

Iorian jerks his head. His voice becomes sharp, impatient. "It's perfectly safe. It's easier, and less

power intensive to draw a circle around a group, than to lift the veil for each one of you individually."

Maybe he's just really serious about his magical work.

As soon as he makes the last mark, the entire circle of white chalk pulses with red and green light. Something fizzles like a sparkler, and motes of red gold and green twirl through the air like dust.

"There, you can come now, and see our home. As I said, it's perfectly safe."

It's not until we step outside the Gazebo that I realize how much the world has changed. We're still standing in a dense forest, but in the distance there's a tree that most certainly wasn't there before. No, to call this... this... wonder a tree is to lionize trees everywhere. It must be a quarter of a mile away, and as big around as a shopping center. To see it through dense bamboo is to mistake this magnificent plant for a mountain wall. To look up, and see thick branches beyond the bushy greens of bamboo tops, is to experience a supernatural wonder, a near religious experience. I suddenly think I know what Jack must have felt while gazing up the beanstalk.

"Wow..." There are no other words.

Tako looks up, "I guess we can fly, since we know where we're goin."

Iorian says. "You may. Meet me at the base of Elenandrial and I will escort you. Before you enter, you must understand our customs."

Frobod is also looking up, taking in the sheer size of the tree. "Elenandrial... I take it that's the tree?"

Iorian purses his lips, but I don't think Frobod notices. "Yes. We'll meet there, and discuss protocol." He puts the stick of chalk back in his pocket, which is replaced with a small pebble that looks a lot to me like a recall stone. Sure enough he disappears without a word.

Frobod looks to me with confusion in his face. "Did I say something to offend him?"

I give him my best "Hell if I know." look, when Lao Fan intervenes. "The Ke'bla are not like their cousins. They have evolved culturally speaking. You will learn when you arrive at the great tree."

Frobod takes it all in stride. "Let's go then. I can almost see the logout button reappearing."

I wave my middle finger in the air, shout "INFERNO!!" and pump my fist. "Let's ride."

* * * * *

It's not nearly as hard as I thought it would be to locate Iorian, because he's a bright green dot on the minimap. Without that, we'd have been circling the base of the great tree looking for anyone that seemed elflike.

Beside Iorian there's a thick red and white sign.

BE FREE WITHOUT QUESTION.

I cock a brow. "Is that because of the whole slavery thing?"

He bristles, and responds with a flat. "No." Iorian frowns, and grudgingly amends. "Not entirely." *What happened to the cheerful guy at Lao Fan's introduction?* "Take a moment to read the signs."

I look around. A few feet away there's another one on a post like a yard sign.

BE FREE AND ASK NO QUESTIONS.

"You mean we're not supposed to ask questions?" I slap myself in the forehead as soon as the words leave my mouth. "Sorry."

"It will be an adjustment, but this is our way. It's quite invasive to speak as you describe. It would be

good to know if you lack understanding, or require clarification."

Tako's wearing a WTF expression on his face. "You mean we can't even ask a question? Like any question, not just about the tree? What are we supposed to say then?"

He purses his lips. "We live a secretive life, and to speak as you do is an invasion of a person's privacy. Our speech patterns were at first an imperative to maintain our secrecy. A geas. So long as we did not speak as you do to others, our concealment magic would remain strong. It has evolved, over the last two hundred years, into proper manners. To even hear other people speak in this way, is horribly offensive, especially when directed at one of ours."

"So..." I catch myself before I ask a question, and think about how to phrase it. "I would like to be corrected if when I say that by not asking questions of others, the magic that hides your presence from Arctica remains strong, I am speaking false."

Now it's Iorian's turn to raise an eyebrow. "Your learning. In time you will become more concise."

Frobod nods, "I think I get it. No questions. If you have one, phrase it as a sentence. Righhh..." He trails, seeming to realize that he's about to ask a

question of confirmation. "..Right.... and wrong speech patterns are...important to distinguish."

Iorian's face softens. "I would agree with that statement."

Tako scoffs, "This is stupid."

I switch to party chat. "Then shut up! Don't endanger the quest!"

Mirae puts a comforting hand on his arm. "It's not too hard. Just copy what he does." She clears her throat. "It'd be good to know if we can see your great tree, and meet Tiasol's family."

Iorian, now breaks into a smile. "We can go now if you promise to be well behaved. I'd hate to eject you for lack of courtesy."

Mirae grins. "Easy peasey."

There's a ring of mushrooms just beyond the first sign, which Iorian gestures to. "Please step into the ring when you're ready."

"Here goes nothing." I step within the circle, and begin floating, rising upward as if on a hidden elevator. In just a few seconds I'm above the top of the bamboo and.... "Whaaaaaaat?"

I swear there was a large rock formation with a cave entrance, just beyond the red and gold gate. I know there was. I just saw it. Now I can see the gate

well enough if I look closely, but that is not a rock formation. For one thing, it's purple and another... I trace what appears to be a giant wing sticking up from the tops of the bamboo with my eyes. *It looks kinda like a space ship.* Not a flying saucer, more of an egg shape attached to a pair of wings at odd angles. My mouth drops as I see what appears to be signs of wreckage from a third. *An Egg at the center of... a tripod? Space pandas? In Haven? What is going on with this game?*

If that's true, where are all the laser guns, and ...
What the hell?

I feel like we've stumbled across some kind of game master island that was never meant to be experienced by players. "Were-Pandas from Outer Space." I shake my head, "That sounds like a worse movie than Starpuncher."

My ascent abruptly stops, and I'm floated horizontally over to a large branch where I can stand normally. It's more a platform than a branch since it measures at least twenty feet across. I'm surprised to note how flat it is. I wonder if the Ke'bla reshaped it with fancy nature magic.

Mirae shows up on the platform branch behind me, followed by Frobod and Annette.

"Did any of you see anything weird on the way up?"

Mirae smiles, "Gorgeous view."

I shake my head. "Not quite what I meant."

Frobod shakes his head. "I didn't see anything."

I lock eyes with Annette, and she nods her head in soundless communication. *Okay... First rule of Goh Tchu, we don't talk about Goh Tchu.*

Lilly's the next to appear on the platform followed by Tako and Iorian.

"Welcome to Elenandrial." Iorian smiles, showing pride in his home. "Please come." He leads us through a giant hollow in the side of the tree big enough to drive a couple of side by side cars through. *This can't be natural, or rather without magic.* It opens into a sprawling marketplace filled with holiday lights, though there's a distinct lack of other holiday imagery... Wreaths, Christmas trees, etc.

If the San'ta elves of Winterland could be described as enthusiastic and curious, the Ke'bla gape at us with expressions of utter shock. I'm coming to believe that they haven't seen outsiders before that weren't pandas. Of course, none ask questions. That'd be magically prohibitive and rude.

More distinctive is that everywhere I go smells of fresh baked cookies, though it's not consistent. Enter the main door and it's chocolate chip, swing around the corner and you've got cinnamon. I want to bottle the aroma and bring it back to Cupcake Keep.

Another interesting note is that aside from chairs, the Ke'bla don't seem to have furniture, or rather, they do, but it's fixed in place, grown directly from the floor, wall or ceiling. There're are no mundane lanterns here with oil and fire. All the illumination comes from frosted glass mage lights casting warm yellow brightness.

"This is really impressive."

Mirae says, "It's beautiful."

"Do-" I catch myself. "I'd like to know how this all came to be. I assume it's magic."

Iorian nods. "We have tree singers. They sing to Elenandrial to express our needs, and the great tree provides."

Mirae touches the wooden wall with her hand. "It's wonderful."

Iorian, in a voice laced with warmth and pride, says, "I'm glad you like it, cousin. This way."

He leads us to a stairwell that leads higher into the tree. In this place there's less hustle and bustle, a

calmer atmosphere. "This is the first residential chamber. Lord Rurodin and Lady Helsidol live at this level." I note the use of the word at rather than on. Suppose a tree doesn't exactly have floors, so the best way to measure location within Elenandrial may be height.

"Here we are." He knocks gently on a sturdy metal door, and I wonder if wood ones would be offensive to the tree.

It opens immediately, as if Tiasol's mother had been waiting right behind it. She smiles. "We've been waiting."

"News of our arrival precedes us."

A deeper voice from within the home behind the door says, "You're all anyone's talking about. We haven't had visitors aside from the Goh Tchu..." He considers. "Ever."

Well aren't we special?

"W-... It would be nice to know of your relationship with the Goh Tchu." I stumble.

Helsidol steps aside, "Please come in."

We enter. It's a small home, much like a large studio apartment with a port hole window. The furniture, as with the market seems to be grown directly from the surface of the ground. There's a

dining table, a sitting area with plush chairs, and a large bed covered in some kind of thick feathered mattress.

Rurodin says, "The Goh Tchu and Ke'bla are both outcasts, wanderers. Far away from home. We support each other out of mutual respect and the need for survival."

"Good to know." This answer supports my wacky spaceship idea. I pull Tiasol's portrait from my inventory and prop it against the wall of the sitting area. "A gift from your daughter."

"It'd do me well, to know that she is in good health."

"She is." I confirm, "... and quite the skater."

"Nuthin' compared to me..." Lilly grumbles.

I shush her.

Rurodin looks to his wife, examining the covered portrait. "I'd like to know if you're ready."

She drifts closer after closing the door. I can see a bit of Tiasol in her mother's face. It's odd, because by human standards they seem less than ten years apart. "I am. I would like to know if we have our guests' permission."

"It's your present, though I'm sure your daughter's kicking herself for having not had time to prepare more festive wrapping."

Helsidol sighs, longingly. "Winterland. I miss it so."

The father narrows his eyes a touch. "It'd be good to know why there was a hurry."

I shake my head. "For now enjoy this. We'll get to that in a moment."

Ionian clears his throat. "I wonder if I'm still needed here."

I can see Tako's about to wave him off, so I quickly interject. "Yes. After this, there are matters of great import."

Helsidol, smiles kindly. "Please sit." He does, atop a metal stool.

Frobod says, "You can unwrap it now. There's no need to wait on our behalf. We've already seen it."

Tiasol's father, slowly reveals the canvas. Her mother gasps, covering her mouth with her hand. *I wonder if that's a San'ta thing.* Even Rurodin is choked with emotion. He swallows hard. His voice is hoarse when he says. "I would be eternally grateful, if you could confirm what this appears to be."

"Well, the woman, that's Tiasol. I'm sure you recognize her."

Helsidol murmurs something that sounds like.
"My beautiful baby."

I continue, "The man is her husband."

Helsidol smiles faintly, though her husband goes ever slightly more rigid. I get the feeling, the skater's staying behind was more than a little contentious within the family. Even so, I can tell her father is holding on with every breath for my next words.

"And the boy is their son. She wanted me to give this to you."

His voice is weak. "I'm a grandfather."

"We're grandparents."

"Two thousand years and I never imagined. Who could have guessed. It would be good to know if I'm right in thinking the boy is twenty five or thirty."

"Errr... I don't know."

Rurodin laughs. "I don't need to find out from you. Just look at him! Thirty five tops! I'm a grandfather! I'm a grandfather!"

He rushes to his wife, embraces her, and twirls around the living room. "Our Tiasol's had a son!" He clears his throat, trying to temper some of those

emotions. "I guess that guy she ran off with wasn't all bad."

I would have guessed about ten. I hope that my ensuing smile doesn't show how far out of my depth I am. "I am curious to know, how common Ke'bla and San'ta children are."

He motions to Mirae. "You can learn from your friend. Most elves are the same if they don't love with humans."

Helsidol admonishes. "Oh stop. She's given us a great gift. I'd say between the San'ta and Ke'bla combined, we see one every..." she considers, "One or two years. Sometimes as long as five."

"Wow..." I'm hit in the chest with the sudden weight of Rei's tragedy, and I understand the reason for an entire community full of festive mourning. Every day, presents on the porch. Everyone doing their part to support a broken mother and father.

Rurodin says, "Come now, I didn't mean anything by it. I just meant to say we're not so different even if we live on an unplotable island, or in the North." He collapses on the couch. "We will feast a week in celebration, and you... short ears, Seakin, human and... Green woman.. will be guests of honor!"

"Yeah..." Frobod hedges. "Unfortunately we don't have that much time."

"You needn't leave so soon! We adopt you as our trusted friends and allies."

Mirae looks at her feet. "The thing is..."

I purse my lips, and then decide to just blurt it out, "Your grandson might be in danger!"

Half-Truths

Manipulation + Subterfuge. Success!

Caliber of Success: 8

"Just hear what I want you to."

The expression of joy drops off his face. "I must know the meaning of your expression."

Ionian inclines his head.

I take a deep breath. "I know why you left Arctica, it's happening again, and only you can save him."

A haunted expression creeps into Helsidol's face as she whispers, "Great Uncle Winter..."

"The monster."

"He's already killed a child. A little girl named Rei. A little younger than your grandson if I had to guess."

Heartstrings**Manipulation + Empathy. Success!****Caliber of Success: 4**

"Would you like to hear my little violin?"

"It would be good to know what you need."

I look to the door. "Cookies. Lots of them. The greatest cookies in all the land. It's the one thing that can save him and restore the balance."

Ionian frowns. "We've taken a vow of no contact. We can't risk it."

Rurodin says, "My grandson's involved! That makes him one of us."

Ionian shakes his head. "No. It's too dangerous. You heard what she said, he's already fallen to the dark. Going back is certain slavery." His frown deepens, and his voice goes quieter. "I am sorry."

"You don't need to make contact. If you bake them here, we bring them when we return to Winterland."

Ionian's voice is grave. "This is a matter for Ke'bla Council. It is not a decision I can make on my own. This involves all of Elenandrial."

I look to Tiasol's father. "We're going back regardless. I'll be happy to bring a letter to Tiasol and her family when we return."

Rurodin stands. "I'll do you one better. I'm going back with the cookies, to deliver them in person, and meet my grandson."

Helsidol says, "You can't!"

Ionian says, "That's yet to be determined. Cookies take resources, and bakers. It would seem you expect everyone in the kitchen to quit their jobs, and bake knowing that in so doing we'll all be exposed. Exposed. Returned, and caught under the monster's Thumb."

He shakes his head no, "It's not every day you get a chance to be a hero, but this is something I can do. I'll bring those cookies back to Winterland if I have to bake every last one of them myself."

Ionian stands to meet Tiasol's father. "This is a matter for Ke'bla Council."

"Then go, and call an emergency session."

Ionian seems at a loss for how to respond to that, his mouth moves without making a sound. There's a few false starts before finally, "I will." He moves to the door.

"Hurry!"

Ionian shuts the door behind him.

Rurodin grumbles, "Coward. He's too..."

Helsidol fills in the blanks. "There are some who are paranoid about our secrecy. They wouldn't let us leave the island if they had their way. Others are more tolerant. It's hard to say which way Ke'bla Council will go."

Frobod says, "I take it he's on the council."

Rurodin nods. "Chairman."

Helsidol stands, "Why don't you take a walk around Elenandrial while we await their decision."

I hope it doesn't take long.



Chapter 18 - Sugar

Tiasol's mum has decided to be our personal guide. I'm sure for NPCs, Ke'bla cookies are the best snacks ever, but for us... Let's just say they smell a lot better than they taste. We're now standing on a balcony overlooking the bamboo forest. We're so high I feel like I'm looking on a city of long grass and ants, whenever I catch a glimpse of a panda. A bit of unsnow falls on my hand, and I touch it too my tongue. *It is sweet.*

I'm about to say "Can I ask you a question?" but catch my tongue in the nick of time. Instead it comes out as "It'd be useful to know what this snow is."

Lilly perks up. "Oh yeah! With everything, the forest and their mother killin' my monsters, family deliveries, and trying to save Christmas..." she pauses

and looks to Helsidol, "That's Winterfest to you, I forgot to ask about this delicious weather phenomena."

Helsidol startles. "Don't say that word. People here will think you're a barbarian."

"Sorry, Winterfest. For me and my people it's always been Christmas, so it's hard to adapt."

"Not that." Helsidol sounds scandalized, and mouths the word 'ask.'

"Oh right. Sorry about that. Different strokes for different folks, I guess."

I try to redirect the topic. "It'd be good to know where it comes from. We've never see it."

At this Helsidol smiles. "I'll show you. It'd be good to know if you're all interested."

Mirae holds Tako's arm, "I think Tako and I are going to tour the market."

Frobod looks off in the distance. "I'm good to stay here for a bit. It's a nice view and I'm thinking."

Again, I have to catch my tongue to avoid a question. "You must be thinking about your family."

"Yeah, a lot of that. We'll probably go out for pizza when I get back. I'm also kind of wondering where I'll wake up, and if I've been evicted."

"Ouch." I pause. "I wonder if I've been evicted."

He holds his thumb and pointer finger together. "Were this close. I can practically taste it. Anyway, I'm staying here. You can go find out about the snow if you want."

Annette says, "I'll stay here too."

"It looks like it's just us then. Lilly and I would like to come."

Helsidol nods, and leads us off the balcony to yet a higher level of the tree and another after that, and then another.

Lilly takes a deep breath. "I'm starting to get why ya never see a fat elf."

Finally we come upon yet another balcony with a wizard in flowing brown and red robes, with a glowing staff that he waves in the wind. There's a lot of air stirring up here, compared to the lower levels.

"When we allied with the Goh Tchu we had to give up snow, because they don't like the high elevation, and prefer to stay near their home, which can't be relocated. We live together, supporting each other."

I nod. "Understood."

"It was hard for a lot of us to live year after year without snow. You've seen our homeland."

"It's a bit different." Lilly confirms.

"This is our compromise. Once a year throughout the month of Winterfest we create our own snow, but not so cold as to offend our friends."

"You're tellin' me this wonderful stuff is a spell."

"It is."

"Teach me!"

I give Lilly a flat look.

"Please, teach me... My husband would love this. In fact, I think me comin' home with the know how of how to work this magic, would give him the happiest Winterfest eva."

Helsidol smiles serenely. "It's been a long time since I've had a direct hand in spreading holiday cheer to anyone but my own family, and our closest friends. I think I might like that, and after the joy you all have brought to our family... Let's head to Magisters' Hall, and see what we can do."

Magisters' Hall is, of course, several levels down which reaffirms Lilly's association with long stairs and fit elven bodies. They don't bother me because I've got about a million stamina, but Lilly having gone up and down so many flights is looking a bit flush.

It's a big tree... cavern... for lack of a better word. What do you call a hollow the size of a department store? It's packed from floor to high ceiling with all

kinds of old books, that no doubt keep all the Ke'bla's secret spells and baking recipes.

A stuffy pointy eared man in a red and brown robe says, "It's good to see you Lady Helsidol."

"We need to copy a spell."

"I assume you know which one."

"Yes, we need the sugar snow incantation."

He sits back in his seat. "I'm surprised to see you interested in working the weather. You never struck me as that kind of caster."

She smiles. "It's always good to broaden your horizons."

I'm not quite sure if the spell is forbidden to outsiders or not, so I keep my mouth shut.

"Yes... I can copy up to three circles. Anything beyond that will require authorization from Ke'bla Council."

"I'll take all three to save future trips."

"Yes, just a moment."

He eyes me, and then Lilly for long seconds. "It would be good to know why you've brought visitors."

"I'm giving a tour of Elenandrial until Ke'bla Council has finished."

"Yes." He says sparing us another look. "Please, a few moments."

The librarian stands and disappears into the stacks.

Helsidol smiles to both of us. "It won't be long, he's quite efficient."

I marvel at all the books on shelves that seem more like natural formations than carved walls. "I wonder if Elenandrial takes issue with you using trees to make paper."

"Elenandrial is protective of deciduous trees, and the folk that live in them. Dryads and the like. The old tomes however predate our arrival, and she has accepted them. Newer tomes are made of bamboo since we have so much of it."

"That must be why your door is made out of metal."

She nods. "Not all doors, but most residents prefer metal because it's heavier and makes us feel more private since it's thicker and harder to penetrate. Other doors, such as those in shops are made of bamboo, and others yet use simple curtains."

Lilly looks at her oddly. "You don't worry about theft."

To my ears, that statement seems to tread a thin line between question and statement, but Helsidol let's it slide. Perhaps their etiquette relies more on grammar

than tonality, or if they do consider tone, Tiasol's mom is making an allowance for new comers.

"No one amongst us steal. It's not in our nature."

"That's hard for me to wrap my mind around."

"The young sometimes borrow items without asking, but it's not done with malicious or greedy intent. Though Elenandrial is large, our population is small, and we are long of years. This encourages us to take care of one another as long lives make for long memories."

Lilly says, "I'm sure coming from the most festive place in the world doesn't hurt either."

Helsidol smiles, a bit sadly, longing. "It is our culture."

The librarian approaches with three sheets of parchment in hand. "Here you go. Sugar Snow first circle, second circle, and third circle."

He passes them to Helsidol, who examines the pages and passes them back. "Your calligraphy is lovely, and diagrams masterful."

The librarian beams under the praise. "I thank you. He retreats to the front desk where he first greeted us, where he rolls them each into separate tubes, and seals them with his mark.

Helsidol passes him a few coins, and takes the spells from him. "Have a wondrous day."

I feel like I should reimburse her.

As we depart, rounding a corner outside the library, Helsidol passes the scrolls to Lilly. This makes me think she wasn't necessarily supposed to share this secret. Then a bell tolls and reverberates through the tree. "Attention all visitors and their hosts, please assemble in the kitchens."

I was skeptical at the sound of the bell, but the words confirm that the announcement is some form of amplifying magic. I recall the spell used during Lord Zarentu's tourney, and trust that it's a variation of that.

I look to Helsidol, "It seems that's us. It'd be good to know the way to the kitchens."

She smiles, less sad than her previous ones, "I'll show you. I believe this is a good thing."

Back up the half dozen twisting staircases leading to Magisters' Hall, and another few above the open market.

Lilly pants. "You're killing me, but my athletics skill just got a boost."

Having been farther away than everyone else, we're the last to arrive. Tako, Mirae, Frobod, Annette, and Rurodin all wait patiently.

Ionian greets us in front of a set of heavy metal doors. His face is unsettled. "Ke'bla Council has decided to aid you." Tiasol's dad's face splits with a triumphant grin. "We voted, and the motion passed by only a small margin. Our chefs are aware of your plight, and will bake the cookies you require."

Rurodin beams. "That's good news."

Ionian continues, "Furthermore. Any Ke'bla who wish to return with you to Winterland will be allowed to do so. The centuries have not dimmed all of our memories, and for some nostalgia is unbearable. You may not, however, under any circumstances reveal our location, the presence of the Goh Tchu, or Elenandrial. I trust you will say something if you do not understand."

"Understood."

Ionian gives us a curt nod. "I will introduce you to our bakers."

As if on cue, wide, heavy doors swing open revealing countless baking stations and Ke'bla elves in toque blanches standing at attention. A commanding chef in a red coat rather than white paces before the assembled bakers, hands behind his back, barking militaristic shouts.

"It's been years. Centuries, but you are called back to duty to serve the North. We are not slaves, but saviors. The world needs us. Great Uncle Winter has gone evil, and he needs your baking. Sugar cookies, thin mints, fudge striped coconut, chocolate chip and peanut butter. We need them all. You will be tired. You will be frantic, and by frost you will bake the best cookies of your entire lives. Confirmation!"

Hundreds of bakers answer in unison. "Yes, chef!"

"I didn't hear you!"

I didn't think it was possible for so many voices to grow louder, and yet they do. "Yes chef!"

He gets in the face of a baker in the front line of stations, and shouts. "You ARE going to redeem Great Uncle Winter with your snicker doodles! Confirm!"

There's a chorus. "Yes, chef!"

He walks deeper into the room, and gets in to the face of a small rosy cheeked woman with longer than average ears and a cute nose. "You ARE going to kick evil's ass with your macaroons! Confirm!"

A chorus response. "Yes, chef!"

"You ARE going to save Winterfest with your gingerbread men! Confirm!"

"Yes, chef!"

He drifts back to the front and faces the assembled bakers. "Today, is a day for the histories. In five thousand years, your children will sing your names. It's time to put on your armor of powdered sugar, jelly, and cream cheese frosting and send your confections to war. The fate of Winterfest lies in these ovens and in your hands. Bake, chefs! Bake!"

He salutes the chefs, and the kitchen explodes into a whirlwind of culinary motion. Every where I look bakers blur about preparing dough, melted chocolate, and readying their ingredients. They moved like cogs in a perfectly efficient machine.

I'm about to ask about using fire to bake in a living tree, when a man rushes past with a wide push cart, and a red sleeping baby dragon curled up in what appears to be a dog bed. He wheels it to the ovens, opens a small metal door to the side and on the ground. He then pokes the creature's snout.

The dragonette opens it's orange eyes, and snorts a puff of smoke from it's nostrils. The Chef tosses it a large green cookie, which the youngling catches in its mouth. It lethargically climbs off the push cart, and sticks it's head in the oven.

FWOOOF! Yellow flame glares around the opening. Another baker opens the main door of the

oven, where they place the cookies, and gives an enthusiastic thumbs up. The chef with the push cart drags the soft bed to the floor, which the little creature curls up in and falls back to sleep.

Helsidol must see me watching the process, because she says, "There's no danger to Elenandrial. The ovens have magic to preserve and distribute the heat."

I nod, and hesitate, choosing my words to avoid a question. "It'd be good to know when they will be ready."

"You'll have a sizeable stash by the end of the night." I nod.

Rurodin claps me on the shoulder. "It's a Winterfest miracle. Look at them all go."

"I'm surprised you're not baking with them."

He shakes his head. "I've another kitchen to attend. Come. We'll prepare the Sea Sleigh."

"Huh..."I'd been prepared to just put a few boxes of cookies into my inventory and Thunder Bridge us back to Arctica, but looking at the sheer size of this operation I suspect the game has a different mode of transport in mind, even though our inventories are virtually endless. "To the Sea Sleigh then."

Iorian says, "Anyone who goes to Winterland
will be joining you shortly."



Chapter 18 - Sea Sleigh

Iorian and Rurodin lead me to a spell chamber high in the tree, where he sketches an elliptical diagram in chalk that fast becomes a portal. I can't see anything on the other side, but the surface shimmers with swirling red and green magic. For now, it's just Rurodin and our party, but the Chairman assures me that others will be soon to follow.

"D-" I stop myself. "It'd be good to know if this portal goes two ways."

He nods. "I'll take it down when you depart."

Tiasol's dad, looking excited, steps through. I shrug, look to the rest of my group and follow.

This would be the perfect opportunity to send us off to a dungeon without an exit.

I step through swirling colors into darkness, which Rurodin pierces with a light spell. It smells dusty, and floorboards creek underfoot. "I hope we didn't just get sent to the inside of a cell to starve to death."

Rurodin laughs, "Think no such thing! This is the right place. The Sea Sleigh is hidden, and needs to be moved out of dry dock."

Lilly, Frobod, Annette, Mirae and Tako file out of the portal.

Lilly waves a knife like a wand which casts another light spell.

Frobod squints at the magic, then looks out into the darkness. Each spell only has a radius of about twenty feet. "It's so dark."

"Dry dock." I try to sound like that makes perfect sense. I look to Rurodin, "I'd like to know if this thing will still be sea worthy after five hundred or... however many hundred years."

"Of course it is! We're Ke'bla! At the time we built it, we were San'ta, and It would be good to know who you think built Great Uncle Winter's Sleigh,"

"I'm going to go out on a limb and say Elves."

"Exactly. We just need to break the locking mechanism."

Frobod says, "I want to know where that is."

"This way." He motions and walks toward the front of the ship, or at least I assume it's the front because the floorboards underfoot lay the direction we are moving. He then drifts to the right where we come upon a golden banister with a rope ladder attached.

Tako eyes the ladder skeptically. "I always trust my safety to ladders that are older than Jesus."

The last time I did something like this, a pit of rotting undead awaited me at the bottom. I sigh, and look over the edge, knowing what's coming. "I'll go first. If I fall, I'm the most likely person to survive it."

Tako smiles. "You're a champ."

I hate the feeling of wobbling in high places. I like the feeling of wobbling in high places over darkness even less, but it seems Rurodin was right and the ladder is safe. Either it was brought here recently, it's magical, or this is one of those game inconsistencies that you just have to let slide. My foot comes down on solid ground. *That's a relief.* Better yet, so far, nothing's trying to murder me.

I cup my hands around my mouth like a megaphone. "It's good." The ladder shakes as Lilly, with one of light sources comes down. With her descent, I make out the boat's shiny red color. A few minutes later everyone's on the ground, and Rurodin leads us to

the front of the vehicle, where a strong metal loop in the floor prevents two steel chains as big around as my thigh from moving.

Rurodin touches the eye protruding from the stone floor. "We just have to break this part, and the container will open.

Where's Leroy's hammer when you need it?

"I've got a staff, those two use daggers, Annette's an archer and he uses a sword. It would be good to know how you expect us to do that."

"I almost forgot." He walks off leaving us in darkness, before returning with a monster sledgehammer. "Use this."

Mirae says, "I don't think I can even use that."

I glance between our party members. "Annette, your claws can rend metal, but it'll take a lot of scratching to break through this. It's not exactly like ripping into the side of a car."

Her voice is sharp when she says. "You don't need to explain that thin metal is harder to rip than thick metal to me."

Right... She's still Rodekin. Don't annoy her.
Then I laugh.

"What?" I can just imagine her rage meter rising.
Rurodin grimaces.

"Nothing, it's not you. I just had a funny thought. Frobod you've got the most strength, so give it a shot."

I pull out my VT.

Melpomine: I was just thinking it'd be hilarious if we wiped down here because I annoyed Annette. There's not even a boss.

CLANG! *That's an unpleasant sound.* CLANG!
CLANG!

A little yellow bar, like a health meter appears over the metal eye. Every time Frobod swings it, it drops a bit. CLANG! CLANG!

Lilly groans,. "This quest is gonna give me a migraine."

Just when I think I can't take it anymore. Clank. Clank. Clank. Clank. Clank. Clank. Chains running. Darkness is pierced by a red, orange and yellow sunset. CRASH. We're near a pristine yellow sand beach that greets us with the sound of gently lapping waves. Two halves of a wooden box fall to the Earth and despawn revealing a gigantic red sleigh the size of a cruise ship. The only difference is that the runners are only decorative, and the bottom would rest

flat on the earth if not supported by float magic. As it is, it hovers like a magnet pushing away from its polarity twin.

Rurodin smiles. "Ahh... That's a sight. Just needs a little cleaning. This was actually one of Great Uncle Winter's backup storage sleighs before we converted it to a ship."

Mirae says. "Santa.... Great Uncle Winter.. has storage sleighs."

He nods picking up on the question. "He couldn't possibly fit all the toys for the whole world in the one he rides in. Instead there are storage sleighs with invisibility charms, that allow him to reach into his sack, and fetch the necessary presents from inside. It's magically more efficient than trying to portal all these goods from the North Pole. We'd send these out with him, hooked on to the back of the one you're used to seeing like a train's caboose, only invisible."

"So you made a flying sleigh into a boat to escape. I'd like to know the logic behind that."

"Oh, we thought of flying. A lot of us wanted to snatch Great Uncle Winter's reindeer to make it happen, but in the end we decided against it. We didn't know if we could control them, or if they had a way of getting back to him and telling him where we settled."

"Reindeer are needed to make a sleigh fly."

He looks at me like I'd just made the most obvious statement on the planet. "Of course. I thought you'd know."

Sounds from up above tell me that other elves have arrived and are tidying up the ship.

"You mentioned another kitchen."

He motions to the ladder. "Let's go back up."

On top, three or four blonde haired Ke'bla busily swab the deck leaving shiny amber paths in the accumulated dust revealing the underlying floorboards. Another elf propels down the side like a mountain climber with a giant squeegee while a mage hammers the side of the sleigh with a magical jet of water.

"They're really serious about this."

"And efficient..." Mirae adds.

"The nostalgia for home is no small thing. For many it's been a source of long aching depression."

"I'm surprised some of you haven't just left the island to live in a more wintery environment."

"Some have." He sighs. "We call them Kel'rog, the orphans. They leave with no memory of the San'ta and Ke'bla and make a life of their own. Oddly enough, many have collected in urban environments, and have

made a good business of mass producing breakfast treats. It goes to show that baking is in our blood."

"I understand that by leaving, you'll forget everything on this island and Winterland."

He shakes his head no. "We stopped clouding minds a hundred and fifty years ago. It's held in reserve for only those who choose to forget, or have committed the most heinous crimes."

"Murderers." Mirae says.

"Worse.... Asking too many questions. Each one weakens our defenses, and endangers both the Goh Tchu and the Ke'bla."

"The Goh Tchu do not have to watch their speaking."

"They have different obligations to their totem spirits."

Annette says, "Owl."

Rurodin nods. "They must control the Rat Fiend population, and occasionally leave ordinary rats out for Owl's consumption. There are other spirits too, but Owl is the one we know most about since the rats often like to eat our treats, and the fiends occasionally try to kidnap our citizens. It is an indirect benefit of Owl's blessing. Our mixed children sometimes receive direct blessings from the Goh Tchu spirits."

Blink. I'm trying to imagine a child of mixed Goh Tchu and Ke'bla heritage. How are they even compatible? "You have children with the Goh Tchu."

Tako wears an expression caught between disgust and amusement. "Things just got furry, and painful. Assuming the moms aren't all Goh Tchu women."

Rurodin looks puzzled, and then roars with laughter. "Pwa ha ha! You don't know very much about the Goh Tchu then. They can transform into panda bears, and human women! Oh! By Frost. I can't believe it, you must have had such an impression."

Lilly exchanges a look with Tako and glances at Annette, "We never saw any pandas, or humans walkin' around."

He chuckles. "The Goh Tchu simply prefer their hybridized form. They say it takes too much effort to switch back and forth, and it's harder to chew their bamboo."

Now I'm smirking. "Imagine a were creature that's too lazy to change forms."

Rurodin's face grows serious. "They're good people, and not weres. We know of weres. We've seen were bears, wolves, and snow rats. That is not them."

"I understand." I point to Annette with my eyes. "She and I more than most. We have experience with the kinds of creatures you describe. They aren't what Havenfolk think of them."

"Anyway, about the kitchen." He leads us to a door set in a red wall that would ordinarily represent the seat of the sleigh if viewing it from the side. Inside is a full kitchen with magical stove tops, a steel counter on an island, and a wall full of ovens. "There's magic in the scent of baking, and I have a feeling you might need it." A woman with a cleaning rag dips into the room behind us and begins wiping down the counters. "It's not enough just to bring Great Uncle Winter cookies. You have to entice him to eat them."

"I'd like to know why he wouldn't want to. They look delicious."

Rurodin shrugs. "It's just a safety precaution. With the right magic, the scent of this kitchen will reach from port all the way to Great Uncle Winter's nostrils."

Frobod looks around, then leans against the wall. "This is all really great stuff, but I feel kinda useless. Elves are preparing the boat, and the bakers are making the cookies. Doubt I'd be much help there if I

wanted. It'd be good to know if there's anything we should be doing before we go."

Rurodin thinks on that a moment, then says. "Enjoy Elenandrial. Get some rest before the journey so you're not too tired."

* * * * *

After waiting a while for rooms aboard Sea Sleigh to be cleaned, we were escorted to a cozy dormitory full of bunk beds. There was enough to sleep about twelve people, but we didn't need so much space. We slept.

We're now all awake looking at a collection of some one hundred elves gathered on deck with cookie crates stacked as along the entire length of the Sea Sleigh's deck, and I'm sure many more below. Helsidol stands with her husband as he addresses the gathered elves. The sun rises over the horizon and our boat's bobbing in the water.

"Tonight we return home, not to Elenandrial, but to Winterland, our true home. I regret to say that circumstances this year are not much brighter than when we left, but we have the power to make a difference. Great Uncle Winter has gone bad once again, but these cookies have the power to bring him back. We

will face him, and restore him to the light! I thank you all for your dedicated efforts."

A resounding cheer sounds.

"Some of us have friends and cousins we haven't seen in centuries. Some of us just miss the weather." Scattered laughter. "I for one have a new grandson I've yet to hold." The crowd erupts in a cheer, just as loud as the first. Elven children are really big news. "A few weeks at sea is a small price to pay to see my daughter and grandson." Scattered murmurs of agreement.

I clear my throat. "Actually... I don't mean to contradict you Lord Rurodin." I decide to use the honorific since this is a public address. "... but you'll see your grandson far sooner than that."

His brow furrows, not in anger but confusion. "It would be good to know how this is possible. I know how long it took for us to arrive here."

"Ahh... Right... I might have left out a few details." I can feel my face flushing. "We have a pact with Winter, who has offered to aid us in our quest to redeem Great Uncle Winter. Part of that help is swift transportation."

"Lady Frost." A note of wonder settles in his voice, and a startled rumor sweeps through the gathered elves. "I don't know what to say."

I give him a forced smile to hide the awkwardness. "Surprise." In retrospect, I probably should have said something about the involvement of their local deity... guardian spirit... whatever she is to the San'ta. "If we're ready to go, Annette will help us call her."

More startled wisps of conversation.

"She can't be serious."

"It would be nice to know the meaning of this."

"I wonder if it's true."

"We'll get to meet Lady Frost."

Rurodin swallows and licks his lips. "We're ready.

"

I wave my hand. "Make room."

The elves jump back as if I'd hit them with a spell. Annette kneels beside me, and holds her hands above her head like I taught her with her eyes closed. A biting wind stirs, the spirit fades into view, impossibly huge, like a monument; insubstantial. "Child of Rat."

More than half the elves, including Helsidol and Rurodin extend their index fingers and draw the snowflake asterisk symbol, Rei's mother made. A few drop to their knees and stare at the ship's deck.

Oh my.

Annette takes a deep breath. "We're ready to go back to Winterland. We have everything we need to restore the balance, but no means to arrive there quickly."

"It is so. I honor our agreement. Restore the balance, and I will guide you, from then until you wish it no more." Shocked sounds from everyone, reflecting astonishment at Winter's trust in a human. The spirit points an accusing finger at one of the Ke'bla that actually spoke those words. "Stand."

His face grows pale, and his bottom lip trembles. "Goh Tchu are not human. They are kin. Rodekin are not human. They are kin. You will honor them, and the gifts they bring, for they are of the Earth Mother." Winter touches Annette with her palm, like a woman scratching the head of a cat. She's surrounded in a glimmering aura of Winter's frosty blue essence.

The Rodekin groans, as her features distort, and her face grows hairy. "Ugh!" A rat tail pushes out of the seat of her pants, as she becomes heads taller, and human hands are replaced with wicked clawed paws with opposable thumbs. Her expression is painful to watch as her flesh stretches to accommodate a larger, furrier, inhuman skeleton. "She's pushing me into war form! I can't control it!"

"When the balance is restored. She is chosen." Winter extends her index finger to the elf who complained about human, and hits him full in the face with an icy blue blast. He falls unconscious to the deck. "They must know you for what you are, as you are the first of many. Our chosen will not be hunted."

Annette lowers her eyes and bows her head, or at least I think she does. It's hard to tell when they're solid black. I get the feeling that she's been washed up in something way bigger than she ever imagined.

Although the sun's coming up, the world darkens as if it decided to go back down again. The shoreline becomes shadowy and indistinct, while a path of ice reaches out far over the water beyond the eye can see.

Winter rises off the deck floating and gliding as she does without any legs, showering snow flakes beneath her. She examines Sea Sleigh while caressing her chin with her thumb and forefinger. "Does this conveyance not move of it's own accord?"

Rurodin has a false start before using his voice, not daring to call the spirit on her lack of manners. "Lady Frost... It's made for water, or snow, or air with the proper beasts."

I nod, feeling more comfortable dealing with the spirit than one who worships her. Unlike the elves, I know that they can be weak, or powerful, fickle, generous, and human in their emotions if not their understanding. "We used a similar transport to carry us from near where we first met you, to Winterland."

She floats back down to deck. "You, prism souled, lend me your mind."

What did she just call me?

I look to either side of me to see if she's addressing someone else in the party, but alas she's not. I point at my chest as if to say, 'Who me?'

"Melpomine of the yellow hair and short ears. I sense the Rodekin and Arachnekin, and yet for now, you are not kin. You change faces and being, as colors split through a prism. Lend me your mind."

I guess that answers that question.

"Okay..." I hesitate not sure where she's going with this. She presses a frigid finger to my forehead, causing my brain to lock up like I've chugged a two liter slushy. I clutch my forehead, not realizing she's finished.

Frobod grabs my arm. "Mel?"

I whimper. "Brain freeze."

"Thank you." Lady Frost drifts to the front of the boat, and raises her arms causing winds to stir up. For over a minute, blizzard snow swarms the moonwalk that's so thick it's impossible to see through. The newly fallen snow rolls and collects into a mound of it's own accord. It's now taking shape... a wolfish head, a sleek body, big ears and a bushy tail of animated snow.

Not a wolf.

The snow creature wags its tail, and chatter-yips in a way that reminds me of Bosko. Those direfoxes were big, but this thing's the size of an office building.

"This should serve for your transport."

I don't know how, as I don't see any harness, but when the big fox steps forward, it drags Sea Sleigh behind. There's a jolt as everyone lurches to keep their balance as we're hoisted out of the water, and onto the slick moon walk.

"Go, Child of Rat, and restore the balance."

Winter fades like a ghost, and once we're on the moonwalk the snow fox sits, waiting for instruction. *I think I know what to do.* I look to Mirae remembering how she reacted to the dire foxes. "It'd be good to know if you'd like to do the honors."

She smiles, and skips to where Winter stood at the bow of the ship.

"Mush!" We lurch forward. "Hike! Hike!"

Acceleration Gs kick in, and the world around us blurs.



Chapter 19 - Bad Santa

The end of the moonwalk's up ahead, a luminous pillar of light.

We glide to a rest on the bank of the lake with colorful magic fish, and the San'ta skate. The air is brisk, light, and refreshing. The sun was rising when we left Taiwan, but in Arctica it's about to set. I would have liked to have caught another glimpse of the snow fox, but it vanished as soon as the Sleigh left the spirit world.

The Ke'bla give Annette a wide berth, some bowing low to show their sincerest respect. The rest are quickly cracking open crate after crate of winter cookies, scrambling to arrange them in a sugar rush, top deck, buffet.

"It's time to find Great Uncle Winter." I open the door to the kitchen, and am unsurprised to see Rurodin making good progress on his baking. He even has a few helpers, Helsidol, and a man I don't know. "It'd be helpful to know how to find Great Uncle Winter."

Tiasol's dad wipes his hands on his apron, and hands his wife the mixing spoon. "I'll show you." We follow him on to the deck, where he points to the top of a high hill overlooking Winterland. "That's where he lives and spends most of his time. You'll see a cottage, and a special workshop. If he's in Winterland, that's where he'll be."

"Okay. It looks like our job is to go up there, and convince him to follow us down here."

A pretty round faced Elf woman with blonde hair down to her butt hands us each a box of cookies. "Take these. Maybe you can give him a taste and he'll follow."

"Good idea." We each take a box and stash them in our inventories. I wave my finger at Great Uncle Winter's hill and shout, "INFERNO!" When Big Red makes it's roaring entrance, I pump my fist, and say, "Let's ride." I buff up before mounting.

Woouoooooosh. Thump-Bump. Thump-Bump. I spin Bite around me, and embrace my inner Yin to cast

my Flow Like Water defense. The chill of the spell seeps into my bones.

Now we're on our elechoppers, me on fire, Mirae and Annette on earth, Tako on wind, Lilly on water and Frobod on ether. I switch to party chat. "The plan's just to go there, knock on the door, agro and kite back to the Sleigh, unless any of you have something better."

Frobod says, "Sounds like good a plan as any. This is a new boss."

"Really?"

Mirae says, "There's never been an evil Santa."

Tako says, "We can wing it. I'm not too worried about a holiday boss."

"Before we go... Re'amus gri atu protectus." Mirae hands me one of her soap figurines.

"Same as last time?"

"That's the only useful one I can do. "

"I appreciate it. Okay everyone, move out!"

I have a different feeling than you'd expect gearing up for a boss. We're flying over the lake, looking down on Winterland and its holiday lights. Skaters twirl on the ice. I see windows of cafes where I know joyous elves are drinking hot cider and cocoa.

There's none of the adrenaline I'm usually pumped with after wading through a dungeon full of

monsters, and happening across the big bad in the final room. The experience is... How can I explain it?

This quest has pulled on my emotions in ways that most others haven't, running me through holiday joy, and family tragedy. I've witnessed heartfelt reunions, and the unfettered joy of becoming a grandfather. To put it in other words, these people, NPCs, blocks of code on Freehaven servers, feel real in a way that makes them worth fighting for. Not to win, but to protect.

Before Archangel? We fail, oh well. The village dies. Wait for everything to respawn. Now? I hate to lose a single one of them. Is that the point? What's the end game here? Not of the Winter Dungeonland quest, but Freehaven Online.

I can see Great Uncle Winter's Cottage. A demon patrols. Dark, horned, red eyed and bat winged. CRACK! It whips the back of a helpless elf. He moans and falls with hands and knees in the snow. The monster kicks the pitiful man toward a building that I assume must be the workshop.

Do the people in town not know what's happening here?

"What do you want to do, kill the demon, or go straight for the house."

Frobod frowns. "Demon."

"Alright. Let's go."

We drop down to the snow and dismount. Our opponent hasn't seen us. I don't give him a chance.

Shadow Step (Rank 5) - Success!

I whirl Bite, and crack him behind the knees. Unfortunately his legs don't buckle. He turns with an ugly laugh. I get my back to the workshop wall. "Puny mortal." He's got a gnarled face full of tusks and fangs.

"Bite me."

Taunt. Successful.

San'ta Clawfiend attacks.

I duck out of the way of his meaty clawed fist, which crashes into the wall.

Tako and Lilly appear behind him and deliver simultaneous strikes. Tako's dagger goes in with a wet 'shick,' but Lilly's comes packed with an explosion that sends bits of demonic gore flying into the snow.

Now, no longer confident, the monster roars and pummels me with a trio of lightning fast punches. *He moves like a werewolf.*

WHAM!

The first splashes right through my Flow Like Water defense. My flesh warps around the fist so fast that I'm not aware it's happening until it's already done. *Six resistance levels gone. Damn!* This thing hits like a cement truck.

WHAM! The second blow lands, obliterating the last of flow like water. My flesh begins to reshape, but then gives way to regular damage.

**San'ta Clawfiend hits you for 3 points of damage.
You resist 3 damage.**

WHAM!

**San'ta Clawfiend hits you for 9 points of damage.
You resist 8 damage.**

An arrow sticks me in the breast, it pinches a moment, I smell cherry blossoms, and it no longer hurts. My health creeps back to full.

Okay, not like a truck.

I'm just not used to getting hit on the first attack. Frobod's running up the hill with his greatsword.

Tako and Lilly both manage extra stabs.
Clawfiend health: 70%

The monster takes another swipe at me, this time using claws. I dip out of the way, and counterattack with Bite sending a mild jolt of electricity through its body. There's no arcs of lightning this time, because there are no other hostile targets for it to jump to.

Now Frobod's on him. The demon's attention is still on me, so he takes a chance with a two handed thrust with his sword. The monster jerks in response, and staggers to the side. I hit him under the chin with my weapon delivering an electric zap.

Clawfiend health: 40%.

It reaches for a pouch I hadn't noticed on its belt, and withdraws a potion which he chugs in a single gulp.

Clawfiend health: 50%

Clawfiend health: 60%

Clawfiend health: 70%

"Regeneration potion!"

Lilly sticks him with another dagger that causes unhealthy dark veins to worm around under his skin.
"Ain't demons supposed to regenerate on their own?"

"How should I know? I've never fought one in Haven!"

Whatever this guy's deal is, the potion's helping him recover health super fast. He's almost up to one hundred, before it stops rising and begins trickling down again.

Lilly gives him another poke, causing more black lines to crawl through his body like an ugly road map.

"What is that?"

The clawfiend raises his hand and swipes, before it gets anywhere near me I slap his forearm with Bite, zapping him. He unleashes a raw bellow. "Ughh!"

"Recovery block! Don't leave home without it!"

"Good work!"

One of Mirae's green magic arrows, lands in his chest, causing more grunts of protest and dropping our opponent's health a little more. Frobod chop's with his sword. Lilly shrieks, "Stop!"

Clawfiend health: 10%.

"Hold DPS!"

I dip out of the way of another attack. When he's not using his super-speed trio punch, this guy is slow as hell. I wonder if that ability comes at the cost of exhaustion and slowed attacks.

Lilly throws her dust in the air. It settles in the circle and twelve pointed star formation.

The swirly stream of violet magic energy connects their foreheads. Tako, Frobod and I vacate the circle to let her do her thing. I glance at Annette, the only NPC to make sure she's not about to hit it, thankfully her bow's not drawn and there's no sign of her loosing an arrow.

Lilly's circle fades, and the monster kneels. "I... will serve."

She cuts a rip in the air with her dagger and points. "Then get the hell outta here!"

"As you command." The clawfiend stands tiredly, and exits through the opening, stepping up and into it like he's going up on a ledge. The rip disappears.

The goblin dances, waving her arms, and shuffling her feet. "About fricking' time. Who's still got it? That's right, it's me."

I extend a hand to the cowering beaten elf. I hadn't noticed before, his feet are shackled. "We're taking you home." He doesn't initially speak, but I can sense his gratitude in the way he gulps and nods. "Is this the workshop?"

"Y-Y-Yes."

"Alright. Stay here. We're gonna get everyone we find back home." He nods, trembling. I look to Frobod. "On the count of three we're gonna bust through the

door. One..." I look around to make sure everyone's ready. "Two... Three."

I twist the handle to make sure it's not locked, and then throw the door wide open so it cracks against the wall. CRASH. The whole door rattles in its hinges.

A workshop, filled with San'ta elves shackled to their work stations greets me. They flinch at my arrival, and I inwardly grimace. *In retrospect, that might not have been the most compassionate entrance.*

At the far end of the room an obese man in a jolly red suit gnaws on a juicy fat turkey leg. Unfortunately, good humor neglects to extend past his wardrobe because it fails to reach his eyes. Timid elves affix a swirling green glow in the dark contraption to his chest that looks like an upside down plate.

His eyes lock on mine, and his hand moves to put the leg down, until he pauses, moves it back to his face for another bite, and discards it with a casual toss on a table near the throne.

"Oh! Ho ho ho!" I've never heard that laugh sound so evil. "Visitors! Have you come to work in my workshop?"

"No." My voice is flat. "We've brought cookies." In party chat I command, "Cookies. Out. Now."

He smiles with white teeth, but it doesn't touch his eyes. With one hand, he picks up one of the elves that are working on the magical gadget on his chest. and throws her to the floor. She hits it with a fleshy slap, but I think she's okay.

"Did you now? They look delicious."

"They are." I'm trying to decide what to do. I could walk over and hand them over, but if I do, I'm in range of whatever he has for attacks, and by the look of this place there could be a lot of collateral damage. "Why don't you come get them?"

He kicks the woman on the ground, she hadn't yet risen, and motions to me. She stands quickly. Cowed, staring at her feet. I hand her the box when she approaches and whisper, "It'll be okay." Each of the other party members gives her their cookies, which she brings to Great Uncle Winter. He sets them on a table beside his turkey.

I sigh. "So much for that idea."

Tako grumbles. "Just get on with it."

His hand flashes, and a throwing knife darts for Great Uncle Winter's face. The fat man's deceptively fast when he jerks his head to the side, resulting in a bloody gash to the cheek as opposed to a flying lobotomy.

The fat man roars, "You dare! No toys for you!"

Tako sprints out the door.

"Time to kite! Incoming! Clothies go!" Lilly, Mirae and Annette run out followed by me and Frobod. "Keep going!"

The others are running, but I'm moving at a casual jog, to be sure I'm the one Great Uncle Winter comes for. He bursts out of the workshop howling, "I'll turn your hearts to coal and hang them in your stalkings!"

"Not if you can't catch us jiggle butt... fuzzy.. lumpkins!!"

Taunt. Successful.

Great Uncle Winter Attacks

Awkward verbal taunt for the win.

A piece of something flies at me. I side step aside just in time to see a half eaten turkey leg crash into the snow. *I guess he went back for one last bite.*

"Now to play with my new toys. HO! HO! HO!"

He presses his palm to the green contraption stuck on his red suit like a big button. For all I know that's exactly what it is. Great uncle winter's gloved

hands and feet expand like balloons, and then the rest of him starts growing, bigger and bigger until he can step up and stand on his own house.

"Santa's got enlargement! Incoming."

"Ho! Ho! Ho! Now it's my turn."

He rushes at me, kicking up enough snow to cause an avalanche. Fortunately the hill's not too steep, and I'm running.

Slippery Slope - Balance. Success

Dexterity + Athletics

Caliber of Success: 12

My feet slide in the snow, but by the grace of my freakishly high dex, I'm able to maintain my footing, and slide down the slope like I'm on really crappy skis. As soon as the slip and slide stops, I continue booking it luring the boss toward the lake and the town. I'm almost at the Winterland gate. A snowman tips his top hat and says "Happy Winterfest!"

Great Uncle Winter crushes him beneath his imposing black boot.

"Run! Sorry in advance for the property damage!"

San'ta elves scream, and scurry away from the market street as Great Uncle Winter plows over the welcome sign. Fortunately he only has eyes for me since I'm the one that taunted. A few San'ta don't have the sense to move as fast as their fellows. So I scream. "Go! Go! Go!"

An elf in a warm red coat and green scarf gets knocked to his stomach by a black boot, but he's thankfully quick enough to roll out of the way.

Mirae hit's Great Uncle Winter in the thigh with a green magic arrow. He doesn't notice. The man's an unstoppable wall of festive red suit and flesh.

"Keep going!" She's lingering up ahead on her Elechopper. Hovering and loosing arrows. Annette's not with her, instead, she seems to be riding with Frobo and loosing arrows of her own.

Lilly waves her daggers, and sends a blast of fire. It crashes into his armpit leaving black scorch marks, but no damage.

Great Uncle Winter Health: 100%.

I'm still running. It's a lot easier on well maintained roads. "This isn't a fight to the death keep going!" I'm trying to remember the way to the lake. Just before the residential district turn left... or was it right? I look at the sign.

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"HO HO HO!" a boot's coming down. I dive to evade, just in time to come up under the other foot.

Great Uncle Winter hits you for 27 damage.

You resist, 19 points of damage.

My health bar plummets to 20%.

"HO! HO! HO! Do you like my new toys. You're caught beneath my missile toes!"

"Missile what?"

The end of a boot that just stomped me flips open, revealing a five missile ballista which immediately launches. The projectiles swirl with unholy black and red magic. The one on end curves straight up, and rockets down at me. I try to get out of the way.

"Heat seeking ballist-" That's all I can get out because it slams right through my chest.

Great Uncle Winter's Missile Toe hits you for 17 damage.

You resist 14 points of damage.

I'm waiting for the "You have died." Prompt and to find myself standing at my corpse, when a notification fills my vision.

Would you like to use Effigy of Protection to prevent your death?

Yes / No

There's a count down 10... 9.... 8... 7... YES!

I open my eyes. I've dropped all agro. Lilly and Tako are down for the count, but the foot balisstras seem to have missed Mirae and Frobod. Our dead party members are still using party chat.

"What the shit was that?"

Lilly's dead, but she has a bit of humor in her voice. "Didn't ya hear Missile Toes!"

I groan, "Gotta love a boss with a sense of humor."

A grey comet streaks overhead, and a white fletched arrow knocks me in the chest. "Owe!" the pain disappears, as my health rises. Another one sticks in me and another. "Owe! Owe!" It's not like getting hit by something that's trying to kill you. It's more like getting pinched real hard.

My health is recovering. I'm now at 60... 70%.

"Annette! You're heals are like flying titty twisters! Watch your aim!"

I reach to yank one of the projectiles from my flesh, but it's already gone. I hadn't noticed before, but the healing arrows seem to disappear once they've worked their magic.

I'm now up to 80% health and ready to jump back in the fight.

I look around, Frantically trying to spot Great Uncle Winter. I wave my middle finger. "INFERNO!!!" He's already down by Frosty's.

"Frobod, Annette, thanks for heals. Mirae! What's the boss doing?"

"Chasing me."

"Are you okay?"

"I'm fine. He's got laser eyes by the way, but he hasn't hit me. I'm high above him."

"Everyone whose still alive, close on Sea Sleigh!" I hit the gas, and rocket across the lake with a tongue of fire creating steam and blowing out my exhaust. I swoop in for an intentional near miss. "I'm not dead yet! I understand the confusion, the eyes are the first to go when you get old."

Taunt. Successful.

Great Uncle Winter Attacks.

A gloved hand that's as big as my entire ride comes at me. I dive just in the nick of time.

Drive skill increased by 1. Current level: 5

Specialization Unlocked: Aerial Motor Vehicles

This specialization only works with magical cars, trucks, and motorcycles, and cannot be applied to vehicles that utilize the pilot skill.

Frobod says, "Nice dodge."

"Thanks, I just got a new specialization for it."

Great Uncle Winter's looking around trying to figure out where I went, when a whiff of heaven tickles my senses. My mind knows it's cinnamon, but it conjures memories of every good thing I've ever smelled in a bake store. *Bakery magic!*

For a moment, the boss is dazed too, as he begins to sniff, looking more and more like an animal. "Ho! Ho! Ho! Doesn't that smell inviting?"

I'm imagining all the Ke'bla aboard the Sea Sleigh clutching their ears in horror.

Bad Santa spots me, but only makes a half hearted effort to swat me out of the way. It's easy to dodge. At the same time, he begins to deflate, growing smaller.

"Looks like the batteries in his enlargement toy ran out."

He's almost at the Sleigh.

An Elf Man, perhaps hoping the boss has already been redeemed says "Great Uncle Winter. It's so good to..."

Bad Santa backhands him across the face, sending the elf a good eight feet before he hits the earth.
Mental note: Great Uncle Winter is crazy strong.

"I smell cookies. Where are they? Let me have some."

Helsidol peeks over the edge of the Sea Sleigh's top deck. Santa roars, "Wench! Bring me those cookies or I'll make some from the crushed bones of your pointy eared spawn!"

I call, "Stay there Helsidol! I'll bring the cookies."

I hit the gas, and launch toward the Sea Sleigh with Frobod and Mirae in tow. Up top, the make shift

cookie buffet is even more ornate than we left it. It's a shame Great Uncle Winter can't get to it. I grab an end plate display, and attempt to ride one handed. Holding it up like a waiter.

Creative Balance

Dexterity + Athletics

Caliber of Success: 9

Distracted Driving

Dexterity + Drive (-1 Difficulty, Aerial Motor Vehicles Specialization)

Caliber of Success: 3

I've got a firm hold on my plate, no need to worry about cookies falling into the snow. Mirae's not so lucky as she attempts to mimic me and drops her entire plate. I have to drop down slow and cautiously on my bike however due to the low caliber of success on my drive roll.

"I've got your cookies."

Great Uncle Winter rips off his black gloves revealing gnarled claws in place of finger nails. I mentally groan. *Santa Claws.*

I force calm into my voice, like the first time I spoke to Cerberus, "I'm not going to attack you if you don't attack me."

"Just bring em here wench. Uncle's hungry."

I sigh, and approach. His greedy little fingers pluck cookie after cookie off the plate, with one hand, while he stuffs them in his mouth with the other. There are now crumbs in his beard, and the plate's empty. His eyes grow dangerous, and I'm pretty sure he's about to hit me.

To my surprise, he doesn't.

"I WANT MORE!"

"You heard the man! Bring more cookies! Make it a train! You pass the plates down, and I'll bring them over. Frodo, Annette, Mirae help me."

Mirae shakes her head. "I think you can handle this yourself. I'm going to go see my boyfriend."

Lilly explodes in party chat, "What about me?"

I also respond in pc. "I'll get you in a minute after we know the boss is safe."

A hand touches my shoulder from behind. I'm pretty sure it's the baker with the macaroons. I smile at her. "Your macaroons are gonna kick evil's ass." She returns the smile. I take the plate, and offer it to Great Uncle Winter.

He gobbles them up in all of two seconds.

"More! More!"

Is it me, or are those claws getting shorter?

Frobod drops to the ground and hops off his bike.

"I'll take it. Go get Lilly."

"Lilly, I'm coming. Where did you die?"



Chapter 20 - Rewards

With Lilly back amongst the living without a res penalty thanks to a player resurrection, our first item of business is to free the shell shocked slaves in the special workshop. We stop in town, pick up some clothes, and return to the little house of Christmas horror, to care for them. A few of them wear expressions that make me think they'll never be able to celebrate Winterfest again. I don't know what to say to them. I don't know how to help them.

Great Uncle Winter on the other hand is being treated to a dusk until mid morning all you can eat Ke'bla cookie buffet.

I page through my quest log looking for the turn in. "Let's take care of Winter first."

Tako shrugs. "Fine with me."

We head to a quiet corner of the frozen lake, where Annette, now in human form, raises her hands, and focuses on calling winter. Lady Frost appears in less than a second. "Well done Child of Rat." She eyes me contemplatively. "And you Prism Souled." She redirects her attention. "Annette, Rodekin, Child of Rat, I accept you as my chosen. I will guide you and teach you, from now until you wish it no more."

I whisper to Annette, "You have to accept the bond. Tell her you accept, and promise to pay tribute and honor her."

Annette nods. "Lady Frost, Winter, I accept your guidance. I will remember you while you sleep, and honor you while you are awake, from now and until you wish it no more."

Winter frowns. "You are young. How will you pay tribute?"

"I..."

"Remember my touch. When I slumber you must consume ice before you sleep so that I may guide you in your dreams. When I am awake, the moon is dark, and the night is coldest you must leave me a sacrifice by freezing it in water before you rest."

Annette nods. "I will do it."

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"It is done. Go now, and embrace my teachings. Child of Rat, Daughter of Winter."

Quest Complete: Taming the Rage Babies

You've encountered Winter, a powerful nature spirit, and have gained her favor. Teach Annette to gain repute so that she may become one of her spirit guides.

Completion:

Spirit Bond Formed 1/1

Report to Lord Zarentu at Dragonswood Keep to claim your reward.

"Now for the big one." Frobod's voice oozes with anticipation.

I check my quest log.

Winter Dungeonland - Part 2

Difficulty: Hard

Alvawynn has revealed to you the secret history of the Ke'bla elves. Find them, retrieve a recipe to restore great uncle winter, or convince them to bake the greatest cookies in all the land, and bring them back to Winterland.

Objectives:

Retrieve Recipe or Cookies	1/1
Return to Winterland	1/1
Redeem Great Uncle Winter	0/1

Chain Completion Rewards (Choose One):

- A unique evolving weapon (Legendary Potential)
- A unique evolving chest piece (Legendary Potential)
- A unique evolving helm (Legendary Potential)
- A unique evolving spell (Legendary Potential)
- Logout re-enabled

Additional Rewards (Limited Edition) (Choose One):

- **Unlock Rebirthing as Ke'bla Elf**
- **Unlock Rebirthing as San'ta Elf**
- **Unlock Rebirthing as Kel'rog Elf**

"It looks like Great Uncle Winter hasn't been redeemed yet."

Frobod says, "Maybe we have to talk to him."

Lilly nods. "Probably. Quests can be annoying like that."

We return to the top deck of the Sea Sleigh to find Great Uncle Winter, rosy cheeked, and happy. He pops a cookie in his mouth with fingers that look all too human. Gone are the weapons that might have given him the nick name Santa Claws. "Oh! Ho! Ho! Ho! Happy Winterfest!" His voice is bright, and warm enough to heat even the coldest of frozen hearts.

"You seem to be feeling better."

"Oh! Ho ho! I am, and these lovely people tell me that I have you to thank for it." He puts down the cookie plate and takes my hands in his, "Thank you from the bottom of my heart. You've saved Winterfest."

He goes to each person in the party and repeats the gesture. "If only there was some way to thank you.

Ah! But there is. Go to the workshop near my home and enter the back room." He fishes a golden key on a chain from around his neck. "There, you may take anything you like. My darker half had an interest in terrible, warlike things. This is not the way of the San'ta, and it is not the way of Great Uncle Winter. You'd be doing me a kindness by removing these creations from Winterland."

Quest Complete: Winter Dungeonland - Part 2

Visit Great Uncle Winter's storeroom to claim your reward.

Frobod chokes up, and pinches his eyes shut, clinching his copy of the key. "We're going home. I'll get to see my family. This can't be real"

I offer a wan smile. "Let's go to the workshop and find out if it is."

* * * * *

The shackles that held San'ta prisoners despawned during our visit to the Sea Sleigh, as has the red throne Evil Santa lounged in. The rest of the workshop looks about how you'd expect. Partially completed toys and contraptions litter a large workstations that stretches the length of the room, and

hammers, pliers, mallets, and screw drivers hang from pegs on the walls. In place of bad Santa's seat, stands a heavy door I hadn't noticed. It seems just right for golden keys.

Frobod's all but dancing in anticipation, so I step aside. "Why don't you do the honors.

"Thank you! Here goes nothing." He eases his key into the lock and twists. CLICK.

He pauses a moment, staring into nothing.

Lilly says, "Hey! What is it? What's inside."

Seconds pass with no response, and then Frobod turns with a golden phoenix medallion in his hand with eyes of red ruby. "It's real."

Lilly says, "What, did you use it?"

Frobod shakes his head. "No, not yet. It just says Use: Log Out re-enabled."

"Well whatta ya waitin' for? The suspense is killin' me!"

"Okay..." He breathes heavily, there are tears in his eyes. "I'm just expecting this thing to disappear somehow, so I want to hold on to it."

"All the more reason to hurry up with it."

"Okay."

The phoenix's eyes flash with a brief, but intense fire, before the whole thing crumbles into ash in his palms.

"Shit! I hope I didn't Jinx it. Frobod? Ya still here!"

He nods silently.

"Whaaat?"

"Are you okay?"

Mirae asks, "What's going on."

"It worked. The button's clickable again. I think it'll work. Mel! I think it'll work!"

"I'm Justine, remember?"

"Right. Real names, because sometime that's where I'm going to see you."

"Awe. Ya big lug. Give me a hug." He puts his plated arms around me, and it feels... nice. "You can DJ my waking up party."

"Hey! What gives?"

That's Lilly. Frobod looks over. She's standing in the door. "Sorry about the PDA."

"Huh? Forget that, I want my reward!"

Frobod, looking baffled, says "What do you mean? You step through, you get a prompt, and you choose what you want. You didn't get it?"

"I got it alright, but it says logout's unavailable!"

"Try closing the door and using your key. I opened the door that time so maybe it's remembering my choice."

"Good thinkin'." She sticks the key in the door, twists, and throws it open. "What the fuck dude? I still can't pick it! I got people to see too!"

Frobod looks like he's staring down a semi truck that's about to hit him. "I... I don't know what to say."

"Lilly, step away from the door. Let me try. I want to see the message."

"Go for it."

I step up to the door.

Quest Chain Completed: Winter Dungeonland

Choose your rewards:

- A unique evolving weapon (Legendary Potential)
- A unique evolving chest piece (Legendary Potential)
- A unique evolving helm (Legendary Potential)
- A unique evolving spell (Legendary Potential)
- *Logout re-enabled (unavailable)(?)*

Additional Rewards (Limited Edition) (Choose One):

- **Unlock Rebirthing as Ke'bla Elf**
- **Unlock Rebirthing as San'ta Elf**
- **Unlock Rebirthing as Kel'rog Elf**

I choose the question mark, to pull up additional information.

A player in your party has already claimed this reward.

I step away from the door. "Frobod drop party. Gonna try this again."

Frobod has left the group.

I step through the door.

Quest Chain Completed: Winter Dungeonland

Choose your rewards:

- A unique evolving weapon (Legendary Potential)
- A unique evolving chest piece (Legendary Potential)
- A unique evolving helm (Legendary Potential)
- A unique evolving spell (Legendary Potential)
- *Logout re-enabled (unavailable)(?)*

Additional Rewards (Limited Edition) (Choose One):

- Unlock Rebirthing as Ke'bla Elf
- Unlock Rebirthing as San'ta Elf
- Unlock Rebirthing as Kel'rog Elf

I choose the question mark.

This reward has already been claimed by another player.

"Fuck... Guys?" I send Frobo another invite.

Frobo has joined your group.

There's an edge in Lilly's voice that wasn't there before. "What is it?"

I sigh. "Each reward can only be chosen one time."

I don't know what to feel. Shocked? Lied to? This whole quest turned out to be a lie for four out of every five participants. What I don't feel is the soul crushing despair Frodo'd have experienced if he hadn't gone first. With tears leaking from my eyes, I realize that's my Christmas miracle.

I close my eyes. Hard until I can get my emotions under control, and walk to the big guy I've kind of liked these past few months. I throw my arms around his armored self. "You're going to have to wait for me a little longer." and then in a barely audible voice, "I'm glad it was you."

I wipe a tear from my face with the back of my thumb. "I've got to alert the others," and pull out my VT to send out a guild notice.

**WARNING: EACH WINTER DUNGEONLAND
REWARD CAN BE SELECTED ONE TIME**

I pause a moment, and send another.

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**THAT MEANS EACH PERSON CAN CHOOSE
ONE SEPRATE THING. THERE'S ONE LOG OUT
PER GROUP.**

Staring at the door in numb shock, the rest of us
select our loot.



Epilogue - Home

"I guess now this is family."

Pehrom's prepared a delicious homecoming meal. Honey ham, I'm in heaven. We're cleaning off the last of our plates.

"That's total bullshit with the log out though."

Lilly sighs. "Look, I'm over it. I came back here knowin' I may never get out." She wraps her arms around her husband. "I got all the family I need right here."

"Still. I'm sorry you ain't gettin' to see your folks. What about you guys?"

"I'll survive. To be honest, even if only one of us was forced to stay in game, I'd have chosen my self. I'm

the guild captain. This is my brother's place, and as a dev, I can't help but feel somewhat responsible."

I leave out the part about the little voice inside that's no longer certain I want to leave.

Tako shrugs. "We're back where we started. I'll get out when they fix it."

"Besides." Lilly smiles. "I'm a happy girl, epic blades, and a helm that gives me a +5 bonus to taming, and halves negotiation time. Do you realize what this means? There's a 50% chance that people like you won't get the chance murder my new summons!"

I smile. "I'm glad your happy."

"Plus five, and it's still evolving! Do you realize what this could mean?"

"You'll pwn."

"I already pwn! ... but I'll pwn harder."

"Congratulations."

Frobod stands, from the table. "Hey guys... I'd love to stick around and keep talking but... I've got kids to see."

I nod. "I understand."

"I just want to say... Thanks. for everything. I don't know what I'd have done if I hadn't found you. I gotta say, someone was looking out for me when you

were running around looking for peeps to go hunt dragons."

"Are you going to come back?"

He hesitates. "I... I don't know. Mel, Justine, I want to see you, but I'm afraid. I've got too much out there to lose."

I nod, sadly, biting the inside of my lip to keep from crying. "You've got the contact information for Leroy's wife, right?"

He nods. "He made me recite it a hundred times, so I won't forget."

"You've got Mirae's parents?"

He nods. "Everything."

"Okay." The word is so final. "At least... Let me walk you to the door."

"Justine, you know I don't actually have to go to the door to leave."

"Humor me."

We pass into the hall outside the dining room and into the antechamber, speaking nothing, and feeling everything. I stop in front of the great front doors and look above me.

"Mistletoe."

"Really?"

I touch my finger to my lips. My heart's beating fast.

Frobod hesitates. "I -"

"Shut up and kiss me." I stand on my tip toes, and touch my lips to his.

He kisses back feverishly, in a way that makes my toes curl. I'm floaty. His big hands pull me close to his body. I don't want it to stop, but he's slowing down.

"Justine... I have to..."

"Just do it. I want to hold on to this until you go."

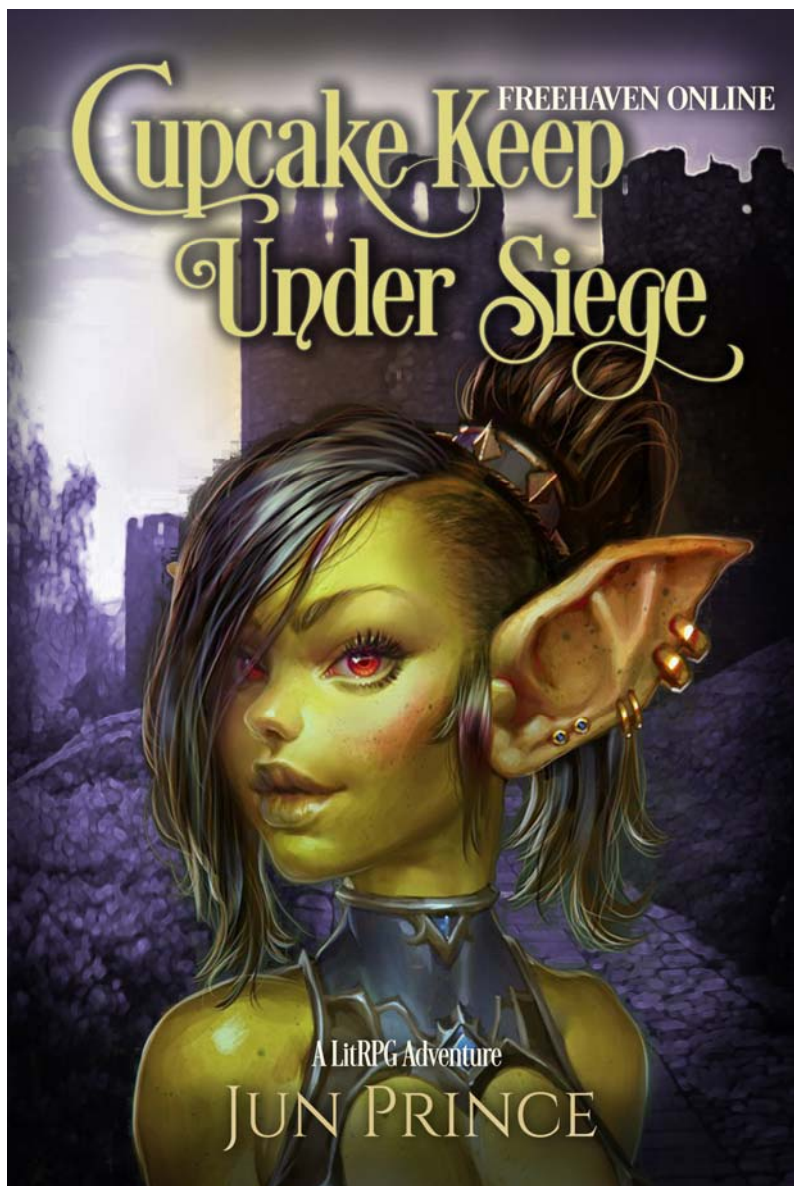
I can't see his reaction because my face is against his chest. He kisses the top of my head as we stand swaying. I enjoy his heat, his warmth. His dedication to the ones he loves. I like feeling his bulk within my arms. *What would it feel like in the real world?*

We rock together until I feel him no more, and I can mourn what might have been.

Frobod has gone offline.

The End

Coming Soon



Coming Soon

